

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

by

MRETYUN JAI B

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

**Written by
MRETYUN JAI B**

**"Every decision creates a future.
Some decisions create two."**

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Before You Begin...

This is not a story about perfect love.

It is not a story about heroes or villains.

It is a story about ordinary people...

ordinary conversations...

ordinary mistakes...

and one decision...

that quietly changed two lives forever.

**If you have ever looked back at your life
and wondered,**

"What if I had chosen differently?"

perhaps...

**you'll find a part of yourself somewhere in
these page**

About the Author & this Novel

Author – **Mretyun Jai B**

I never liked reading books, and I had never even finished one completely. Yet, I ended up writing a novel. It's funny, isn't it?

I wrote this book because I wanted others to experience my overthinking and the emotions I went through during some of the most important moments of my life.

This novel is inspired by both real and imagined events, so it is not entirely based on true incidents. It is a story about love, choices, distance, hope, and the emotions that come with them.

Whenever I overthink, I write. That's how this novel came to life.

Author's Note

Dear Reader,

Thank you for picking up this book.

I never imagined that one day I would write a novel. In fact, I wasn't someone who enjoyed reading books. Yet here I am, sharing a story that began with countless thoughts, emotions, and sleepless nights. **Can Love Survive?** is a work of fiction inspired by emotions, memories, and moments that many of us experience in different ways. While some parts are inspired by real feelings and events, much of the story has been imagined and shaped for the purpose of storytelling. The characters, conversations, and situations are not intended to represent any specific individual or real-life relationship. This story isn't about perfect love. It's about the choices we make, the distance we endure, the words we leave unsaid, and the hope we hold on to even when everything feels uncertain. Whenever my thoughts became too loud, I wrote. Page by page, those thoughts became this novel. If you've ever loved someone, missed someone, waited for someone, or questioned whether love can truly survive, I hope you find a part of yourself somewhere in these pages.

Thank you for joining me on the first step of this journey.

Happy reading.

— Mretyun Jai B

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Part I - Before Love13

Chapter One..... 13

Chapter Two23

Chapter Three28

Chapter Four.....36

Chapter Five..... 41

Chapter Six.....46

Part II - Becoming My Favourite Person53

Chapter Eight53

Chapter Nine59

Chapter Ten73

Chapter Eleven85

Chapter Twelve96

Part III — The One She Trusted Most105

Chapter Thirteen..... 105

Chapter Fourteen.....118

Chapter Fifteen 129

Chapter Sixteen..... 142

Chapter Seventeen 156

Part IV — Silent Love.....169

Chapter Eighteen..... 169

Chapter Nineteen 183

Chapter Twenty	196
Chapter Twenty-one	210
<i>Part V — The Silent Years</i>	223
Chapter Twenty-Two.....	223
Chapter Twenty-Three	233
Chapter Twenty-Four	246
Chapter Twenty-Five	249

Prologue

A short emotional scene from the future.

Someone is looking at an old photo,
wondering if love can survive everything life
throws at it.

Then...

"Let me tell you where it all began."

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PART I

Every story begins with a hello...

Part I - Before Love

Chapter One

The Boy Named Mithran

"I don't remember the day I was born. But I remember every person who made my childhood worth remembering."

Everything I know about that day comes from the stories my family has told me over the years.

Whenever my relatives gather for a family function, someone always brings it up.

"You know how everyone was waiting outside when you were born?"

Then another person continues the story.

"You were the first child in the family. Everyone was so happy."

I wasn't there to remember any of it.

But after hearing the same story so many times, it almost feels like I was.

I was born into a middle-class family.

We didn't have a luxurious life.

We weren't rich.

But one thing we never lacked was love.

For my parents, I wasn't just their son.

I was their first experience of becoming parents.

Every small thing I did became a celebration.

Twenty-eight days after I was born, my family held my naming ceremony.

I obviously don't remember that day either.

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But I've seen the photographs more times than I can count.

My mother holding me carefully.

My father standing proudly beside us.

My grandparents smiling at the camera.

And somewhere in the middle of all those people...

a tiny baby who had no idea everyone was discussing what his name should be.

After considering many names, my family finally chose one.

Mithran.

That name became my identity long before I even learned to say it.

Sometimes I wonder...

If they had chosen another name that day...

Would my life have been any different?

Probably not.

But that's one of those useless questions our minds ask when we grow older.

Looking through my old photo albums always makes me smile.

Every page is filled with pictures of a little boy laughing without any worries.

Back then, life was simple.

I cried when I was hungry.

I laughed when someone played with me.

And I slept without knowing what tomorrow looked like.

For my first birthday, my parents wanted everything to be special.

They ordered a cake shaped like the number 1.

Everyone gathered around me.

The candles were lit.

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The room became brighter.
People started singing.
Then everyone began clapping.
And I started crying.
Not because I was hungry.
Not because I wanted anything.
I was simply terrified of the candle.
Even the sound of everyone clapping scared me.
Instead of enjoying my birthday, I cried throughout
the celebration.
Even today, whenever my family sees those photos,
someone laughs and says,
"This fellow was scared of a birthday candle."
And everyone laughs.
Including me.
Childhood has a beautiful way of turning
embarrassing moments into funny family memories.
When I was little, I was loved by almost everyone in
my family.
Whenever relatives visited, someone would carry me.
Someone would feed me.
Someone would want a photograph with me.
At that age, I never understood how lucky I was.
Love felt normal because I was surrounded by it every
day.
Even though I received love from both sides of my
family, I always felt closer to my mother's side.
I never had a reason.
I simply felt happier whenever we visited them.
Maybe it was because everyone there treated me like I
belonged.
Or maybe that's where my favourite memories were
waiting to be made.

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My father's job wasn't permanent.
Whenever his workplace changed...
our address changed too.
Moving from one place to another became a normal
part of our life.
It never felt strange.
It was simply how we lived.
For almost three years, we stayed in Chennai with my
grandfather.
Looking back now...
those three years were priceless.
If someone asked me who my childhood hero was...
I wouldn't say a movie actor.
I wouldn't say a cricketer.
I would say...
"My grandfather."
He wasn't rich.
He wasn't famous.
He wasn't someone the world knew.
But to a little boy like me...
he was everything.
Almost every evening, he would call out,
"Mithran... come."
I never asked where we were going.
If he was going somewhere, I wanted to go too.
Sometimes I held his hand while we walked through
the streets.
Sometimes I ran a few steps ahead before waiting for
him to catch up.
He sold healthy food products around the
neighbourhood.
At that age, I had no idea what he was selling or why
he did that work.

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I only knew one thing.

If I went with him...

I would come back happy.

After finishing his work, he would always ask me the same question.

"Hungry?"

He already knew my answer before I even spoke.

A few minutes later, we would be sitting in a small roadside shop.

Some evenings, he bought me a glass of fresh lemon juice.

Other days, it was warm idiyappam served with sweet coconut milk.

I can still remember the taste.

Maybe not because the food was extraordinary.

But because of the person who bought it for me.

Food tastes different when it's served with love.

Every morning before school, my grandfather had another small routine.

While I hurried around the house looking for my shoes or my school bag, he quietly sat beside me with a plate.

Some mornings it was mango.

Some mornings it was ice apple.

He patiently peeled every piece before giving it to me.

Only after making sure I had eaten enough would he tell me,

"Don't rush."

Then he'd smile.

"Go slowly."

Back then...

they were just words.

Today...

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they're one of the few voices I still hear whenever I think about my childhood.

I never imagined those ordinary mornings would become memories I would spend years trying not to forget.

There was another battle I fought almost every morning.

School.

I hated going to school.

Every single morning, I cried as if my parents were sending me somewhere I could never return from.

My mother would patiently get me ready, carry my school bag, hold my hand, and walk me to school.

But the moment she tried to leave...

I started crying again.

"I'm scared."

"I don't want to stay."

"Please don't go."

She never became angry.

She would kneel in front of me, wipe my tears, and say,

"I'm not leaving."

"I'll be right here until school is over."

I believed every single word.

After entering the classroom, I couldn't concentrate on anything.

Every now and then, I would ask permission to drink water or go outside.

But that wasn't the real reason.

I wanted to check if my mother was still waiting.

I walked all the way to the security room.

Every single time.

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The security uncle slowly became familiar with my routine.

"Uncle..."

"Where's my mother?"

He smiled every time.

"She just left."

"But don't worry."

"She'll come back."

I trusted him.

I happily walked back to my classroom.

Years later, I realized something.

Both of them had lied to me.

Not because they wanted to fool me...

but because they wanted me to stop crying and slowly become brave enough to stay in school on my own.

Looking back now...

I can't help but smile.

Sometimes, the smallest lies are told with the biggest love.

One afternoon, something happened that I still remember clearly.

The final bell rang.

All my classmates slowly left with their parents.

One by one, the classrooms became empty.

I sat on the small bench near the entrance, waiting for my father.

Five minutes passed.

Then ten.

Then twenty.

Almost everyone had gone home.

My class teacher noticed that I was still waiting.

Instead of leaving, she stayed with me.

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She spoke to me, asked me if I was hungry, and tried to keep me distracted.

Finally, my father arrived.

He looked worried.

He immediately apologized to my teacher.

He had accidentally fallen asleep at home and completely forgotten the time.

Since nobody else was at home, there was no one to pick me up.

After thanking my teacher, my father even dropped her at her house on the way back.

At that age, I didn't understand how responsible my teacher had been.

Today, when I think about it, I realize not everyone would have waited.

She did.

And I'll always remember that.

During my first standard, our school announced the Annual Day celebration.

Every class had to perform something.

Our class was chosen for a dance performance.

To my surprise...

I was selected too.

I still remember how excited everyone at home was.

Every evening, I practiced the steps again and again.

For days, our classroom became a dance hall.

The teachers corrected our movements.

We laughed whenever someone forgot a step.

And slowly...

the performance came together.

When Annual Day finally arrived, I wore my costume and waited behind the stage.

For the first time in my life, I wasn't scared.

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I was excited.
The music started.
We walked onto the stage.
I don't remember the song anymore.
I don't even remember every dance step.
But I remember looking into the crowd, trying to find
my family.
The moment I saw them smiling...
all my nervousness disappeared.
That night, I returned home feeling proud.
Not because I danced perfectly.
But because I had done something I never thought I
could.
Around that same time, I experienced something
almost every child goes through.
My first crush.
Her name was ***Kathija Begam***.
Calling it love would be an exaggeration.
It wasn't.
I didn't even know what love meant back then.
I just liked seeing her.
Whenever she smiled, I smiled.
Whenever she talked to me, my day became a little
better.
That was enough.
Children don't need complicated reasons to like
someone.
Sometimes...
they just do.
Life was peaceful.
School, Home, Family.
Birthdays.
Summer vacations.

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Everything felt ordinary.

And maybe that's why those memories became so precious.

Because none of us knew how quickly ordinary days could become unforgettable ones.

I thought my childhood would continue like this forever.

I had no idea that the year 20XX was about to introduce someone who would quietly become one of the most important people in my life.

Her name was...

Aashika.

Chapter Two

The Wedding

The year was 20XX
My uncle was getting married.
Like every Indian family wedding, our house became
crowded days before the actual ceremony.
Relatives started arriving one by one.
Some came from nearby towns.
Some travelled from different cities.
The house was filled with laughter, children running
everywhere, endless conversations, and people trying
to remember how everyone was related to each other.
As a child, weddings meant only one thing for me.
No school.
New clothes.
Unlimited food.
And lots of cousins to play with.
Nothing else mattered.
I wasn't interested in the wedding rituals.
I wasn't interested in photographs.
I only wanted to find the other children and start
playing.
Among the relatives who arrived that year was a
family from Kerala.
I had seen them before when I was very young.
But I didn't remember much about them.
That day...
I met Aashika.
She was my MESD.
At that age, she wasn't someone special.

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She was simply another cousin.
We didn't even introduce ourselves properly.
Children never do.
Someone said,
"Go play."
And that was enough.
Within minutes, we were running around the wedding
hall with the other kids.
Sometimes we played hide-and-seek.
Sometimes we chased each other around the dining
hall until one of the elders shouted,
"Don't run! You'll fall!"
We laughed...
Stopped for two minutes...
Then started running again.
That's how childhood worked.
There were no mobile phones in our hands.
No social media.
No overthinking.
We created our own happiness.
The wedding lasted for a couple of days.
Every morning, all the cousins gathered before
breakfast.
Someone would bring a ball.
Someone would suggest a new game.
Someone would start an argument over whose team
was better.
Five minutes later...
everyone would be laughing together again.
I don't remember winning any games.
I don't remember losing either.
I only remember enjoying every moment.
Aashika was just another part of those memories.

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Nothing more.

Nothing less.

After the wedding rituals were over, the adults became busy talking among themselves.

As usual, the children escaped.

We found an empty space near the marriage hall and continued playing until someone called us back for lunch.

Time passed without any of us noticing.

Looking back now, I wish I had noticed those moments a little more.

Because they never came back.

The wedding finally came to an end.

Suitcases were packed.

Cars were ready.

Everyone hugged each other before leaving.

The adults promised to meet again soon.

The children didn't understand what "soon" actually meant.

Before leaving, Aashika looked at all of us and smiled.

"Bye."

I waved back.

"Bye."

That was all.

No emotional goodbye.

No sadness.

No feeling that I would miss her.

Because I believed we would all meet again very soon.

I had no idea that one ordinary meeting would slowly become one of the most important memories of my life.

At that moment...

she was just my cousin.

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Nothing else.

Life returned to normal after the wedding.

School started again.

Homework replaced holidays.

Days passed as they always did.

Then...

life changed once again.

One afternoon, my grandfather suffered a heart attack while he was in the bathroom.

Everything happened so suddenly.

One moment he was there.

The next moment...

he wasn't.

I didn't fully understand what death meant.

I only understood one thing.

The person who walked beside me every evening...

The person who bought me lemon juice...

The person who peeled mangoes for me every morning...

wasn't coming back.

For the first time in my life...

the house felt empty.

That night, I couldn't sleep.

When I finally did, I had a dream.

My grandfather stood in front of me wearing the same gentle smile he always had.

He looked at me.

Without saying much, he simply smiled and said,
"Study well."

That was it.

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

I suddenly woke up.

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The dream felt so real that I looked around the room
hoping he was actually there.

He wasn't.

The next morning, I developed a very high fever.

It became so severe that my parents admitted me to
the hospital.

Even today, I don't know whether it happened
because of sadness...

or if it was simply a coincidence.

But that week became one of the earliest painful
memories of my childhood.

Life slowly moved forward.

It always does.

Even when we don't want it to.

My father left his job.

Our family packed everything once again.

This time...

we moved to Thanjavur.

As I looked back one last time before leaving, I didn't
realize I was also leaving behind one of the happiest
chapters of my childhood.

Some places become special because of the people we
share them with.

For me...

Chennai would always be my grandfather.

Chapter Three

A New Beginning

After my grandfather passed away, nothing felt the same.

The house that once echoed with his voice suddenly became quiet.

Even though I was still a child, I could feel that something important was missing.

Life slowly moved on.

It always does.

A few weeks later, my father decided to leave his job, and our family moved to Thanjavur.

By then, changing houses had almost become normal for us.

Whenever my father found work somewhere else, we packed our things and started over.

As a child, I never questioned why we moved so often.

Whenever my parents packed our things, I simply assumed we were going somewhere new.

Looking back now, I realize how difficult those days must have been for them.

Finding a new house.

Starting over.

Adjusting to another neighbourhood.

Another school.

Another life.

For me...

it was just another adventure.

For them...

it was responsibility.

When we finally reached Thanjavur, everything looked unfamiliar.

New streets.

New neighbours.

A new house.

For the next few days, every room was filled with boxes waiting to be unpacked.

While my parents arranged the house, I walked around exploring every corner.

Children don't need much time to accept a new place.

Give them an empty room...

and they'll imagine a hundred games.

A few days later, my parents admitted me to a nearby school for my second standard.

I wasn't excited.

Changing schools meant losing the friends I had already made.

It also meant introducing myself all over again.

On the first day, my father held my hand as we walked into the school.

Even though I had already completed first standard, I still felt nervous.

The classroom was full of unfamiliar faces.

Some students were talking.

Some were laughing.

Others looked just as nervous as I was.

Luckily, one familiar face was already there.

My aunt's daughter studied in the same school.

She was six months older than me.

Seeing someone I already knew made my first day a little less frightening.

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But children have their own way of welcoming newcomers.
Before the first day was even over, a boy suddenly pushed me while we were outside the classroom.
I don't even remember why.
Without thinking...
I slapped him.
Right on his ear.
The teachers rushed over after hearing him cry.
I was scared.
I thought I had just made my first enemy in the new school.
Life had other plans.
A few days later, we started talking.
Then we started playing together.
Before I realized it...
the same boy had become one of my closest friends.
Even today, whenever I think about him, I laugh.
Our friendship began with a slap.
Only childhood can create stories like that.
As the weeks passed, I slowly settled into my new school
The classrooms no longer felt strange.
The teachers knew my name.
I had made new friends.
Found a new 2nd standard crush named "Yalini"
Life was becoming normal again.
I didn't know it then...
but another unforgettable memory was waiting just around the corner.
And this time...
it would happen on a stage.

One morning, just after our class teacher finished taking attendance, she looked around the classroom before stopping at me

"Mithran..."

I stood up.

"Yes, Miss."

"Our school is conducting a role-play competition next month. I want you to participate."

I quickly shook my head.

"No, Miss... I don't want to."

The entire class turned around and looked at me.

My teacher smiled.

"You can do it."

I wasn't convinced.

Standing in front of my classmates was one thing.

Standing on a stage in front of hundreds of people... That was different.

I tried refusing again.

But she had already made up her mind.

"You'll be playing Veerapandiya Kattabomman."

Just like that...

I became a participant.

The following days were completely different from my usual school routine.

Whenever there was free time, my teacher called me outside the classroom.

She handed me the dialogue sheet.

"Read."

I started reading.

"Louder."

I read again.

"With more confidence."

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Every day, she corrected my pronunciation, my expressions, my hand movements, and even the way I stood.

After school, I continued practicing at home.

My mother became my audience. Even my neighbours heard the same dialogues almost every evening.

At first, I struggled to remember every line.

But after repeating them again and again....
they became part of my memory.

Sometimes I even walked around the house speaking the dialogues to myself

My family smiled every time they heard me.

"Looks like Kattabomman has entered the house,"
they joked.

As the competition day came closer, my confidence slowly started growing.

For the first time, I actually believed I could do it.

Finally...

the day arrived.

The school campus looked completely different.

The stage was decorated.

Students were dressed in colourful costumes.

Teachers were running from one place to another, making sure everything was ready.

Behind the stage, every participant silently revised their dialogues.

Some looked excited.

Some looked nervous.

I belonged to the second group.

My costume was ready.

The fake moustache was carefully fixed.

A small sword was placed in my hand.

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When I looked at myself in the mirror...
I almost couldn't recognise the little boy standing there.
The announcer's voice echoed through the speakers.
"The next participant..."
"...Mithran."
My heart started beating faster.
I slowly walked toward the stage.
The bright lights hit my face.
For a moment...
I couldn't see anyone sitting in front of me.
Then my eyes slowly adjusted.
Hundreds of faces.
Teachers.
Parents.
Students.
Everyone was looking at me.
I took a deep breath.
I opened my mouth to say my first dialogue.
Nothing came out.
My mind...
went completely blank.
Every dialogue I had practiced for weeks disappeared in a single moment.
I stood there, frozen.
My teacher, standing near the side of the stage, quietly encouraged me.
"It's okay..."
"Take your time."
I somehow remembered a few lines.
Not all of them.
Just enough to somehow finish the performance.
When I walked off the stage, I felt disappointed.

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I knew I could have done much better.
All those days of practice...
and stage fear defeated me in just a few seconds.
On the way home, nobody scolded me.
My mother smiled and said,
"You still did well."
At that time, I didn't believe her.
Today...
I understand what she meant.
Winning wasn't important.
Having the courage to stand on that stage was.
That competition taught me something I didn't realise
until years later.
Preparation is important.
Confidence is important.
But sometimes...
fear doesn't care how well prepared you are.
It simply arrives when you least expect it.
That was my first lesson in overcoming fear.
It definitely wasn't my last.
Life in Thanjavur slowly settled into a routine.
School in the morning.
Homework in the evening.
Playing with friends until my mother called me inside.
Days passed peacefully.
But my father's search for a stable job continued.
No matter how hard he tried, things didn't work out
the way he had hoped.
Once again, our family packed everything we owned.
Another new house.
Another new school.
Another new beginning.
This time...

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we moved to Trichy.

At that age, I didn't realize that this city would become my home for many years.

I also didn't know that some of the most important chapters of my life were waiting for me there.

Looking back now...

I can honestly say that moving to Trichy changed everything.

Not immediately.

But slowly.

Very slowly.

Chapter Four

A Little Sister

Trichy slowly became home.

Unlike the other places we had lived before, this city felt different.

The streets became familiar.

The neighbours slowly knew who we were.

I started making new friends, and once again, life found its rhythm.

By then, my mother was pregnant.

Everyone at home was excited.

Relatives often visited us, asking the same question.

"What do you want?"

"A baby brother or a baby sister?"

Without even thinking, I always gave the same answer.

"A sister."

People laughed whenever I said it.

"Why not a brother?"

I never had a proper answer.

I just wanted a little sister.

Even before she was born, I had already imagined what life would be like with her.

Sometimes, when I was alone, I placed my stuffed toys beside me and pretended one of them was my younger sister.

I spoke to the toy as if it could hear me.

I imagined teaching her games.

Sharing my chocolates with her.

Protecting her whenever someone made her cry.

Children have strange imaginations.
Mine always included a little sister.
As the months passed, everyone in the house became busier than usual.
Tiny clothes started appearing.
Baby blankets were folded neatly inside the cupboard.
Whenever relatives visited, they smiled at my mother and asked how she was feeling.
The whole house waited for one small person.
Then...
the day finally arrived.
It was 31st August, 20XX.
Early that morning, my mother suddenly complained of severe stomach pain.
Everything happened very quickly.
My grandmother immediately understood what was happening.
"The baby is coming."
There wasn't much time.
My father wasn't at home at that moment, so I quickly ran outside and called the auto driver who was well known to our family.
Within a few minutes, he arrived.
Everyone helped my mother into the auto.
I quietly sat beside my grandmother as we rushed towards the hospital.
Nobody spoke much during the journey.
Everyone was praying silently.
After reaching the hospital, my mother was taken inside.
The operation theatre doors closed.
All we could do was wait.
Time moved differently inside hospitals.

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A few minutes felt like hours.
Every time a doctor or nurse walked past us, we immediately looked up, hoping for some news.
Finally...
a doctor walked towards us with a smile.
"The operation was successful."
"It's a baby girl."
For a few seconds...
I couldn't stop smiling.
I had wished for a younger sister for so long.
Now she was finally here.
I don't even remember what everyone else was saying.
I only remember asking one question.
"Can I see her?"
After some time, they allowed me inside.
She was sleeping peacefully beside my mother.
She looked so small that I was afraid to even touch her.
I simply stood there looking at her.
It felt unreal.
For the first time in my life...
I had someone younger than me.
Someone who would call me "Etta" one day.
I smiled without even realizing it.
That day...
I didn't just become a brother.
I became an elder brother.
As I stood beside her, I quietly made a promise to myself.
"I'll always protect you."
She was too young to hear it.
Too young to understand it.
But I meant every word.

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A few months later, another big change happened in our family.

My father got a job in Oman.

It was a good opportunity for him, and everyone was happy.

But it also meant he had to stay away from us.

I still remember the day he left.

The bags were packed.

Relatives had come to wish him well.

He hugged all of us before leaving.

I didn't fully understand what it meant back then.

I only knew that Acha wouldn't be coming home every evening anymore.

From that day onwards, it was my mother, my grandmother, my little sister, and me at home.

Life became quieter.

But something else slowly became a beautiful part of our lives.

Every year, during holidays or family functions, our relatives from Kerala visited us.

Among them...

was Aashika.

This time, things felt a little different.

Not because of love.

Not because of attraction.

Simply because we were growing up together.

She had visited our house before, but after we moved to Trichy, these visits became more regular.

Whenever her family came, our house suddenly became lively.

The adults spent hours talking.

The children disappeared into their own world.

And somehow...

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Aashika and I always ended up in the same group.
At that age, I never waited to see one particular person.

I simply waited for the holidays.

Because holidays meant family.

Family meant laughter.

And laughter usually meant...

Aashika was somewhere nearby.

Looking back now, I realise something.

Our bond didn't become strong because of one special day.

It became strong because of many ordinary days.

One holiday at a time.

One visit at a time.

One memory at a time.

Chapter Five

Kerala Days

Every year, our family looked forward to one thing.
The holidays.
Not because we could escape school for a few weeks.
But because holidays meant family gatherings.
Sometimes Aashika's family came to Trichy.
Sometimes we travelled to Kerala.
It didn't matter where we met.
As long as everyone was together, we knew we were
going to have fun.
Whenever my mother said,
"We're going to Kerala next week,"
I became more excited than I ever did for a school
trip.
I started asking questions every day.
"When are we leaving?"
"How many days are left?"
"What time are we going?"
My mother usually smiled and said,
"We still have time."
But for me...
waiting was the hardest part.
The night before every trip, I could hardly sleep.
I packed my clothes long before my mother asked me
to.
Every few hours, I checked whether everything was
ready.
Looking back now...
I wasn't excited about travelling.

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I was excited about meeting everyone again.
The journey to Kerala always felt shorter than it actually was.
Maybe because my mind had already reached there before the bus did.
The moment we arrived, the adults started talking as if they had met just yesterday.
The children didn't waste a single minute either.
Within moments...
our slippers were lying somewhere near the door...
and we had already disappeared.
Aashika was always there.
Sometimes she suggested the games.
Sometimes I did.
Sometimes none of us had any idea what to play.
Yet somehow...
we always found something.
Hide and seek.
Police and thief.
Running around the house.
Board games.
Cards.
Even simple conversations somehow became fun.
Every small thing felt exciting.
There were no mobile phones in our hands.
No television keeping us busy.
We had each other.
And somehow...
that was enough.
The elders often called us inside.
"Come and eat first."
We always answered the same way.
"Five more minutes."

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Those five minutes usually became thirty.
Eventually, one of our mothers came outside and dragged us in.
Only then did we stop playing.
Even while eating, we hurried through our food because we wanted to get back outside.
Some evenings, all of us sat on the terrace after sunset.
The adults continued talking downstairs.
The children made their own world upstairs.
We counted stars.
Made silly jokes.
Argued about things that didn't matter.
Laughed over absolutely nothing.
Back then...
life didn't need a reason to be beautiful.
Aashika's mother always treated me like one of her own children.
Whenever snacks were prepared, she never forgot to call me.
"Mithran... come and eat."
Even if I politely said,
"I'll eat later."
She never accepted that answer.
"No."
"Eat now."
That small care always made me feel comfortable in their house.
It never felt like I was visiting relatives.
It felt like another home.
Sometimes our families planned small trips together.
A nearby temple.
A park.

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A relative's house.
The destination never mattered.
The journey itself was enough.
The adults sat together talking.
We children occupied the last seats, laughing at things
only we found funny.
Every trip created another memory.
Every visit made our bond a little stronger.
Not because we were trying.
It just happened naturally.
Year after year.
Without either of us realizing it.
Neither Aashika nor I ever spoke about becoming
close.
We simply were.
She wasn't my favourite person.
Not yet.
She was just someone whose company I genuinely
enjoyed.
Nothing more.
Nothing less.
And maybe...
that's exactly why those memories felt so pure.
Because there were no expectations.
No complicated emotions.
Only childhood.
Every vacation eventually came to an end.
The bags were packed.
The adults checked if everything was ready.
Someone always forgot something and had to go back
inside.
The children suddenly became quieter.
Not because we were sad.

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But because we knew the fun was over.
As we stood near the gate, everyone started saying
goodbye.
The adults hugged each other.
The children simply waved.
Aashika smiled.
"Bye."
I smiled back.
"See you next year."
She laughed.
"See you."
The train slowly goes away.
I stood there watching until it disappeared from sight.
Then I walked back inside.
Life returned to normal.
School started again.
Homework replaced holidays.
But somewhere in my mind...
I had already started waiting for the next vacation.
Not because I hated school.
But because I knew...
when the holidays arrived...
so would another chance to make another childhood
memory.
At that time, I never imagined those memories would
one day become the foundation of the biggest story
of my life

Chapter Six

Growing Together

As the years passed, meeting once a year became a tradition.

It never mattered whether we met in Trichy or Kerala.

One thing always remained the same.

The moment our families came together...

the children disappeared into their own world.

Every visit felt shorter than the previous one.

Maybe because we were growing up.

Or maybe because time moves faster when you're happy.

Whenever Aashika's family came to Trichy, our house suddenly became full of life.

The silence disappeared.

The living room became crowded.

Someone was always making tea.

Someone was always laughing.

Someone was always calling us to come inside.

But we rarely listened.

The adults had their conversations.

We had ours.

Sometimes we played cricket in the street.

Sometimes we played carrom.

Sometimes we argued over whose turn it was to play.

Five minutes later...

we forgot the argument and continued playing together.

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Looking back now, I don't remember who won those games.

I only remember that we enjoyed playing them together.

As we grew older, our games slowly started changing. We still played.

But we also talked.

About school.

About exams.

About absolutely random things.

There was never an awkward silence between us.

Even if nobody spoke for a few minutes...

it never felt uncomfortable.

Those moments slowly became normal.

Our families also noticed how comfortable we were around each other.

Whenever there was a family photo, someone would say,

"Mithran... stand there."

"Aashika... you stand beside him."

Neither of us thought much about it.

We simply stood where they asked us to.

Someone clicked the picture.

Then we ran away before another photo could be taken.

Whenever snacks were served, everyone sat together.

Somebody always offered me one more dosa.

Someone else insisted I eat more sweets.

Aashika's mother never forgot to ask,

"Mithran, did you eat properly?"

I always smiled and nodded.

"Yes."

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Even if I had already eaten, she still placed something on my plate.

That small gesture made me feel like I wasn't just a guest.

I was family.

As children, we never understood the value of those moments.

We thought they would happen forever.

Every holiday...

Every vacation...

Every family function...

It felt like life would always stay the same.

Sometimes, after dinner, all the cousins sat together sharing ghost stories.

One person scared everyone.

Another pretended not to be afraid.

Then someone suddenly switched off the lights.

Within seconds, everyone started shouting and running.

A few minutes later, the elders came outside.

"What happened?"

"Nothing..."

We tried our best not to laugh.

Those little memories still make me smile.

They weren't extraordinary.

But somehow...

they became unforgettable.

As another vacation came to an end, the familiar routine began once again.

Suitcases.

Goodbyes.

Promises to stay in touch.

The adults hugged each other.

The children stood near the gate.

Aashika looked at me and smiled.

"Bye, Mithran."

"Bye."

"See you next year."

"See you next year."

The car slowly disappeared down the road.

I stood there for a few more seconds before walking back inside.

I didn't feel sad.

I knew we'd meet again.

At least...

that's what I believed.

Back then, Aashika was just someone I enjoyed spending time with.

I never waited for her messages.

I never counted the days thinking about her.

I never imagined a future with her.

She was simply a beautiful part of my childhood.

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

Sometimes I wonder...

If someone had told that little boy standing near the gate,

"The girl you just said goodbye to will one day

become the biggest chapter of your life,"

he probably would have laughed.

Because at that age...

"See you next year"

was just a goodbye.

None of us knew those four words would one day carry so many memories.

Chapter Seven

Growing Up

Years passed.

Without realizing it, both of us were growing up.

Our height changed.

Our voices changed.

Even our conversations slowly started changing.

But one thing didn't.

Our families still met whenever they got the chance.

Sometimes they visited us in Trichy.

Sometimes we travelled to Kerala.

Those trips slowly became a part of our lives.

School became more serious as we moved into higher classes.

Marks started becoming important.

Teachers gave more homework.

Exams became more frequent.

Even during vacations, someone always reminded us to study.

Still...

family trips never stopped.

Whenever our families met, it felt like nothing had changed.

The adults sat together talking about work, family, and life.

The children...

well...

we weren't exactly children anymore.

But we still behaved like them.

The games slowly disappeared.

Instead, we spent more time talking.

Sometimes about school.

Sometimes about our favourite movies.

Sometimes about absolutely nothing.

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Hours passed without us realizing it.
Back then, conversations were easy.
Nobody cared about replying late.
Nobody cared about who started the conversation.
Life wasn't that complicated.
One thing I slowly noticed was how comfortable I
had become around Aashika.
I never felt nervous talking to her.
She wasn't someone I had to impress.
She was simply...
someone I enjoyed being around.
If everyone sat together in one room, I naturally sat
wherever there was an empty place.
Many times...
that happened to be beside her.
Not because I planned it.
It just happened.
Our families never thought much about it either.
To them...
we were just cousins growing up together.
Sometimes our mothers laughed while looking at us.
"You both have become so tall."
Every year, they seemed surprised.
Every year, we smiled and ignored the comment.
Time moved quietly.
Without asking anyone's permission.
Birthdays came.
School years ended.
New academic years began.
The photographs kept increasing.
Looking back now, I realize something.
Most of my childhood photographs include Aashika
somewhere in the background.

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Neither of us noticed it then.

Today...

those photographs feel different.

One evening, while returning from Kerala after another family visit, I looked outside the bus window.

The city lights slowly disappeared behind us.

Everyone else had either fallen asleep or was busy talking.

I quietly put on my earphones and looked outside.

For the first time...

I felt something strange.

I couldn't explain it.

I wasn't sad.

I wasn't happy either.

I simply wished the trip had lasted one more day.

I ignored the feeling.

I told myself it was because I enjoyed family gatherings.

Maybe that was true.

Or maybe...

something had already started changing inside me without me realizing it.

Sometimes, life doesn't announce its biggest changes.

It lets them happen quietly.

Just like sunrise.

You don't notice the exact moment darkness disappears.

You only realize it when everything becomes bright.

Looking back now...

"I think this was the beginning."

Not of love.

But of something that would slowly become much bigger than either of us ever imagined.

Part II - Becoming My Favourite Person

Chapter Eight

The First Calls

As children, Aashika and I never had a reason to think about phones.

Every year, we met during family gatherings, spoke for a few days, played together, and then went back to our own cities. We never counted the days between one meeting and the next because we always believed another trip would come.

That was simply how our childhood worked.

After returning home, life continued as usual until we met again.

As we slowly grew older, things also started changing around us.

Mobile phones became common in every house.

People who once waited for festivals to meet could now hear each other's voices without travelling. For us too, communication slowly became easier.

At that time, I still didn't own a smartphone.

Whenever I wanted to speak to Aashika, I used my mother's phone.

She, on the other hand, already had her own mobile.

Initially, the calls were very short.

Most of the time, one of us would ask simple questions.

"How are you?"

"How is school?"

"When are you coming to Madurai?"

"When are you coming to Kerala?"

Those conversations rarely lasted more than ten or fifteen minutes.

Neither of us had much to say.

But somehow...

those short calls slowly became a habit.

Every time a family trip ended, we no longer had to wait for the next vacation to hear each other's voices.

A phone call was enough.

Looking back now, I think that was the first time distance stopped feeling like distance.

A few months later, our conversations became longer without either of us planning it.

One evening, I borrowed Amma's phone after dinner.

"Can I call Aashika?"

My mother smiled.

"You've already finished your homework?"

"Hmm."

"Okay. Don't talk for too long."

"I won't."

At that moment, I genuinely believed I would only speak for a few minutes.

I dialled her number.

She answered after a couple of rings.

"Hello?"

"Hi."

"What are you doing?"

"Nothing... I just finished studying."

"What about you?"

"I was watching TV."

The conversation started exactly like every other call.

Simple.

Ordinary.

Comfortable.

We spoke about school, teachers, cousins and the next family gathering. Whenever one topic ended, another somehow began.

Neither of us noticed how much time had passed.

Finally, Amma came into my room.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"Give me my phone."

I looked at the screen.

One hour and forty-eight minutes.

I stared at the call duration for a second before looking at Amma.

"I didn't even realise."

She laughed.

"I know."

"Finish the call."

That night, after returning the phone, I kept thinking about one thing.

How had we spoken for almost two hours without running out of things to say?

At that time...

I didn't have an answer.

I only knew that talking to her never felt difficult.

After that day, the long calls slowly became normal.

Sometimes she would call.

Sometimes I would borrow Amma's phone and call her.

There was never a fixed topic.

Some days we spoke about school.

Some days we argued over which movie was better.

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Some days we simply laughed at childhood memories.

The conversations were never planned.

They simply happened.

Whenever Amma noticed me holding her phone after dinner, she already knew whom I was calling.

"Aashika?"

"Hmm."

She smiled.

"Okay."

"But don't keep the phone until midnight."

"I won't."

Most days...

I failed to keep that promise.

The more we spoke, the more I realised how different we were.

Whenever I called in the evening, she was almost always doing something.

Sometimes she answered while helping her mother in the kitchen.

Sometimes she was folding clothes.

Sometimes she was arranging things around the house.

Every time I asked,

"What are you doing?"

The answer was rarely,

"Nothing."

She always seemed busy.

One evening I heard vessels making noise in the background.

"Are you in the kitchen?"

"Hmm."

"Helping Amma."

"You do so much work."

She laughed.

"What about you?"

I looked around my room.

I was lying on my bed doing absolutely nothing.

"I'm resting."

"Again?"

"I've been resting since school ended."

She laughed even more.

"You really are lazy."

"I prefer the word relaxed."

"No."

"Lazy suits you better."

I couldn't even argue.

She wasn't wrong.

She had always been responsible.

I wasn't.

That difference somehow became one of the funniest parts of our conversations.

She often teased me for being lazy.

I laughed and accepted it because...

it was true.

Sometimes our calls continued while she worked.

She would pause for a moment to answer her mother.

Then continue talking to me as if nothing had happened.

I never minded waiting.

Listening to those small sounds from her house somehow made the conversation feel more real.

It reminded me that although we lived in different cities...

our evenings somehow crossed paths through one phone call.

By then, our calls had become part of everyday life.

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Neither of us ever said,
"Let's make this a habit."
It simply became one.
Some nights the conversations ended after thirty
minutes.
Some nights they stretched for nearly three hours.
When we finally said goodbye, it never felt like we
had solved a great problem or discussed something
important.
We had simply shared another ordinary day.
At that age, I never thought those conversations
meant anything more than friendship.
She was my cousin.
My closest friend.
The person I could comfortably speak to for hours.
Nothing more.
At least...
that was what I believed.
Looking back today, I realise something.
Love didn't arrive in one moment.
It quietly entered through hundreds of ordinary
conversations that neither of us thought were
important at the time.
And perhaps...
that is why I never noticed it when it first began.

Chapter Nine

Lockdown

Just when life was beginning to settle into its usual routine, the entire world came to a sudden stop.

At first, it felt like another piece of news on television.

Every channel spoke about a new virus spreading across different countries. People wore masks.

Airports became quieter. Schools started closing one after another.

None of us imagined that our lives were about to change as well.

One evening, while I was watching the news with my mother, the announcement finally came.

A nationwide lockdown.

Schools would remain closed.

People were asked to stay inside their homes.

Public transport stopped.

Roads became empty.

For the first time in my life, I saw my neighbourhood completely silent.

The children who usually played cricket every evening disappeared.

The tea shop near our street stayed closed.

Even the temple loudspeaker, which I had heard every single morning since childhood, seemed quieter than before.

Everything had changed within a few days.

At first, I thought it would only last for a week or two.

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None of us knew it would continue for months.
Like everyone else, I also stayed at home.
School became online classes.
Instead of wearing my uniform every morning, I
attended classes wearing a T-shirt, sitting in front of
my mother's phone.
It felt strange.
Teachers who once stood in classrooms were now
speaking through a mobile screen.
Sometimes the network disappeared.
Sometimes someone's microphone stayed on.
Sometimes the teacher spoke for five minutes before
realizing nobody could hear her.
Everything felt new.
Everything felt confusing.
But slowly...
that too became normal.
The biggest change wasn't school.
It was the distance.
For the first time, I knew that even if I wanted to visit
Kerala, I couldn't.
Even family gatherings stopped.
There were no train journeys.
No vacations.
No "See you next year."
Everyone remained inside their own homes.
The only way to stay connected...
was through a phone.
That was when our conversations became more
frequent.
Not because we planned them.
Because there was nothing else, we could do.

Every evening, after finishing online classes, I would ask Amma,

"Can I use your phone?"

She never asked whom I wanted to call.

She already knew.

"Okay."

"But give it back before sleeping."

"I will."

Most nights...

I forgot.

The phone would ring only once or twice before Aashika answered.

"Hello."

"Hi."

"What are you doing?"

"Helping Amma."

The answer rarely changed.

Sometimes she was cutting vegetables.

Sometimes she was washing vessels.

Sometimes she was arranging groceries that had just arrived.

Even during lockdown, she somehow always found something to do.

I laughed one evening.

"Do you ever sit quietly?"

She laughed back.

"I do."

"When?"

"When I sleep."

"That doesn't count."

She smiled.

"What about you?"

I looked around my room.

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"I've been lying on my bed since lunch."

"I guessed."

"How?"

"Because you're lazy."

"I prefer 'peaceful.'"

"No."

"Lazy."

I couldn't even argue.

She knew me too well.

Sometimes, in the middle of our conversation, I would suddenly hear another voice.

"Aashika!"

It was her mother calling from another room.

"Wait... Amma is calling me."

"Okay."

The line became quiet.

I could hear faint sounds from her house.

Vessels.

Cupboards opening.

Someone speaking in the background.

A few minutes later, she returned.

"Sorry."

"What happened?"

"Amma asked me to help."

"Again?"

"Hmm."

"You never get tired?"

She laughed.

"I don't have a choice."

I smiled.

That was one difference between us that never changed.

She always helped everyone at home.

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I always looked for ways to escape work.
Even today, when I think about those conversations,
I remember laughing more than speaking.
Maybe that was why talking to her never felt tiring.
It felt easy.
It felt familiar.
And without realizing it...
those evening calls quietly became the best part of my
day.
As the weeks passed, staying at home slowly became
our new normal.
The days looked almost identical. I woke up, attended
online classes, ate lunch, watched YouTube for a
while and spent the rest of the evening doing
absolutely nothing. Since we couldn't go outside,
every day felt like a repeat of the previous one.
But there was one part of the day that never felt
repetitive.
Talking to Aashika
By evening, I would automatically reach for Amma's
phone.
Without anyone reminding me.
Without planning it.
It had quietly become a habit.
Most of our conversations started with the same
question.
"What are you doing?"
Sometimes she answered immediately.
"Helping Amma."
Sometimes she replied,
"Wait for two minutes."
A few minutes later, she would return and continue
the conversation exactly where we had left it.

There was never any awkwardness between us.
Even if five minutes passed in silence, it still felt like
we were talking.

One evening, I called her just after dinner.

She answered after a few rings.

"Hello."

"Hi."

"Were you busy?"

"Hmm... I was washing the vessels."

"You've already finished dinner?"

"Yes."

"What about you?"

"I finished just now."

For a moment, neither of us spoke.

Then she laughed.

"What?"

"I was just thinking..."

"What?"

"You always call after dinner."

"I do?"

"Hmm."

"I never noticed."

"I did."

I smiled without saying anything.

She was right.

Without realising it, I had started waiting for that time
every day.

Not because I planned to.

Because somewhere in my mind, evenings had
become our time to talk.

Some days, our conversations were about online
classes.

She complained about teachers giving too much homework.

I complained about waking up early even though school was at home.

She laughed.

"You still wake up late, don't you?"

"I wake up exactly five minutes before class."

"I knew it."

"How?"

"You've always been like that."

"What about you?"

"I wake up early."

"Even during lockdown?"

"Hmm."

"Amma won't let me sleep for long."

I wasn't surprised.

That sounded exactly like her.

There were also days when we spoke about food.

By then, I had started spending more time in the kitchen.

At first, it was simply because I was bored.

Then it slowly became something I genuinely enjoyed.

One afternoon, I made fried rice for the first time.

It wasn't perfect.

The vegetables weren't cut evenly, and I had added a little more salt than necessary.

Still...

I was proud of it.

Before eating, I clicked a picture using Amma's phone.

That evening, while talking to Aashika, I casually mentioned it.

"I cooked today."

"You?"

She sounded genuinely surprised.

"Yes."

"What did you make?"

"Fried rice."

"Really?"

"Hmm."

"How was it?"

"I survived."

She laughed.

"So, it wasn't good."

"It was good."

"According to you?"

"According to Amma too."

"Oh..."

"I need proof."

I smiled.

"I took a picture."

"Send it."

sent the photograph.

A few minutes later, she replied.

"It actually looks nice."

"You really made this?"

"I told you."

"I thought you were joking."

That small compliment made me happier than I expected.

Not because she praised my cooking.

Because she had looked at something I made and smiled.

At that moment, I didn't think much about why that mattered.

I simply felt happy.

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As the lockdown continued, cooking became part of my routine.

Every few days, I tried making something different. Sometimes it turned out well.

Sometimes it didn't.

Whenever I managed to make something that looked decent, I showed it to her.

She never laughed at my attempts.

Instead, she asked simple questions.

"What did you add?"

"Who taught you?"

"Did Amma help?"

Most of the time, the answers were simple.

"Mostly YouTube."

She laughed.

"I knew it."

Looking back now, I realise something.

We weren't having extraordinary conversations.

We weren't talking about love.

Or the future.

Or dreams.

We were simply sharing ordinary days.

A school class.

A recipe.

A funny mistake.

A family chore.

Yet somehow...

those ordinary conversations slowly became the memories I remembered the most.

At that age, I thought we were just passing time during lockdown.

Years later, I realised...

we were unknowingly becoming a part of each other's everyday life.

As the lockdown continued, days slowly turned into weeks, and weeks quietly became months. At first, everyone believed life would return to normal soon.

But as time passed,

we stopped asking when everything would end and simply learned to live with it.

Our conversations continued almost every evening.

Sometimes I called her.

Sometimes she called me.

There was never a fixed reason.

We just spoke.

One evening, after finishing my online classes, I spent the entire afternoon watching cooking videos on YouTube.

Since there wasn't much to do at home, I had started trying different recipes whenever Amma allowed me into the kitchen. Some dishes turned out well, while others became lessons for the next attempt.

That day, I decided to make noodles.

Amma stood beside me, watching quietly.

"Don't rush," she said.

"I know."

"Stir slowly."

"I know."

"And don't burn it."

"I know."

She smiled.

"You always say you know."

A few minutes later, I accidentally added more chilli powder than I intended.

The moment I tasted it, I started coughing.

Amma looked at me and laughed.

"I told you not to rush."

"I thought it was the masala packet."

"You thought wrong."

Even though it was much spicier than planned, we still finished eating it together.

After washing the dishes, I picked up Amma's phone as usual.

Aashika answered after a few rings.

"Hello."

"Hi."

"What happened?"

"Why?"

"You sound tired."

"I was cooking."

There was silence for a second.

Then she laughed.

"What did you make this time?"

"Noodles."

"How did it turn out?"

"I almost burnt my tongue."

"What did you do?"

"I added too much chilli powder."

She couldn't stop laughing.

"I told you..."

"You don't even know what happened."

"I don't have to."

"It always ends like this."

I smiled.

"You're making fun of me."

"A little."

"You'll never appreciate my cooking."

"I do."

"But your mistakes are funnier."

For a few seconds, both of us simply laughed.

It wasn't the noodles that made the conversation memorable.

It was how naturally we laughed together.

As our conversations became longer, I slowly started noticing something.

Whenever I told her about something that happened during the day, she listened carefully.

She never interrupted.

She asked questions.

She remembered details.

If I mentioned a recipe today, she would ask about it again a few days later.

If I spoke about an online test, she remembered to ask how it went.

Those were small things.

Things that most people would probably forget.

She didn't.

Without realising it, I had also started remembering the little things she told me.

If she mentioned helping her mother with some work, I would ask about it the next day.

If she said she had an assignment, I remembered to ask whether she had finished it.

Neither of us ever decided to do those things.

They simply became part of our conversations.

One night, while talking to her, Amma walked into my room.

"Mithran."

"Hmm?"

"Still talking?"

I looked at the clock on the wall.

It was almost ten-thirty.

"I didn't notice."

"You've been saying that every day."

"I'll finish in five minutes."

She smiled knowingly.

"You always say five minutes."

"I mean it this time."

"Okay."

She left the room without saying anything else.

I looked back at the phone and laughed.

"Amma?" "Hmm."

"She thinks we'll never stop talking."

Aashika laughed softly.

"My Amma says the same thing."

"Really?" "Hmm."

"Whenever she hears me talking for a long time, she asks..."

"Are you talking to Mithran?"

I smiled.

"So, both our mothers know."

"I think they do."

There was something comforting about hearing that.

It wasn't embarrassing.

It wasn't awkward.

To both our families, it was normal.

We had grown up together.

Talking to each other had simply become another part of our lives.

That night, after ending the call, I returned Amma's phone and lay down on my bed.

The house was completely quiet.

The only sound came from the ceiling fan above me.

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Before closing my eyes, I thought about our conversation.

Nothing extraordinary had happened.

We had spoken about cooking, Online classes, Family.

Small everyday things.

Yet somehow...

those ordinary conversations always stayed in my mind much longer than the important ones.

Back then, I believed lockdown had taken many things away from us.

Years later, I realised it had also given me something. Time.

Time to know Aashika better than I ever had before.

Time to speak without waiting for the next family trip.

Time to slowly build a friendship that neither of us questioned.

I didn't know where those conversations would eventually lead.

At that moment...

they were simply the happiest part of my day.

Chapter Ten

Midnight Conversations

As the lockdown continued, our conversations slowly found their own time.

It wasn't planned.

Neither of us ever said, "Let's talk every night."

It simply happened.

By the time dinner was over and the work at home had settled, one of us would call the other. If I didn't call first, she usually did. If she was busy, I waited. If I was attending an online class or helping Amma with something, she waited.

Somehow, without discussing it, we always found time for each other.

Most of our calls started in exactly the same way.

"Hello."

"Hi."

"What are you doing?"

"Nothing much."

"You?"

"Same."

From there, the conversation went wherever it wanted.

Sometimes we spoke about online classes.

Sometimes about our cousins.

Sometimes about a movie we had both watched.

And sometimes...

we spent ten minutes laughing over something so small that neither of us remembered it the next day.

The strange thing was...

we never ran out of things to talk about.

If someone had asked me what we discussed for three hours, I probably wouldn't have been able to answer.

Because we weren't discussing one big topic.

We were simply sharing our day.

One memory would lead to another.

One joke would become another conversation.

Then we'd suddenly remember something from childhood.

Before we knew it, another hour had passed.

One night, while we were talking, I casually looked at the clock.

10:47 PM.

"I think we've been talking for a long time."

She laughed.

"Maybe."

"What time did we start?"

"I don't even remember."

"Me neither."

Neither of us cared enough to check.

The conversation simply continued.

A few minutes later, Amma walked into my room.

"Mithran."

"Hmm?"

"Sleep early."

"I will."

She looked at the phone in my hand and smiled.

"You've been saying that for the last half an hour."

"I'll end the call now."

"Okay."

She quietly closed the door and left.

I smiled.

"Amma?"

"Hmm."

"She thinks I never stop talking."

Aashika laughed.

"My Amma says the same."

"What does she say?"

"Still talking to Mithran?"

We both laughed again.

Neither of our mothers complained.

They had watched us grow up together.

To them...

we were simply two cousins talking.

Nothing more.

The conversation continued for another hour.

Neither of us noticed when the clock crossed eleven.

Outside, the streets had already become silent.

The only sounds I could hear were the ceiling fan above me and the occasional barking of a stray dog somewhere outside.

On the other end of the call, I could hear faint sounds from her house.

A vessel being placed on the kitchen counter.

Someone closing a bedroom door.

Then silence.

It almost felt as though our houses, though hundreds of kilometres apart, had become connected by one simple phone call.

Around midnight, there was another long silence.

Not an awkward silence.

A comfortable one.

Sometimes we simply stayed on the call without speaking.

Neither of us hurried to disconnect.

Finally, she broke the silence.

"You should sleep."

"You too."

"We've been talking for too long."

"I know."

"Good night."

"Good night."

For a moment...

neither of us disconnected.

Then both of us laughed.

"You cut first."

"No... you."

"No."

"You."

That childish argument lasted another two minutes before the call finally ended.

I looked at the screen.

Call Duration: 3 hours 12 minutes.

I smiled to myself.

If someone had asked me what we spoke about for more than three hours...

I honestly wouldn't have known how to answer.

All I knew was...

those conversations never felt long.

They simply felt comfortable.

And comfort has a strange way of making time disappear.

Birthdays had always been special in our family.

Every year, relatives called each other, wished one another and shared photographs in the family

WhatsApp group. Even after we started growing up, that tradition never changed.

But during the lockdown, birthdays felt different.

Nobody visited anyone.

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There were no family gatherings.
No cake cutting with relatives.
Everything happened inside our own homes.
Only the phone connected everyone.
As our friendship grew stronger, I quietly started
following one small habit.
Whenever Aashika's birthday came closer, I made
sure I stayed awake.
Not because she expected it.
She never asked me to.
It was something I wanted to do.
Around eleven-thirty that night, I kept checking the
time every few minutes.
The house was completely silent.
Amma and my little sister had already gone to sleep.
Only the light in my room was still on.
I unlocked the phone.
11:52 PM.
Eight more minutes.
I opened our chat.
Closed it.
Opened it again.
Typed a message.
Deleted it.
Typed another one.
Deleted that too.
Nothing I wrote felt right.
Finally, I smiled to myself.
"Why am I thinking this much?"
At exactly twelve o'clock...
I typed.
"Happy Birthday, Aashika!"

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I hope this year brings you lots of happiness, good health and everything you've been wishing for. Stay the same... and keep smiling. Have a wonderful day.”

I looked at the screen for a second.

Then pressed Send.

The message was delivered immediately.

A few moments later...

she replied.

“Thank you so much, Mithran!”

That one reply was enough to make me smile.

I locked the phone and went to sleep.

There wasn't any special reason behind it.

I simply liked being one of the first people to wish her.

A months later...

my birthday arrived.

Unlike her birthday, I didn't stay awake waiting for messages.

I never expected anyone to wish me exactly at midnight.

Not even her.

I simply slept.

The next morning, after waking up, I checked my phone.

There were messages from relatives.

School friends.

Family groups.

But not from Aashika.

For a brief moment, I wondered whether she had forgotten.

Then I smiled.

"She's probably busy."

That thought disappeared almost as quickly as it had come.

I got ready, helped Amma with a few things and continued with the day.

Around noon, while I was sitting in the hall, my phone vibrated.

It was her.

“Happy Birthday, Mithran!”

I'm really sorry. I completely forgot to wish you in the morning. I remembered only now. Hope you have a wonderful year ahead!

I read the message twice. Then smiled.

There wasn't even a single moment where I felt disappointed.

Because for me...

it didn't matter whether she wished me at twelve in the night or twelve in the afternoon.

What mattered was...

she remembered.

I replied.

“Thank you. No problem at all.”

A few seconds later, she replied again.

“Did you cut the cake?”

That one question naturally started another conversation.

Soon we were talking about birthdays from our childhood, the cakes our parents used to buy and the funny photographs that always appeared in the family WhatsApp group every year.

By the end of the conversation...

I had completely forgotten that she hadn't wished me at midnight.

All I remembered...

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was the smile on my face while talking to her.
Looking back today, I realise something.
People show affection in different ways.
Some remember the exact minute.
Some remember later.
Some express it through long messages.
Some through simple words.
I never wanted to compare the way we cared.
Because caring was never a competition.
If she remembered me...
that was enough.
And somehow...
it always was.
As the months passed, our conversations became
more than just phone calls.
They quietly became a part of my daily routine.
There wasn't a single day when I thought,
"I have to talk to Aashika today."
It happened naturally.
If something funny happened during the day, I
wanted to tell her.
If I learnt a new recipe, I wanted to tell her.
If my online class became boring, I wanted to
complain to her.
Somehow...
the smallest moments of my day slowly found their
way into our conversations.
Sometimes, after ending a call, I would suddenly
remember something I had forgotten to tell her.
Without thinking much, I would call again.
She answered and laughed.
"What happened now?"
"I forgot to tell you something."

"What?"

Then I would spend another ten minutes explaining something that wasn't even important.

By the time I finished, both of us would be laughing.

Looking back now, I realise...

I wasn't calling because the story was important.

I simply enjoyed talking to her.

Whenever we met during family gatherings, I wanted to keep something behind before leaving.

Not anything expensive.

Just small things.

A pen.

A keychain.

A tiny object that belonged to me.

There wasn't any special meaning behind it.

Somewhere in my mind, I simply liked the thought that something of mine would remain in her house after I had gone back to Trichy.

I never told her why.

She probably never thought much about it either.

To everyone else...

they were ordinary objects.

To me...

they quietly became little memories.

There were also moments when I did random things just to make her notice me.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing childish enough to trouble anyone.

Just small things that made her laugh or made her ask,

"What are you doing?"

Sometimes I succeeded.

Sometimes she simply smiled and continued with whatever she was doing.

Even then...
that was enough for me.
Seeing her smile somehow felt like a small
achievement.
At that time, I never questioned why.
I simply liked making her laugh.
One thing, however, never changed.
Whenever our families met, everyone happily took
photographs together.
Group photos.
Family selfies.
Pictures during lunch.
Pictures before leaving.
I never had any problem standing in those group
photographs.
But asking Aashika for a selfie...
That was impossible.
Every single time I thought about asking, I stopped
myself.
"What if it feels awkward?"
"What if she thinks it's strange?"
"What if someone teases us?"
Those thoughts appeared before I could even open
my mouth.
So, I never asked.
Instead, I quietly stood beside everyone whenever the
whole family gathered for a photo.
Later, after returning home, I searched through the
pictures to find the ones where both of us happened
to be standing together.
Those photographs were enough.
Or at least...
I convinced myself they were.

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As the lockdown slowly became part of everyday life,
I also began changing without noticing it.
Before lockdown, school had always been my world.
Friends.
Classrooms.
Lunch breaks.
Sports.
Noise.
Everything happened there.
Now...
all of that had disappeared.
The phone had quietly replaced most of those
conversations.
Since I hardly met anyone outside my family, I slowly
became more reserved.
I spoke less.
I spent more time inside my room.
The person I talked to the most...
was Aashika.
Back then, I didn't think I was becoming an introvert.
I thought I was simply getting used to staying at
home.
Years later...
I realised that lockdown had changed me much more
than I understood at the time.
One night, after ending another long call, I placed
Amma's phone beside my pillow before returning it.
The room was dark.
Only the light from the corridor entered through the
half-open door.
I closed my eyes.
For a brief moment, I replayed the conversation in
my mind.

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I couldn't even remember every word we had spoken.

But I remembered how easily we had laughed.

How naturally we had talked.

How comfortable the silence between us had become.

At that time...

I still called it friendship.

Maybe it was.

Or maybe...

some feelings begin so quietly that they don't ask for a name.

They simply become part of your life.

Chapter Eleven

My First Phone

After completing my eleventh standard, something happened that I had been waiting for without even realizing how much it meant to me.

I finally got my own mobile phone.

It wasn't a brand-new phone.

It wasn't expensive.

It was a used phone.

But to me...

it felt brand new.

For the first time in my life, I no longer had to wait for Amma to finish using her phone before calling someone. I no longer had to ask,

"Amma... can I use your phone for a while?"

This phone was mine.

It had my own SIM card.

My own number.

And for a sixteen-year-old boy...

that felt like a small step towards growing up.

The first evening after setting up the phone, I sat on my bed exploring everything.

Changing the wallpaper.

Adjusting the ringtone.

Saving contacts.

Opening apps just to see how they worked.

It felt strange holding something that belonged only to me.

Even though it was an old phone, I handled it carefully.

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I didn't want anything to happen to it.

After saving a few family contacts, one name immediately came to my mind.

Aashika.

Until then, every time we spoke, I had called from Amma's phone.

Now...

I had my own number.

There was only one thing left to do.

I opened WhatsApp.

For a few seconds, I simply looked at the empty screen.

Then I typed a message.

Hi... This is my new number. Save it.

I read the message once.

Then again.

I don't know why.

Maybe because it was the first message I was sending from my own phone.

Finally...

I pressed Send.

The message showed one tick.

A few moments later...

Two blue ticks.

She had seen it.

My heart waited for the typing indicator.

A few seconds later...

Hey!

Got it. Saved.

I smiled without realizing it.

It was such a small conversation.

Only a few words.

But for some reason...

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it felt like the beginning of something new.
From that day onwards, Amma's phone was no longer part of our conversations.
We both had our own phones.
We both had WhatsApp.
Calling each other became easier.
Sending a message became even easier.
Sometimes we called.
Sometimes we texted.
Sometimes both happened on the same day.
Without noticing...
our conversations slowly became more frequent than ever before.
One evening, while I was scrolling through WhatsApp, I saw her profile picture appear for the first time on my own phone.
It was something I had seen before from Amma's phone.
But this time...
it somehow felt different.
Whenever her name appeared in my chat list, I instinctively smiled.
Not because of the phone.
Not because of WhatsApp.
Simply because seeing her name had quietly become a familiar part of my day.
That night, before going to sleep, I checked my phone one last time.
No new messages.
I locked the screen and kept it beside my pillow.
For the first time...
I felt that a small used phone had made Kerala feel a little

closer to Trichy.

And I had a feeling...

this phone was going to become much more than just a phone.

Getting my own phone didn't change who I was.

But it completely changed how we stayed connected.

Until then, every conversation depended on whether

Amma's phone was free. If she was using it, I waited.

If she had gone outside with it, I couldn't call at all.

Now...

all I had to do was unlock my phone.

Her chat was always there.

Waiting.

The first few days felt exciting.

Every notification made me look at my phone.

Every vibration made me wonder who had messaged.

Most of the time, it was a family WhatsApp group.

Sometimes it was my classmates.

But the notification I unknowingly started waiting for the most...

was hers.

Whenever her name appeared on my screen, I opened the chat almost immediately.

Unlike phone calls, WhatsApp allowed us to continue conversations throughout the day.

If I woke up and saw one of her messages, I replied.

If she sent something while I was having lunch, I answered after eating.

Sometimes our conversations lasted only a few minutes.

Sometimes they continued the entire day.

One topic would stop.

Another would begin after an hour.

Neither of us ever said,
"Let's continue."
We simply did.
As the days passed, we also started sharing things that
we never usually spoke about on phone calls.
Random thoughts.
Funny incidents.
Things that happened at home.
Things that happened during online classes.
Sometimes even small worries.
It wasn't because WhatsApp was different.
It was because writing made certain conversations
easier.
There were things that felt difficult to say aloud but
easy to type.
Without realizing it...
we had started sharing little secrets with each other.
One evening, I was sitting in my room when my
phone vibrated.
It was a message from Aashika.
Guess what happened today?
I smiled.
Whenever a conversation started like that, I already
knew it was going to be something funny.
What happened?
A few seconds later...
I'll tell you after dinner. Amma is calling me.
I laughed.
Some things never changed.
Even on WhatsApp...
her mother came first.
I locked my phone and waited.
Almost an hour passed.

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I picked up my phone again.
No new message.
I kept it aside.
A little later, I checked again.
Still nothing.
I wasn't upset.
I simply thought she was busy.
That happened often.
She always helped her mother before doing anything else.
Nearly an hour and a half later...
my phone vibrated.
Sorry... I got busy.
Now I'll tell you.
I smiled before even reading the next message.
Not because she apologised.
Because she came back.
That was enough.
She then spent the next twenty minutes telling me a funny incident that had happened at home.
By the time she finished, both of us were laughing through messages.
If someone had read that chat later, they probably wouldn't have found anything extraordinary.
But to us...
those ordinary conversations slowly became unforgettable.
As weeks passed, our chat history became longer.
Every morning pushed yesterday's messages a little further up.
Sometimes I scrolled back just to read old conversations.
Not because I had forgotten them.

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Because reading them made me smile again.
I never told her that.
It felt like a strange thing to admit.
There were days when she replied immediately.
There were also days when she disappeared for hours.
At first, I never thought much about it.
I knew how busy she was.
Helping her mother.
Doing household work.
Studying.
Life at home.
She had responsibilities.
I understood that.
Or at least...
I believed I did.
But slowly...
without even noticing...
I started looking at WhatsApp a little more often than
before.
Not because I expected a reply.
Just because I wondered...
whether one had arrived.
And that small habit...
quietly became the beginning of something I didn't
yet understand.
As our conversations became more frequent, I slowly
started noticing something.
Phone calls were different.
When we spoke over a call, I knew she was there.
I could hear her voice.
I knew she was listening.
But WhatsApp was different.
A message could remain unread for minutes.

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Sometimes hours.
And during those hours...
my mind quietly started creating questions that had
never existed before.
One afternoon, I sent her a message.
It wasn't anything important.
Just something funny that had happened during the
day.
I smiled after pressing Send, expecting that we'd
probably end up talking for a while.
A few minutes passed.
No reply.
I kept my phone beside me.
"It's okay," I thought.
"She must be busy."
An hour later...
I unlocked my phone again.
The message still had two grey ticks.
It hadn't even been opened.
I locked the phone and placed it face down on the
bed.
Without realizing it...
I kept picking it up every few minutes.
Not because I was impatient.
Simply because I wondered if she had seen it.
By evening...
the message finally turned blue.
She had read it.
I smiled instinctively.
A few seconds passed.
No reply.
The smile slowly disappeared.
Then another thought quietly entered my mind.

"Maybe she's busy again."
That made sense.
She had always been busy.
Nothing was different.
So why was I thinking about it so much?
I opened our chat.
I typed another message.
Busy?
I looked at it for a few seconds.
Then...
I deleted it.
"What if I'm disturbing her?"
That question stayed on the screen much longer than
the message itself.
I locked my phone again.
"If she's free..."
"She'll reply."
Almost an hour later, my phone vibrated.
Sorry. I was helping Amma.
Just saw your message.
I looked at the screen for a moment.
Then smiled.
Every unnecessary thought I had during the last few
hours disappeared with those two sentences.
I immediately replied.
No problem.
I thought you were busy.
Very busy
She replied with a laughing emoji.
The conversation continued as if nothing had
happened.
Only one person knew that I had spent hours
thinking about a reply.

Me.

Days slowly turned into weeks. This didn't happen every day.

Sometimes she replied within seconds, sometimes after ten minutes, sometimes after a few hours.

The reason was almost always the same, she was studying, Helping at home or simply away from her phone. Nothing unusual. Nothing wrong. But my habit had quietly changed.

Whenever I unlocked WhatsApp...

the first chat I looked at was hers.

Not because I expected a message every time.

Just because...

I hoped there would be one.

There were moments when she disappeared for an entire evening.

I never asked,

"Why didn't you reply?"

I never wanted her to feel guilty.

If she was busy...

she had every right to be.

Instead, I simply waited.

When her message finally arrived, I replied as though

I had only just opened WhatsApp.

I never told her that I had looked at our chat ten times before that.

Some feelings don't ask to be hidden.

They hide themselves.

One night, after replying to her message, I kept my phone beside my pillow.

The screen slowly turned black.

The room became quiet again.

I closed my eyes, but one thought stayed with me.

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"I hope I never become a burden to her."

It wasn't fear. It wasn't insecurity. It was simply respect.

I never wanted my presence to become an obligation.

I wanted our conversations to happen because she wanted to talk.

Not because she felt she had to.

She never knew those thoughts existed.

To her...

our conversations continued exactly as before.

And maybe...

that was for the best. Because while I was learning how to wait...

she was simply living her life. Neither of us was wrong.

We were just standing on two different sides of the same conversation.

Chapter Twelve

Favourite Person

By the time the lockdown had become part of everyday life, I had also changed in ways I didn't notice.

Before everything closed, most of my time was spent outside.

School.

Friends.

Classrooms.

Lunch breaks.

The noise of everyday life.

Now...

all of that had disappeared.

Every morning started inside the same room.

Every evening ended inside the same house.

The only people I saw every day were my family.

At first, it felt relaxing.

Then it slowly became my routine.

Without meeting classmates or spending time outside,

I spoke less than before.

Even at home, I often stayed inside my room after finishing online classes.

Amma sometimes looked inside and asked,

"Why are you sitting alone?"

"I'm just watching YouTube."

"Go outside for a while."

"There isn't anywhere to go."

She understood.

Everyone's life had become smaller during those days.

Mine had too.

But there was one part of my day that never felt lonely.

Talking to Aashika.

Whether it was through a phone call or WhatsApp, our conversations somehow filled the silence that lockdown had created.

There were days when we spoke for nearly four hours without even noticing the time.

If someone had asked me what we talked about, I probably couldn't have answered.

We didn't need a special topic.

Sometimes we laughed over childhood memories.

Sometimes we complained about online classes.

Sometimes we discussed the food we had eaten.

Sometimes we simply stayed on the call because neither of us felt like disconnecting.

Those conversations didn't solve any problems.

They simply made ordinary days feel a little less ordinary.

As time passed, I unknowingly started sharing more with her than I shared with anyone else.

If something good happened...

I wanted to tell her.

If something funny happened...

I wanted to tell her.

If I learnt something new...

I wanted to tell her.

Not because I had to.

Because it felt natural.

She listened without judging.

She laughed at my terrible jokes.

She remembered the small things I said.

And I remembered hers.
That quiet understanding slowly became the strongest
part of our friendship.
One evening, after finishing another long
conversation, I placed my phone beside me and
looked at the chat for a few seconds.
There wasn't anything extraordinary on the screen.
Just ordinary messages.
Smiling emojis.
Random conversations.
Voice calls.
Yet somehow...
they had become the most opened chat on my phone.
I smiled without thinking much about it.
Locked the phone.
And went to sleep.
At that moment...
I still believed she was simply my closest friend.
As the months passed, our conversations slowly
changed.
Not because we decided to change them.
They simply became more personal.
In the beginning, we mostly spoke about school,
cousins and family gatherings.
Now...
we also spoke about ourselves.
Sometimes she told me about something that had
happened at home.
Sometimes I spoke about my day.
Sometimes we discussed things that I never felt like
sharing with anyone else.
It wasn't because they were big secrets.

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They were simply thoughts that somehow felt easier to tell her.

One evening, while chatting on WhatsApp, I suddenly realised something.

If anything happened during the day...
my first thought had quietly become,
"I'll tell Aashika later."

Whether it was something funny...
or something frustrating...
or even something completely meaningless...

I wanted to share it with her.

Not because I expected advice.

Not because I wanted sympathy.

I simply liked telling her.

And she always listened.

There were many times when one of us would start talking about something completely unrelated.

Within minutes, the conversation would move somewhere else.

Then somewhere else again.

Before we realised it, another hour had passed.

It was never organised.

It never had a beginning or an ending.

It simply flowed.

Sometimes I wondered how we managed to speak for so long every single day.

But I never asked.

Some questions didn't need answers.

As lockdown continued, I slowly became quieter with everyone else.

Since I hardly met my classmates, many friendships slowly faded.

The group chats became silent.

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Some friends stopped messaging completely.
Everyone was busy adjusting to their own lives.
I didn't blame anyone.
'That was simply how life worked.
But because of that...
I found myself talking to fewer people than before.
Without noticing...
Aashika had become the person I spoke to the most.
One afternoon, I opened WhatsApp to reply to one
of my classmates.
While scrolling through my chats, I suddenly noticed
something.
Almost every recent conversation was with Aashika.
The chat was always near the top.
Not because I pinned it.
Because we spoke almost every day.
I smiled to myself.
Closed WhatsApp.
Then opened it again a few minutes later.
I wasn't expecting a message.
I just...
opened it.
At that moment, I didn't think anything of it.
It had already become a habit.
'There were also days when we shared things that
stayed only between us.
Neither of us ever said,
"Don't tell anyone."
We didn't need to.
Some conversations naturally remained where they
belonged.
'That trust slowly became one of the strongest parts of
our friendship.

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It wasn't built in one day.
It had quietly grown over years.
One night, after another long conversation, I kept my
phone beside me and turned off the lights.
The room was completely dark.
I closed my eyes.
For some reason...
our conversation continued inside my head.
I remembered the jokes.
The random topics.
The way she laughed during the call.
I smiled.
Then slowly fell asleep.
Without realising it...
those conversations had become one of the happiest
parts of my everyday life.
And without realising it...
she had quietly become mine.
Not through one big moment.
Not through one unforgettable day.
But through hundreds of ordinary conversations...
that slowly made her the first person I wanted to
share my life with.
As the lockdown slowly came to an end, life outside
our homes also began changing.
News channels started talking about schools
reopening.
People slowly returned to work.
The roads that had remained empty for months
slowly became busy again.
Everything was moving back towards normal.
But somewhere inside me...
I knew I wasn't the same person anymore.

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Before the lockdown, I never thought much about my phone.

It was just another device.

Now...

it had quietly become the place where most of my memories lived.

Our chats.

Call history.

Photographs.

Voice messages.

Everything was there.

Sometimes, without any reason, I opened our old conversations and scrolled upwards.

Not to search for anything.

Just to read.

Sometimes I laughed at old jokes.

Sometimes I smiled at conversations I had completely forgotten.

There wasn't any special reason behind it.

I simply enjoyed reading them again.

One evening, after finishing dinner, I unlocked my phone.

Out of habit, I opened WhatsApp.

There wasn't any new message.

I locked the phone.

A few minutes later...

I opened it again.

Still nothing.

I smiled at myself.

"What am I doing?"

I placed the phone on the table and walked away.

Nearly half an hour later, it vibrated.

It was her.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Hi...

Only one word.

Nothing more.

Yet somehow...

that one word was enough to begin another conversation that lasted until late at night.

It amazed me how easily we spoke.

No planning.

No formalities.

One simple message was enough.

There were many things I never told her.

I never told her that I waited for her messages.

I never told her that her chat was the first one I opened every morning.

I never told her that I reread our old conversations.

Not because I wanted to hide anything.

Because, to me, those things felt normal.

I thought everyone probably did the same with the people they were closest to.

So, I never questioned it.

She never treated me differently either.

She spoke to me exactly the way she always had.

Comfortably.

Honestly.

Without pretending to be someone else.

Whenever she laughed, she laughed freely.

Whenever she was busy, she simply said she was busy.

Whenever she had something to share, she shared it.

There was no confusion between us.

There were no misunderstandings.

Only a friendship that had quietly grown stronger over the years.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

One night, after ending another long conversation, I kept my phone beside my pillow.
Before sleeping, I looked at the screen one last time.
Our chat was still open.
The last message she had sent simply read, Good night. I smiled.
Typed the same words back. Good night
Then I turned off the screen.
At that moment, life felt simple.
I had my family, My studies, My little world and somewhere in Kerala...
there was someone who had unknowingly become an important part of my everyday life.
I didn't call it love. She didn't call it anything either.
To both of us...
it was simply the friendship we had built over the years.
Neither of us knew that life was quietly preparing the next chapter.
A chapter where our conversations would slowly change.
A chapter where another name would enter our chats.
A chapter that would test everything we had built.
But that day had not arrived yet.
For now...
we were simply Mithran and Aashika.
Two cousins, Two best friends.
Completely unaware that our lives were about to take different paths.

Part III — The One She Trusted Most

Chapter Thirteen

Back to Normal

The lockdown that had changed everyone's lives was finally coming to an end.
Schools slowly reopened.
Trains started running again.
People returned to work.
The roads that had remained empty for months slowly became crowded once more.
Life wasn't completely normal yet.
But it was finally moving again.
For the first time in a long while, our family started talking about visiting Kerala.
Hearing that made me happier than I expected.
For almost two years, every conversation with our relatives had happened through a phone.
Now...
we were finally going to meet again.
Like every other trip, we travelled by train.
Ever since I was a child, travelling to Kerala by train had become a tradition in our family.
Every journey carried a different memory.
Every journey felt like the beginning of another story.
This one was no different.
By then, I had entered my eleventh standard.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Looking back at my school life, there was one funny thing about me.

Until tenth standard, I hated going to school.

Almost every morning, Amma had to wake me up, convince me to get ready and somehow send me out of the house.

There were even days when I cried because I didn't want to go.

She still reminds me of those days whenever we talk about my childhood.

But something changed after tenth standard.

When eleventh began...

I started enjoying school.

For the first time, I actually looked forward to meeting my friends.

The classroom no longer felt like a place I wanted to escape from.

Instead, it became a place where every day created another memory.

Maybe I had grown up.

Or Maybe I had finally learned to enjoy the little things.

Whatever the reason was...

I stopped crying about school.

Instead...

I started smiling on my way to it.

My daily routine became surprisingly simple.

Wake up before sunrise.

Get ready for school.

Rush through breakfast because I always woke up later than I should have.

Attend classes.

Spend the whole day with my friends.

Return home.

Eat.

Be lazy.

Eat again.

Sleep.

Somewhere between all of that...

I had also become noticeably fatter than before.

Lockdown had changed many things.

My weight was definitely one of them.

Amma often looked at me and laughed.

"You've become healthy."

I knew exactly what she meant.

She wasn't saying healthy.

She was politely saying fat.

"I'll lose it later," I always replied.

"When?"

"Soon."

She smiled every single time.

"You've been saying 'soon' for months."

She wasn't wrong.

Even though life outside had started moving again...

one habit from the lockdown never disappeared.

Whenever I had a little free time, I opened

WhatsApp.

Not because someone had messaged me.

It had simply become part of my routine.

Sometimes there were class messages.

Sometimes family group notifications.

And sometimes...

there was a message from Aashika.

Those were the ones I always opened first.

She had also returned to school.

She was studying in tenth standard now.

Unlike me, she had an important academic year ahead of her.

Board exams.

Extra classes.

More homework.

More responsibilities.

Naturally...

our conversations became shorter.

Sometimes I sent a message after coming home from school.

She wouldn't reply immediately.

An hour passed.

Sometimes two.

Occasionally...

even longer.

At first, I wondered whether she had become busier than before.

Then I remembered.

Of course she had.

She was in tenth standard.

I knew how important that year was.

So, I never complained.

Whenever she replied, I replied back as though I had only just opened WhatsApp.

I never wanted her to feel guilty for replying late.

In my mind, there was only one thought.

"She's replying."

"That's enough."

There were also many evenings when I typed a message...

and then deleted it before sending.

Not because I had changed my mind.

Because I asked myself one simple question.

"What if she's studying?"

If she was preparing for an exam...

the last thing I wanted was to distract her.

So instead of sending another message...

I simply kept my phone aside.

If she was free...

she would message.

And she always did.

Sometimes sooner.

Sometimes later.

But she always replied.

That was enough to keep the conversation going.

The train slowly entered Kerala station just before sunset.

As the familiar buildings appeared outside the

window, I smiled

without realizing it.

Every visit to Kerala reminded me of childhood.

This time...

I also wondered how much everyone had changed after two years.

Including Aashika.

I had spoken to her countless times over calls and messages.

But seeing someone through a screen and seeing them in person were two completely different things.

I picked up my backpack as the train came to a halt.

The doors opened.

People hurried onto the platform.

I took a deep breath.

Another Kerala trip had begun.

I didn't know it then...

but this journey would quietly become the beginning of a completely different chapter in my life.

After returning from Kerala, life slowly settled back into its usual routine.

School occupied most of my day.

By the time I reached home, finished my homework and had dinner, the day was almost over.

There wasn't much free time left.

Still...

somewhere during the day, I always opened

WhatsApp.

Sometimes to send a message.

Sometimes just to see if there was one waiting for me.

Our conversations had changed.

Not because we wanted them to.

Life had become busier for both of us.

She was preparing for her tenth standard public examinations.

I was busy with my own school life.

Most of our conversations became short.

Sometimes it was just...

Hi.

Hi.

How are you?

Fine. You?

Good.

Had dinner?

Yes.

Okay... study well.

You too.

The conversation would end there.

A few hours later...

one of us would send another message.

Then another.
Instead of one long conversation...
our friendship quietly continued through many small
ones.
Even though we spoke less than before...
one habit of mine never changed.
Whenever I knew another Kerala trip was coming, I
immediately started thinking about one thing.
"What should I take for Aashika this time?"
It had quietly become my own little tradition.
I never bought expensive gifts.
I couldn't.
I was still a student.
But I always wanted to give her something.
Something she would like.
Something she might actually use.
Or simply something that would make her smile.
Choosing those gifts always took much longer than
buying them.
Whenever I saw something interesting, I asked myself
the same question.
"Will she like this?"
If the answer was no...
I ignored it.
If I wasn't sure...
I kept searching.
Sometimes I changed my mind several times before
deciding.
Not because the gift had to be perfect.
Because I wanted it to feel personal.
There wasn't any special occasion.
No birthday.
No celebration.

No reason.

I simply liked carrying something for her whenever we visited Kerala.

Looking back now...

I don't think the value of those gifts mattered.

The thought behind them did.

Sometimes I even made small crafts by myself.

They weren't professionally made.

Some had uneven edges.

Some weren't exactly the way I imagined.

But every time I finished making one, I looked at it and wondered,

"Will she smile when she sees this?"

That single question became more important than whether the craft looked perfect.

Whenever our family prepared for another Kerala trip, Amma packed clothes.

Grandmother packed snacks.

My little sister packed more things than she actually needed.

And me...

I quietly checked one more thing.

Whether Aashika's gift was safely inside my bag.

Only after confirming that...

did I feel ready to travel.

She never asked me to bring anything.

Not once.

In fact, if I hadn't brought a gift, she probably wouldn't have even mentioned it.

But I still wanted to.

Not because I expected anything in return.

Not because I wanted her to remember me.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Simply because giving something to someone who
mattered to me...
made me happy.
At that time, I never thought of it as love.
To me...
it was just another way of caring for someone who
had become an important part of my life.
And perhaps...
the heart always understands its feelings much earlier
than the mind does.
It simply waits patiently...
until one day...
the mind catches up.
As the months passed, nothing about our friendship
looked extraordinary from the outside.
We weren't constantly talking.
We weren't meeting every week.
We weren't sharing every moment of our lives.
In fact,...
our conversations had become much shorter than
they were during the lockdown.
Life had become busy again.
School had returned.
Exams had returned.
Responsibilities had returned.
And both of us slowly adjusted to our new routines.
Still...
some things never changed.
Whenever I came home from school, I automatically
opened WhatsApp before doing anything else.
Not because I expected a message.
It had simply become a habit.
Sometimes there was one.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Sometimes there wasn't.
If there wasn't...
I quietly locked my phone and continued with my day.
I never wanted to force a conversation.
If she was studying, I wanted her to study peacefully.
If she was busy helping at home, I wanted her to finish her work first.
Whenever she replied...
the conversation naturally continued.
I slowly began understanding something about Aashika.
She wasn't someone who stayed on her phone all day.
If she had work to do, she finished it first.
Only after everything else was done would she sit down and reply to messages.
That was simply the kind of person she was.
Responsible.
Patient.
Disciplined.
In many ways...
the complete opposite of me.
I admired that about her, even though I never told her.
'There were evenings when I wanted to tell her something that had happened in school.
I'd unlock my phone.
Open our chat.
'Type half the message.
Then stop.
"She's probably studying."
I'd erase the message, keep the phone aside and decide to tell her another day.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Sometimes that "another day" came the very next evening.
Sometimes I forgot the story completely.
But somehow...
that never bothered me.
Because what mattered wasn't the story.
It was the conversation.
As my eleventh standard continued, I spent more time with my classmates than I ever had before.
For the first time in my school life, I genuinely enjoyed going to school.
My friends made every ordinary day feel memorable.
We laughed during lunch breaks.
Talked between classes.
Made plans that never happened.
Created memories that still make me smile today.
Yet...
when something interesting happened...
there was always one person I wanted to tell after reaching home.
Aashika.
She wasn't there to witness those moments.
But somehow, I always felt like sharing them with her.
She, on the other hand, continued living her own life.
Preparing for her tenth standard.
Balancing studies and home.
Helping her mother.
Managing her responsibilities.
She never gave me the feeling that I was unimportant.
But she also never gave me the feeling that I was the centre of her world.
At that time...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I didn't think there was anything wrong with that.
Everyone has their own life.
Everyone has their own priorities.
I respected that.
Without realising it...
our friendship had reached a point where trust no longer needed words.
If she replied late, I didn't get angry.
If I disappeared for a few hours because of school, she didn't question me.
There was an unspoken understanding between us.
Neither of us demanded explanations.
Neither of us expected constant attention.
We simply believed that the other person would be there.
And somehow...
that belief became stronger than long conversations ever could.
One night, after finishing my homework, I picked up my phone before sleeping.
There was a message from Aashika.
Study well. Good night.
I smiled.
There wasn't anything romantic about those words.
Anyone could have sent that message.
But for some reason...
it stayed in my mind longer than it should have.
I replied.
You are too. Good night.
I kept the phone beside my pillow and switched off the light.
The room became silent.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Outside, I could hear the faint sound of vehicles passing on the road.

I closed my eyes.

For reasons I couldn't explain...

I hoped tomorrow would end with another conversation.

Not because I had something important to say.

Simply because talking to her had quietly become one of the most comforting parts of my life.

At that point...

I still believed I understood my own heart.

The truth was...

I had only begun listening to it.

Chapter Fourteen

Between Messages

By the middle of my eleventh standard, school had become one of my favourite places.
If someone had told my younger self that I would one day enjoy waking up early for school, I would have laughed.
But life has a strange way of changing people.
Every morning, I got ready without Amma having to remind me ten times.
I met my friends.
Spent the entire day laughing with them.
Returned home tired.
And before ending the day...
I almost always opened WhatsApp.
It had quietly become part of my routine.
Not because I wanted to spend hours on my phone.
Because somewhere in that chat list...
there was one conversation I always looked forward to.
Some evenings, she replied quickly.
Some evenings, she didn't.
By then, I had stopped expecting instant replies.
She was preparing for her tenth standard public examinations.
Whenever she replied late, I never complained.
Instead, I smiled whenever I finally saw her message.
That had become enough.
One evening, while talking on WhatsApp, the conversation somehow drifted towards school.

She asked,

"How's your school?"

"Good."

"Made any new friends?"

"Lots."

"What about girls?"

I stared at the screen for a few seconds.

Normally, that question would've been easy to answer.

"No."

Because that was the truth.

I had never been comfortable talking to girls in school.

Even answering attendance beside them made me nervous.

If a teacher asked me to speak to one of them for a project, I spent more time thinking about what to say than saying it.

That was simply who I was.

An introvert.

For some reason...

instead of telling the truth...

I typed something else.

"Actually... I think I have a crush on someone."

I looked at the message.

Read it once.

Then...

pressed Send.

Almost immediately, I wondered why I had written it.

It wasn't true.

There wasn't any girl.

There had never been one.

Still...

I waited for her reply.
A minute passed.
Then another.
Finally...
my phone vibrated.
"Really?"
That was all she wrote.
One word.
No shocked emoji.
No teasing.
No long list of questions.
Just...
"Really?"
I smiled.
For some reason, I wanted the conversation to
continue.
So I replied.
"Maybe."
She sent a laughing emoji.
"Who is she?"
I looked at the keyboard.
There wasn't anyone's name to type.
Because there wasn't anyone.
So I simply wrote,
"I'll tell you later."
She replied,
"Okay."
And just like that...
the conversation moved on to another topic.
As though nothing important had happened.
That night, after putting my phone aside, I lay on my
bed staring at
the ceiling.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I kept replaying that conversation in my head.

Not because I had lied.

Because I realised something.

A part of me had expected her to react differently.

I didn't know what reaction I had been hoping for.

Surprise.

Jealousy.

Curiosity.

Anything.

Instead...

she had simply smiled through a message and continued talking as usual.

For a long time, I couldn't understand why that disappointed me.

I eventually convinced myself that it was just a random joke.

Nothing more.

The truth...

was much simpler.

There had never been around any girls in my school.

The entire story had existed only inside that

WhatsApp chat.

And perhaps...

I had created it because my heart wanted an answer that my mouth was too afraid to ask.

The next morning, life continued exactly as it always had.

I woke up late.

Rushed to get ready for school.

Skipped breakfast until Amma reminded me for the third time.

Picked up my bag and hurried out of the house before the school bus left.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

By the time I reached school, the conversation from the previous night had almost disappeared from my mind.

Almost.

School was filled with people.

Classrooms full of students.

Teachers walking through the corridors.

Friends shouting across the playground.

Everyone seemed comfortable talking to everyone.

I wasn't.

I had plenty of friends.

But almost all of them were boys.

Whenever a teacher asked me to speak to a girl regarding a class activity or a group assignment, I became awkward without even realizing it.

I didn't know what to say.

How to start the conversation.

Or how to keep it going.

Sometimes I answered in just one sentence.

Sometimes I simply nodded.

My friends often handled those conversations much more naturally than I ever could.

That was simply how I was.

It wasn't that I disliked talking to girls.

I was just...

nervous.

Even the simplest conversations felt much more difficult than they probably should have.

I always worried about saying something wrong.

Or making the conversation awkward.

So most of the time...

I avoided starting one altogether.

But there was one person with whom none of those thoughts ever existed.

Aashika.

With her...

I never planned what I wanted to say.

I never worried about choosing the right words.

I never felt nervous before calling her.

If I remembered something funny, I told her.

If something annoyed me during the day, I told her.

If I had nothing important to say...

I still talked to her.

Because with her...

silence never felt uncomfortable.

One evening, after returning home from school, I changed my clothes, had dinner and sat on my bed with my phone beside me.

A message from her appeared.

"How was school today?"

I smiled.

"Good."

"Yours?"

"Same as always."

Within a few minutes, we were talking about teachers, homework and random things that had happened during the day.

As always...

the conversation had no destination.

One topic quietly became another.

Halfway through our chat, I suddenly realised something.

If this same conversation had been with any girl from my school...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I probably would've spent five minutes thinking
before typing every
reply.

With Aashika...

I replied without thinking at all.

Not because I didn't care.

Because I was completely comfortable.

That comfort had been there ever since we were
children.

It had simply grown with us.

The strange thing was...

I never noticed it while talking to her.

I only noticed it after talking to other people.

Only then did I realise how effortless our
conversations had become.

There was never any pressure to impress her.

Never any pressure to sound interesting.

I could simply be myself.

Looking back now, I think that's why our
conversations lasted for hours.

Neither of us was pretending to be someone else.

Before sleeping that night, I opened WhatsApp one
last time.

Our conversation had ended with the same words it
usually did.

"Good night."

Nothing more.

No dramatic conversation.

No emotional confession.

Just two simple words.

Yet somehow...

those two words had become the most peaceful way
to end my day.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I locked my phone and smiled.
For everyone else, she was my cousin.
For me...
she had quietly become the easiest person in the
world to talk to.
And I still hadn't asked myself why.
As the days passed, our conversations slowly found
their own rhythm again.
Some days, we barely exchanged a few messages.
Some days, we spoke for much longer than we
expected.
There was never a schedule.
No fixed time.
No rule that we had to talk every day.
Yet somehow...
we always found our way back to the same
conversation.
One evening, while I was finishing my homework, my
phone vibrated.
It was Aashika.
"Finally finished studying."
I smiled and replied.
"Long day?"
A few seconds later, another message appeared.
"Very."
That single word slowly became a conversation.
She told me about a teacher who had taken an extra
class.
She spoke about preparing for her public
examinations.
She complained about how tired she was after coming
home.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

She even laughed about a small mistake she had made during class.

None of those things were extraordinary.

But for the first time...

she wasn't just replying to my questions.

She was telling me about her day.

I noticed that change immediately.

Earlier, most of our conversations started because I had something to say.

Now...

sometimes she started them.

Sometimes she shared something without me even asking.

It was a small change.

But it made me unexpectedly happy.

Not because I wanted to know everything about her.

Because it felt like she was comfortable enough to share those little moments with me.

As weeks passed, those small conversations slowly became part of our friendship.

Some evenings, she would simply message,

"Today's class was so boring."

Or,

"I'm finally done with today's work."

I would reply with something equally ordinary.

Then, without planning it, another conversation would begin.

The strange thing was...

our chats didn't need exciting topics anymore.

Even ordinary days somehow became worth talking about.

Sometimes she shared small worries.

Nothing serious.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Just the kind of thoughts people casually tell someone they trust.

She never asked me to solve them.

Most of the time, she only wanted someone to listen.

I wasn't very good at giving advice.

In fact, I often struggled to find the right words.

So instead of trying to sound wise...

I simply listened.

Sometimes I replied with only a few sentences.

Sometimes I asked another question.

Sometimes I just let her finish speaking.

Looking back, I think listening became the most important thing I could offer.

One night, after another long conversation, I put my phone down and looked out of the window.

The street outside was almost empty.

A cool breeze came through the half-open window.

Everything was quiet.

Yet my mind was still replaying our conversation.

Not because she had said something unforgettable.

Because she had trusted me with another ordinary piece of her life.

I don't know when that started meaning so much to me.

I only knew that every time she shared something with me...

I felt closer to her.

What I didn't realise at the time was that our friendship had quietly reached another stage.

It was no longer built only on childhood memories.

Or family gatherings.

Or long phone calls during lockdown.

Now...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

it was being built through everyday life.
One conversation after another.
One ordinary day after another.
Without either of us noticing...
those ordinary moments were becoming memories.
And memories...
have a quiet way of bringing two people closer.

Chapter Fifteen

The Things I Never Counted

Life slowly settled into another routine.
Months passed one after another.
School became busier.
Assignments increased.
Examinations came and went.
Even though every day looked almost the same, one habit of mine never changed.
Whenever I knew we would eventually visit Kerala, I started thinking about Aashika's gift long before the journey itself.
It wasn't something anyone asked me to do.
In fact...
nobody even knew how much time I spent thinking about it.
Sometimes I sat alone in my room with small pieces of coloured paper, glue, scissors and a pencil spread across the floor.
I wasn't making them for a competition. Or for school.
I simply wanted to make something with my own hands.
Something that couldn't be bought from a shop.
Sometimes the first attempt didn't look good.
I threw it away and started again.
Sometimes the glue dried in the wrong place.
Sometimes the paper folded unevenly.
Whenever that happened, I quietly began from the beginning once more.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I never liked giving something that looked rushed.
If I was going to give her something...
I wanted to do it properly.
There were also times when I found something small
that reminded me of her.
Before buying it, I always asked myself the same
question.
"Will she actually like this?"
Not...
"Will everyone think this is a good gift?"
Only one opinion mattered.
Hers.
If I thought she wouldn't like it...
I left it where it was.
No matter how much I liked it.
I never kept count of how many small gifts I had
made or collected over the years.
Some were simple crafts.
Some were little things that caught my attention.
None of them were expensive.
But every single one carried the same thought.
"I hope she smiles when she sees this."
That was enough for me.
August arrived.
Like every year, I already knew one date without
needing anyone to remind me.
27th August.
Her birthday.
The closer the date came, the more often I looked at
the calendar.
Not because I was afraid of forgetting.
Because I wanted to be awake before midnight.

On the night before her birthday, everyone at home went to sleep as usual.

The house became quiet.

Only my room still had its light on.

I unlocked my phone.

11:47 PM.

There were still a few minutes left.

I didn't want to send the message early.

I wanted it to reach exactly when her birthday began.

So I waited.

Every minute felt longer than usual.

11:55.

11:58.

11:59.

The second the clock changed...

I smiled.

Without wasting another second, I typed.

Happy Birthday, Aashika!

I hope this year brings you happiness, good health and everything you've been working hard for. Keep smiling. Have a wonderful year ahead.

I pressed Send.

For a few seconds...

I simply looked at the screen.

Not because I expected an immediate reply.

Because I felt happy knowing that I had wished her first.

A few minutes later...

my phone vibrated.

Thank you so much, Mithran!

That simple message was enough.

I locked my phone, switched off the light and slept peacefully.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

A little more than a month later...

September arrived.

20th September.

My birthday.

Unlike her birthday, I didn't stay awake expecting messages.

I never expected anyone to remember the exact minute.

Not even Aashika.

The next morning, after waking up, I checked my phone.

Birthday wishes from relatives.

Family WhatsApp groups.

A few friends from school.

But not from her.

I smiled to myself.

"She's probably busy."

That was the only thought that crossed my mind.

The day continued as usual.

I went about my routine without thinking much about it.

Later in the day, my phone vibrated.

It was Aashika.

Happy Birthday, Mithran!

Sorry... I forgot to wish you earlier.

I read the message once.

Then smiled.

There wasn't even a trace of disappointment inside me.

Because I had never measured her affection by the time shown on a clock.

She remembered.

That alone mattered.

I replied almost immediately.
Thank you.
It's completely okay.
The conversation continued naturally after that.
As though nothing had happened.
And honestly...
nothing had.
That year, another thing was different.
Usually, our family visited Kerala whenever we got
the chance.
But this time...
we didn't.
Everyone had the same reason.
Aashika was preparing for her tenth standard public
examinations.
Nobody wanted to disturb her.
Her studies came first.
So instead of packing our bags and boarding another
train, we stayed in Trichy.
For the first time in a long while...
there were no new family photographs.
No group selfies.
No new memories from Kerala.
Only old photographs...
and everyday conversations through a phone.
Sometimes I opened those older pictures and smiled.
Not because I missed Kerala itself.
Because those photographs reminded me of the
people waiting there.
And one person...
a little more than everyone else.
The academic year slowly came to an end.
Examinations were over.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

The pressure that had filled our daily lives for months finally began to disappear.

Summer holidays arrived quietly.

For the first time in a long while, both of us had a little more free time.

The days felt slower.

There were no school uniforms to iron.

No alarm clocks reminding us to wake up early.

No homework waiting on the table every evening.

Life became peaceful again.

One evening, after dinner, I picked up my phone and opened WhatsApp.

Our conversation had become less frequent during the examination period.

Neither of us had complained about it.

We both understood why.

Studies came first.

Still...

seeing her name on my screen after several quiet days made me smile.

I typed.

Hi.

A few moments later, she replied.

Hi

That simple message somehow made it feel as though no time had passed between us.

The conversation slowly became longer.

I told her about everything that had happened during the previous few weeks.

The last day of school.

The funny incidents with my friends.

How I had spent most of my holidays watching movies and doing absolutely nothing useful.

She laughed.
You haven't changed at all.
I replied,
I don't think I ever will.
As always...
I found myself talking much more than she did.
'That wasn't something new.
It had always been like that.
Whenever we spoke, I usually ended up telling two or three stories before she even finished telling one.
I never noticed it while we were talking.
Only later did I realise how much of the conversation had been about me.
She listened patiently.
Sometimes she laughed.
Sometimes she asked a small question.
Sometimes she simply replied with a smiling emoji.
Then, after a long pause, she would tell me something about her own day.
Not everything.
Just a little.
Enough for the conversation to continue.
There were moments when I felt she stopped herself halfway through a sentence.
She would type...
'Then disappear.
A few minutes later, another message would arrive.
But it wasn't the same thought she had started with.
It was something else.
At first, I ignored it.
Maybe I was imagining things.
Maybe she had simply become distracted.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

As the days passed, I noticed it happening more than once.
Sometimes I felt she wanted to tell me something.
Then she changed the topic.
I never asked why.
If she wanted to tell me, she would.
If she didn't...
I respected that.
Trust, I believed, should never be forced.
One evening, while we were talking, I suddenly asked,
"How are your holidays going?"
She replied after a short pause.
"They're okay."
Then another message appeared.
"Nothing much."
It was a normal answer.
Yet...
for some reason, it didn't feel complete.
I couldn't explain why.
It was just a feeling.
As though there were words she wasn't typing.
For a moment, I thought about asking another question.
"Is everything alright?"
My fingers rested on the keyboard.
Then I stopped.
If something was bothering her...
she would tell me when she was ready.
I didn't want to push her.
So instead, I asked something completely different.
"Have you watched any new movies?"
She immediately replied with another message.
The conversation continued.

Just like always.
That night, after putting my phone aside, one thought
stayed with me longer than usual.
For years, I had told Aashika almost everything about
my life.
Not because she asked.
Because it felt natural.
But she was different.
She shared many things.
Yet sometimes...
I felt there was a small part of her life that remained
untouched.
Not hidden out of dishonesty.
Simply...
kept to herself.
I never saw that as a lack of trust.
Everyone has thoughts they aren't ready to speak
about.
I believed that one day, if she ever wanted to tell me...
she would.
I just didn't know...
that day was much closer than I imagined.
The holidays continued quietly.
Most days looked almost the same.
I woke up late.
Spent time watching movies or web series.
Sometimes I experimented with small electronic
projects that kept me occupied for hours.
Whenever an idea came into my mind, I tried building
it, even if I wasn't sure it would work.
Some attempts failed.
Some worked better than I expected.
Those little projects made the days pass faster.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Every now and then, I picked up my phone.
Not because I had received a notification.
Just out of habit.
Sometimes there would be a message from one of my
school friends.
Sometimes there would only be family group
notifications.
And sometimes...
there would be a message from Aashika.
Whenever I saw her name, I opened it first.
I never thought about why.
It had simply become natural.
There were days when we spoke for only a few
minutes.
There were also days when our conversation
stretched across the entire evening.
A message in the afternoon.
Another after dinner.
A funny reply before sleeping.
There was no urgency.
No pressure to keep the conversation alive.
It continued naturally.
Even silence never felt uncomfortable between us.
By then, I had stopped expecting her to share
everything.
That wasn't who she was.
She spoke when she wanted to.
She shared what she was comfortable sharing.
I never wanted to force anything beyond that.
If she told me something, I listened.
If she didn't, I respected it.
Some friendships survive because of constant
conversations.

Ours survived because neither of us demanded more than the other was ready to give.

Looking back at those days, I realised I had unknowingly started measuring small moments differently.

If something funny happened, I wondered whether Aashika would laugh at it.

If I watched a good movie, I thought about telling her.

If I built something that finally worked, she was one of the first people I wanted to share it with.

Those thoughts appeared naturally.

Without effort.

Without planning.

One afternoon, while cleaning my room, I came across one of the handmade crafts I had kept aside.

I picked it up and looked at it for a few moments.

My first thought wasn't whether it looked nice.

It was whether she would like it.

I smiled to myself.

Some habits had become so normal that I no longer noticed them until they quietly appeared in moments like this.

I carefully placed it back where I had kept it.

Maybe...

the next time we visited Kerala, I could finally give it to her.

That evening, after dinner, I opened WhatsApp once again.

There wasn't any new message.

I locked the phone and kept it on the table.

A few minutes later, it vibrated.

It was Aashika.

"What are you doing?"

I smiled before typing.

"Nothing... just sitting."

"You?"

"Same."

The conversation lasted for almost an hour.

Nothing extraordinary was discussed.

We didn't talk about the future.

We didn't talk about dreams.

We didn't even talk about anything important.

Just ordinary things.

What we ate.

How boring the holidays were becoming.

A movie recommendation.

A random joke.

When the conversation ended, I realised something.

Not every memorable conversation needs memorable words.

Sometimes...

it's the person you're talking to that makes the conversation memorable.

Before going to sleep, I plugged my phone into the charger and placed it beside my pillow.

The room was completely dark except for the small charging light glowing near the switchboard.

I closed my eyes.

Out of everyone I knew...

there was one person whose messages I never got tired of reading.

One person whose late replies never made me angry.

One person whose happiness mattered to me without me ever

expecting anything in return.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

For a long time...
I had simply called her my closest friend.
That night...
without saying it aloud...
my heart quietly chose a different name.
She had become my favourite person.
She didn't know it.
And perhaps...
I didn't fully understand it either.
But somewhere between childhood memories, train
journeys, birthday wishes, late-night conversations
and ordinary WhatsApp messages...
she had found a place in my life that no one else had
ever occupied.
A place I never imagined would one day be tested.

Chapter Sixteen

Something Was Different

Time has a strange way of moving.
While living through it, every day feels slow.
But when you look back...
entire years seem to disappear within a few memories.
Before I realised it, my twelfth standard had come to
an end.
The final examinations were over.
School uniforms were folded and kept inside the
cupboard.
Classrooms that had once been filled with noise
slowly became memories.
Just like that...
my school life ended.
If someone asked me about my twelfth standard
today, the first thing that comes to my mind wouldn't
be marks.
It would be my friends.
Those two years gave me some of the happiest
memories of school.
We laughed during lunch breaks.
Made fun of each other every single day.
Stayed back after class whenever we got the chance.
Every ordinary day somehow became memorable
because of the people around me.
For the first time in my life...
I genuinely enjoyed going to school.
One funny thing about my school life never changed.
Even after spending twelve years in school...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I never became comfortable talking to girls.
Almost all my close friends were boys.
Every conversation.
Every joke.
Every memory from school...
included them.
If someone looked at my class photographs, they
would probably notice the same thing.
I was always standing with my friends.
Never because I disliked anyone.
Simply because I was too shy to start conversations
with girls.
That part of me never changed.
Ironically...
the easiest girl for me to talk to was never someone
from school.
It was Aashika.
Talking to her never felt difficult.
I never thought about what to say.
The conversations happened naturally.
Maybe that was because we had known each other
since childhood.
Or Maybe...
some people simply make you feel comfortable
without trying.
After the public examinations ended, I suddenly had
something I hadn't experienced in years.
Time.
Nearly four months before college would begin.
For the first few days, I enjoyed doing absolutely
nothing.
No homework.
No assignments.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

No exams waiting around the corner.
I woke up whenever I wanted.
Ate whenever I felt hungry.
Stayed awake until late at night.
For the first time in a long while...
there were no schedules controlling my day.
Most of those holidays were spent at home.
I watched movies that had been on my watchlist for months.
Finished web series that my friends had recommended.
Sometimes an entire afternoon disappeared in front of a laptop screen without me even noticing.
Whenever one series ended...
another one began.
My mother often walked past my room, looked at the screen and shook her head.
"You've been watching since morning."
"I'll stop after this episode."
She smiled.
"You always say that."
She wasn't wrong.
Apart from movies, I spent a lot of time doing something else that fascinated me.
Electronics.
I had always enjoyed understanding how things worked.
Taking devices apart.
Looking at small circuits.
Trying to build something with whatever materials I had.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

During those holidays, I spent countless hours working on an idea that had stayed in my mind for a long time.

I wasn't trying to copy an existing project.

I wanted to build something different.

Something I hadn't seen anyone else make before.

Whether it succeeded or failed wasn't the important part.

The excitement came from trying.

Every small improvement made me want to continue.

Some evenings passed without me even realising how late it had become.

Those four months somehow disappeared faster than my entire school life.

Every day followed almost the same routine.

Wake up.

Watch something.

Work on my project.

Eat.

Sleep.

Repeat.

Life felt peaceful.

Simple.

Uncomplicated.

During those holidays, my conversations with

Aashika also became shorter.

Not because anything had happened between us.

Life was simply moving in different directions.

Sometimes I sent a message.

Hi.

She replied.

Hi.

What are you doing?

Nothing much.

Had lunch?

Yes. You?

Yes.

Okay... take care.

You too.

The conversation ended.

Sometimes we didn't speak again until the next day.

Sometimes even longer.

Neither of us questioned it.

There was no awkwardness.

No misunderstanding.

We simply believed the other person would be there
whenever we spoke again.

And somehow...

that belief had become stronger than daily
conversations themselves.

As the holidays came to an end, admission letters
began arriving.

College was no longer a distant thought.

It had become reality.

A completely new chapter of life was waiting.

I didn't know what college would bring.

New people.

New experiences.

A completely different world.

What I didn't know...

was that someone else's life was also quietly changing.

And very soon...

those changes would find their way into one
conversation that neither of us would ever forget.

College life began much faster than I expected.

Everything around me was new.

A new campus.

New classrooms.

New teachers.

New faces.

For the first few days, I spent more time trying to remember classroom numbers than remembering people's names.

School and college felt completely different.

There were no uniforms anymore.

Nobody knew who I was.

Everyone was beginning again.

Including me.

Slowly, I started getting used to the new environment.

I made a few friends.

Learnt my daily timetable.

Found my favourite place to sit during breaks.

Every day introduced something new.

By the time I returned home, I was too tired to think about anything else.

College had quietly occupied a large part of my life.

Even then...

one habit never changed.

Before sleeping, I always checked WhatsApp.

Some habits don't disappear just because life becomes busy.

One evening, while I was scrolling through my phone after dinner, a notification appeared.

Aashika.

I smiled.

It had been a few days since we had spoken properly.

I opened the chat.

Hi.

Hi.

How's college?

It's good. Still getting used to it.

How's school?

Fine.

The conversation continued for a while.

Nothing unusual.

Nothing emotional.

Just another ordinary conversation.

At least...

that's how it began.

A few days later, she called me.

Calls between us had become less frequent over the past few months.

So seeing her name on my screen immediately caught my attention.

I answered.

"Hello."

"Hi."

"How are you?"

"I'm good. You?"

"I'm fine."

For a few minutes, we spoke about the usual things.

College.

School.

Studies.

Family.

Everything sounded normal.

Yet...

something didn't feel normal.

I couldn't explain what it was.

Her voice was the same.

Her words were the same.

But the energy behind them felt different.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

There were longer pauses between sentences.
Sometimes she answered with only a few words.
Sometimes she went silent for a few seconds before replying.
It wasn't enough for someone else to notice.
But after knowing her for so many years...
I noticed.
I didn't ask anything immediately.
Maybe she was just tired.
Maybe school had become stressful.
Maybe I was simply overthinking.
The call ended after a while.
I kept my phone beside me and stared at the ceiling.
One thought quietly stayed in my mind.
"She doesn't sound like herself."
The same thing happened again a few days later.
This time, she was the one who started the conversation.
At first, she spoke normally.
Then, in the middle of the conversation, she suddenly became quiet.
I waited.
Thinking she was probably doing something at home.
After a few seconds, she continued speaking.
But her voice still carried the same heaviness I had noticed before.
I didn't know what had happened.
I didn't know whether anything had happened at all.
I only knew...
something had changed.
Over the next few weeks, that feeling never completely disappeared.

Sometimes she laughed exactly the way she always had.

Sometimes she spoke as though nothing was wrong.
'Then suddenly...

there would be a silence.

Not the comfortable silence we had shared during lockdown.

A different one.

A silence that felt as though she was thinking about something else while talking to me.

I found myself wondering about it more often than I wanted to.

Not because I was curious.

Because I was worried.

'That night, before going to sleep, I opened our chat one last time.

I read the last few messages.

Everything looked completely normal.

If someone else had read them, they wouldn't have noticed anything unusual.

Maybe I shouldn't have noticed anything either.

Yet...

my mind refused to let it go.

For the first time in years...

I felt as though Aashika was carrying something she hadn't told me.

And for the first time...

I didn't know whether I should ask.

After that phone call, I tried convincing myself that I was simply overthinking.

Maybe college had changed my routine.

Maybe I was paying more attention than usual.

Maybe nothing was wrong at all.

For the next few days, I stopped thinking about it.

Or at least...

I tried to.

One evening, while returning home from college, my phone vibrated inside my pocket.

It was a message from Aashika.

"Hi."

I smiled.

"Hi."

"How was college?"

"Good. Yours?"

"Fine."

The conversation continued for a while.

Just like every other day.

But once again...

I noticed the same thing.

Her replies were there.

Her words were there.

Yet something behind those words felt missing.

For the first time, I decided to ask.

Not directly.

Carefully.

"Everything okay?"

A few moments passed before she replied.

"Yeah."

Only one word.

I looked at the screen for a few seconds.

Normally, I would've accepted that answer.

This time...

I wasn't completely convinced.

Still...

I didn't ask again.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

If she wanted to tell me, she would.
Over the next few weeks, that question found its way
into our conversations more than once.
Sometimes through a message.
Sometimes during a phone call.
Whenever I felt that same heaviness in her voice, I
asked.
"Are you okay?"
Or...
"You sound tired."
Or simply...
"Is something bothering you?"
Every time...
her answer was almost the same.
"No."
Or...
"Nothing."
After hearing that, I always changed the topic.
I never wanted her to feel cornered.
But even after changing the topic...
the feeling stayed with me.
There were moments when she laughed exactly like
the Aashika I had always known.
Then suddenly...
she became quiet.
Not for a few seconds.
Sometimes for almost a minute.
I never interrupted those silences.
I simply waited.
Eventually...
she always spoke again.

One afternoon, while sitting in the college canteen with my friends, I suddenly remembered our conversation from the previous night.

Without thinking, I opened WhatsApp.

Our chat was still there.

Nothing unusual.

Nothing that explained what I had been feeling.

I locked my phone again.

One of my friends looked at me and laughed.

"Who are you messaging so seriously?"

I smiled.

"No one."

The conversation moved on.

But my thoughts didn't.

A few evenings later, she called me.

This time, I didn't wait.

As soon as we finished talking about college and school, I quietly asked,

"Aashika..."

"Hmm?"

"Can I ask you something?"

"Okay."

"Is everything really alright?"

There was silence.

Not the comfortable silence we were used to.

A different one.

I waited.

She didn't speak.

For a few seconds, all I could hear was the faint sound of her breathing on the other end of the call.

"I don't know..."

she finally said.

Those three words were enough to tell me that
something really was
wrong.

I didn't ask another question.

I simply listened.

Another silence followed.

Longer this time.

Then she spoke again.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"I want to tell you something."

For a brief moment, I thought she was finally going
to say it.

Instead...

she continued softly.

"But..."

not today."

I didn't know what to say.

So I simply replied,

"Okay."

"Whenever you're ready."

She quietly said,

"Hmm..."

We spoke for a few more minutes about completely
different things before ending the call.

But neither of us was really talking anymore.

Our minds had stayed with the conversation we never
had.

That night, I lay awake much longer than usual.

Not because I was trying to guess what she wanted to
tell me.

Because I kept thinking about her voice.

For the first time since we had known each other...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I had heard something I had never heard before.

Not sadness.

Not anger.

Not fear.

It was something much quieter.

The kind of pain that tries very hard to sound normal.

I didn't know what she had been carrying.

I only knew one thing.

Whenever she was ready...

I would listen.

No matter how long it took.

Chapter Seventeen

The Story She Never Told

The conversation we never had stayed in my mind for the next few days.

Every now and then, I remembered her words.

"I want to tell you something... but not today."

I never asked again.

Not because I had forgotten.

Because I wanted her to tell me when she was ready.

If I kept asking, it would no longer be her decision.

And whatever she was carrying...

I wanted her to share it because she trusted me, not because she felt pressured.

Life outside continued as usual.

College had already become part of my routine.

Assignments slowly replaced introductions.

Teachers no longer felt unfamiliar.

Even my classmates had become friends.

Everything around me seemed to be moving forward.

Yet every now and then...

my mind quietly returned to that unfinished conversation.

A few days later, while I was sitting in my room after dinner, my phone vibrated.

It was Aashika.

"Hi."

I smiled.

"Hi."

For a while, we spoke about ordinary things.

College.

School.

Food.

Family.

The conversation felt lighter than it had been over the past few weeks.

Hearing her laugh again made me feel relieved.

For a moment, I thought perhaps whatever had been troubling her had already passed.

Then...

the conversation suddenly slowed down.

Her replies became shorter.

A few minutes passed without another message.

I didn't type anything.

I simply waited.

Finally...

another notification appeared.

"Can I ask you something?"

I replied almost immediately.

"Of course."

There was another pause.

Longer this time.

Then she sent another message.

"I need your opinion about something."

I looked at the screen for a few seconds.

An opinion?

About what?

For some reason, I smiled.

Maybe it was about school.

Maybe about choosing a course after tenth standard.

Maybe something at home.

I didn't think too much about it.

I replied,

"Try me."

A few seconds later...

she sent a laughing emoji.

"Don't laugh later."

I smiled.

"I won't."

"Promise?"

"Promise."

After sending that message, I placed my phone beside me and waited.

The typing indicator appeared.

Then disappeared.

Appeared again.

Then disappeared once more.

I watched it come and go several times.

It felt as though she was writing something...

then changing her mind.

Finally...

my phone vibrated again.

"It's a long story."

I replied,

"I'm listening."

Another pause.

Then another message.

"You have to listen completely before saying anything."

I smiled.

"Okay."

"I won't interrupt."

For nearly a minute...

there were no new messages.

The typing indicator appeared again.

Disappeared.

Appeared once more.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I had never seen her hesitate this much before.
Whatever she wanted to tell me...
it clearly wasn't easy.
Then my phone rang.
She was calling.
I answered immediately.
"Hello.", "Hi..."
Her voice was softer than usual.
Almost hesitant.
"I thought it would be easier to tell you on a call."
"Okay."
I adjusted myself against the wall and listened.
For a few seconds...
neither of us spoke.
I could hear only her breathing from the other side of
the call.
She was trying to gather the courage to begin.
I didn't rush her.
Some stories need silence before they can be spoken.
Finally...
she took a deep breath.
"Mithran..."
"Hmm?"
"I've never told anyone this completely."
I stayed silent.
"I just...", "I want to know whether I was wrong."
For the first time since the call began...
I realised this wasn't a casual conversation.
This wasn't about school.
Or family.
Or studies.
Whatever she was about to tell me had stayed inside
her for a long time.

I spoke as calmly as I could.
"Tell me from the beginning."
There was another deep breath.
Then...
she quietly began.
For a few moments, neither of us spoke.
I didn't want to interrupt her.
She had already told me that it was a long story.
So I simply listened.
The room around me had become completely silent.
The ceiling fan continued spinning above my head.
Outside, I could hear the occasional sound of vehicles
passing on the road.
Everything else had disappeared.
Only her voice remained.
She took another deep breath.
"Mithran..."
"Hmm..."
"If I tell you everything..."
"You'll tell me honestly who was wrong, right?"
I didn't answer immediately.
Instead, I asked,
"Do you want me to tell you the truth..."
"...or do you want me to support you?"
She became quiet.
After a few seconds, she replied softly.
"The truth."
Even if I'm wrong."
I smiled faintly.
"You already know me."
"If you're wrong..."
"I'll tell you."
"If you're right..."

"I'll tell you that too."
There was another brief silence.
Then she quietly said,
"That's why I'm telling you."
Those words stayed with me.
Out of everyone she knew...
she had chosen me.
Not because I always agreed with her.
But because she believed I would be honest.
I didn't know it then...
but that trust would become both my greatest
happiness and my greatest pain.
She slowly began.
"This happened during my eleventh standard..."
I listened carefully.
"There was a boy in my class."
She paused.
"He wasn't my friend at first."
"We were just classmates."
I nodded quietly, even though she couldn't see me.
"At first..."
"I didn't even think much about him."
"He was just another student in my class."
"But later..."
"I found out..."
"he had a crush on me."
She stopped speaking.
As though waiting for my reaction.
I didn't react.
I simply listened.
"He didn't tell me immediately."
"He just started talking normally."
"Small conversations."

"Nothing serious."

"Sometimes about studies."

"Sometimes about class."

"Sometimes just random things."

I could almost picture everything she was describing.

Two classmates.

Talking casually.

Nothing unusual.

She continued.

"At first..."

"I thought he was just being friendly."

"So I also spoke normally."

"I never thought anything more than that."

Her voice remained calm.

She wasn't trying to justify herself.

She was simply telling the story exactly as it had happened.

That made me listen even more carefully.

"Days passed."

"We started talking more."

"Then..."

"I slowly realised..."

"he liked me."

For the first time since the conversation began...

she stopped speaking for a longer time.

I didn't interrupt.

I knew there was more.

Finally, she continued.

"I didn't know what to do."

"I had never experienced anything like that before."

"I kept thinking about it."

"I didn't tell anyone."

"Not even you."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Those last four words stayed in my mind.
Not because she had hidden something from me.
Because I understood why.
At that time...
it was her life.
Her decision.
She wasn't doing anything wrong.
Everyone has moments they keep to themselves until
they're ready to speak.
I respected that.
She let out a slow breath before continuing.
"After some time..."
"I also started liking him."
The sentence was simple.
She didn't dramatize it.
She didn't try to make it emotional.
She simply told me the truth.
And for a moment...
everything around me became silent.
I don't remember hearing the fan anymore.
Or the traffic outside.
Or even my own breathing.
Those seven words quietly echoed inside my mind.
"I also started liking him."
My fingers tightened around the phone.
Somewhere inside me...
something broke.
Not loudly.
Not suddenly.
Quietly.
The kind of pain that doesn't show on your face.
The kind that only your heart hears.
I wanted to react.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I wanted to ask something.
I wanted to understand why hearing those words hurt
so much.
But none of those thoughts reached my voice.
Because at that moment...
this conversation wasn't about me.
It was about her.
She had trusted me enough to tell me the most
personal chapter of her life.
The least I could do...
was listen.
So I took a slow breath.
Kept my voice exactly the same.
And gently said,
"Then..."
"What happened next?"
She continued speaking.
And I continued listening.
Even though, somewhere inside me...
I already knew that nothing would feel the same
again.
For a few moments, neither of us spoke.
I had asked only one question.
"Then... what happened next?"
She quietly continued.
"He confessed to me."
There was no excitement in her voice.
No smile.
She was simply telling the story as it had happened.
"I didn't answer him immediately."
"I asked for some time."
"I kept thinking about it for days."
"I didn't know what to do."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I listened without interrupting.
Every sentence she spoke slowly painted a picture
inside my mind.
A picture that I had never known existed.
While I had been living my own school life...
She had been living another story.
A story I had never been a part of.
She continued softly.
"After thinking for a long time..."
"I accepted."
"We started talking more."
"We became close."
Her voice remained calm.
It almost sounded as though she was reading an old
diary.
Not because the memories no longer mattered...
But because she had already cried enough before
telling me.
I adjusted the phone against my ear and closed my
eyes.
I wanted to say something.
Anything.
But every sentence that came into my mind felt
unnecessary.
So I remained silent.
Sometimes...
listening is the only response another person needs.
She spoke for several more minutes.
Not once did she ask me what I thought.
She wasn't looking for an answer yet.
She only wanted someone to know the story from the
beginning.
Exactly as it had happened.

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I let her continue without stopping her.
Inside me...
another conversation had quietly begun.
"Why does this hurt so much?"
I didn't know the answer.
I had never confessed anything to her.
She had never promised me anything.
She had every right to fall in love with someone.
She had every right to make her own choices.
I knew that.
I genuinely did.
So why did my chest suddenly feel so heavy?
I slowly realised something that I had never allowed
myself to think before.
'The reason this conversation hurt...
wasn't because she had loved someone.
It was because, without noticing it...
I had started imagining a future where she was always
a part of my life.
Not as someone's girlfriend.
Not as someone else's story.
Simply...
as Aashika.
'The person I always spoke to.
'The person whose messages I waited for.
'The person who had quietly become my favourite
person.
I had never admitted that to myself.
Until now.
Still...
none of those thoughts reached my voice.
When she paused again, I simply asked,
"And then?"

She continued.

I listened.

Every now and then, I quietly said,

"Hmm..."

"I understand."

"Okay..."

Not because I knew what she was feeling.

But because I wanted her to know I was still there.

She trusted me enough to tell me something she had
never shared

completely before.

That trust meant more to me than my own emotions
in that moment.

If I allowed my feelings to interrupt her story...

this conversation would become about me.

It wasn't.

Tonight...

it was about her.

And she deserved to be heard.

As she continued speaking, I decided without saying it
aloud.

No matter how much this story hurt me...

I would listen until the very end.

Without judging her.

Without blaming anyone.

Without letting her know what was quietly breaking
inside me.

Because sometimes...

loving someone isn't about saying what you feel.

Sometimes...

it's about protecting the space where they feel safe
enough to tell you the truth.

The story had only just begun.

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And so had the silence I would carry from that day
onward.

Part IV — Silent Love

Chapter Eighteen

The Love That Once Made Her Smile

The room remained silent for a few seconds.

I didn't interrupt her.

She had trusted me enough to tell me something she had carried alone for a long time.

The least I could do was listen.

I adjusted the phone against my ear and leaned back against the wall.

"Take your time," I said softly.

"I'm listening."

She let out a slow breath.

Then she continued.

"You know..."

"At first..."

"I didn't even like him."

I quietly listened.

"He was just another boy in my class."

"He talked to everyone."

"So I never thought much about him."

"For me..."

"he was only my classmate."

She paused for a moment.

Then continued.

"Later..."

"I came to know that he had a crush on me."

"I didn't believe it at first."

"I thought my friends were simply teasing me."

"But after some time..."

"I realised it was true."

I smiled very slightly.

Not because it was funny.

Because I remembered how teenagers often discovered these things through friends before hearing them directly.

"So..."

I asked gently.

"What happened after that?"

She replied almost immediately.

"Nothing changed in the beginning."

"He never forced me."

"He never asked me anything."

"He just continued talking normally."

"About school."

"About homework."

"About random things."

"Sometimes we'd laugh."

"Sometimes we'd argue."

"It was all very normal."

As she spoke, I quietly imagined everything in my mind.

A classroom.

Two students.

Casual conversations.

Nothing unusual.

Nothing dramatic.

Just two teenagers slowly becoming friends.

"He was patient."

She continued.

"He never asked me to accept him immediately."

"He simply stayed."

"The more we spoke..."

"The more comfortable I became."

"I slowly started understanding the kind of person he was."

There wasn't any excitement in her voice.

She wasn't trying to make those memories sound beautiful.

She was simply remembering them exactly the way they had happened.

"Did you tell anyone?"

I asked.

"No."

She answered.

"I kept everything to myself."

"I didn't even know whether I actually liked him."

"I was confused."

"So I didn't tell anyone."

I quietly nodded.

Even though she couldn't see me.

"For many days..."

"I kept asking myself the same question."

"Do I really like him?"

"I didn't want to answer too quickly."

"I didn't want to make the wrong decision."

"So I took my time."

She became quiet again.

Then softly said,

"One day..."

"he proposed."

I didn't react.

I simply waited for her to continue.

"I didn't answer immediately."

"I asked him for some time."
"I wanted to think properly."
"I didn't want to say yes just because he liked me."
"I wanted to be sure about my own feelings."
Those words made me respect her even more.
She hadn't rushed into the relationship.
She had thought about it carefully.
After another short pause, she finally said,
"I accepted."
Not dramatically.
Not proudly.
Just honestly.
"I accepted because..."
"...he seemed like a genuinely good person."
"I believed he would take care of me."
"I believed we could understand each other."
"And..."
"I liked him too."
The moment she finished that sentence...
I instinctively tightened my grip on the phone.
For a second...
my throat felt dry.
I looked towards the window beside my bed.
The night outside was completely still.
I blinked once.
Then again.
I didn't want my voice to change.
I didn't want her to notice even the smallest
difference.
So I remained silent.
She continued speaking.
"After that..."
"We started talking every day."

"In school."

"After school."

"Whenever we got the chance."

"It all happened very naturally."

I quietly closed my eyes.

Every sentence she spoke felt like another page from
a book I never knew existed.

A part of her life had unfolded while I was living
mine.

Not because she wanted to hide it from me.

Simply because...

it wasn't the right time to tell me.

I understood that.

I truly did.

But understanding something...

doesn't always make it hurt less.

I took a slow breath before asking my next question.

"What happened after that?"

She answered softly.

"That's when everything became beautiful..."

And she continued.

She became quiet for a moment.

I could hear only her breathing through the phone.

Then, very softly, she continued.

"After we got together..."

"...everything felt new."

I smiled faintly.

Not because I was happy.

Because I could hear the happiness she once had in
her voice, even though those memories had already
become part of her past.

"Every morning..."

"I looked forward to going to school."

"Not because of the classes."

"But because I knew I'd see him."

"We used to meet before the first bell."

"Sometimes we'd just stand there and talk."

"Nothing important."

"Just random things."

She laughed quietly.

"Looking back..."

"Those conversations never made any sense."

"But at that time..."

"They meant everything."

I remained silent.

She continued.

"During lunch breaks..."

"We always tried to sit close whenever we could."

"If our friends were around..."

"We talked normally."

"But whenever we got a chance to be alone..."

"We spoke about everything."

"School."

"Family."

"Our dreams."

"Our future."

"We didn't realise how quickly time passed."

She paused.

Then laughed softly again.

"You know..."

"We even started sitting together in the bus."

"If there was an empty seat..."

"He'd save it for me."

"If I reached first..."

"I'd save one for him."

"The journey home never felt long."

"We'd keep talking until one of us had to get down."
I listened carefully.
Every little detail painted another picture in my mind.
She continued.
"Sometimes..."
"After school..."
"We didn't want to go home immediately."
"So we'd go out for a little while."
"Nothing big."
"Just small outings."
"We'd have something to eat."
"Walk around."
"Sit in a park and talk."
"Then we'd go home before it became late."
Her voice carried warmth while remembering those moments.
It wasn't excitement.
It was nostalgia.
The kind of smile people have while remembering days they know will never return.
I quietly asked,
"Were you happy?"
Without even thinking...
she answered.
"Very."
That one word stayed with me.
There was no hesitation.
No confusion.
She had genuinely been happy.
For a moment...
I simply closed my eyes.
Somewhere inside me, another small piece quietly fell into place.

She continued speaking.

"After reaching home..."

"We still talked."

"Every single day."

"Phone calls."

"WhatsApp."

"Voice messages."

"We'd tell each other everything."

"What happened in school."

"What our teachers said."

"What we ate."

"What made us laugh."

"Even the smallest things."

"There were days when we talked until late at night."

Then...

her voice suddenly became softer.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"I think..."

"...I should apologise to you."

I frowned slightly.

"Why?"

She stayed quiet for a few seconds.

Then answered.

"Do you remember..."

"...how I used to reply to you very late?"

I didn't answer.

I already knew exactly what she meant.

She continued.

"At that time..."

"I wasn't ignoring you."

"I wasn't angry with you."

"I just..."

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"...spent most of my free time talking to him."

"My whole day was filled with our conversations."

"So whenever you messaged..."

"I often replied much later."

"I didn't realise it back then."

"I'm sorry."

For a few seconds...

I couldn't say anything.

Suddenly...

dozens of old memories returned.

The evenings when I had looked at my phone again
and again.

The nights when I wondered,

"Maybe she's studying."

"Maybe she's busy."

"Maybe I'm disturbing her."

I remembered typing messages...

then deleting them.

then deleting them.

I remembered waiting for replies without ever asking
why they were late.

Back then...

I had created hundreds of reasons inside my own
mind.

The real reason...

had never crossed my thoughts.

Not once.

I slowly smiled.

Not because it didn't hurt.

Because I didn't want her to feel guilty.

I quietly replied,

"You don't have to apologise."

"You didn't do anything wrong."

"You were giving your time to someone you loved."
"That's completely natural."
She didn't say anything.
Perhaps she wasn't expecting that answer.
Inside me...
my heart felt heavier than it ever had before.
But strangely...
I wasn't angry.
Not at her.
Not even at him.
If two people are in a relationship...
of course they would spend time talking to each
other.
If our positions had been reversed...
perhaps I would have done the same.
That thought stopped every trace of bitterness before
it could grow.
After a long silence, she softly said,
"Thank you..."
I simply replied,
"Hmm."
She continued telling her story.
And once again...
I became nothing more than a listener.
Because tonight...
this wasn't about the memories I had lost.
It was about the memories she was finally ready to
share.
For a few moments, neither of us spoke.
The story had reached a place where the happiest
memories had already been told.
I could hear a small sigh from the other end of the
call.

It wasn't the sigh of someone who was remembering happy moments.
It was the sigh of someone who knew those moments no longer existed.
She laughed softly.
A tired laugh.
"You know..."
"There was a time when I really believed he would always stay."
I quietly listened.
"I never imagined..."
"that one day I'd be telling this story as a memory."
Her voice slowly faded into silence again.
I looked out through my bedroom window.
The streetlights were glowing outside.
A few vehicles passed in the distance.
Everything around me continued as usual.
Only this conversation had stopped time.
After a long pause, she suddenly asked,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm?"
"Can I ask you something?"
"Of course."
She hesitated.
Then, in a very soft voice, she asked,
"Do you think..."
"...I made the wrong decision by accepting him?"
The question stayed between us for a few seconds.
I didn't answer immediately.
Not because I didn't know what to say.
Because I wanted to answer honestly.
She hadn't called me to hear comforting lies.
She had trusted me with the truth.

So I owed her the same honesty.

I slowly replied,

"From everything you've told me..."

"I don't think saying yes to him was a mistake."

She remained silent.

So I continued.

"You accepted him because you believed he was a good person."

"You didn't rush into it."

"You took time."

"You thought carefully."

"And only after understanding your own feelings..."

"...you accepted."

"I don't think that's wrong."

She didn't interrupt.

She simply listened.

I continued speaking.

What matters isn't only how a relationship begins."

What matters is..."

"...how both people protect it after it begins."

"A relationship isn't tested during the happy days."

"It's tested when misunderstandings come."

"When expectations become different."

"When both people have to choose each other again and again."

She quietly whispered,

"So..."

"...accepting him wasn't my mistake?"

I gently answered,

"No."

"From what you've told me..."

"I don't think accepting someone's love is ever a mistake."

"The important part is how both people treat each other after that."

The other end of the call became silent again.

Not an uncomfortable silence.

A thoughtful one.

As though she was replaying every memory in her mind while listening to my answer.

Finally...

she spoke.

"I've been blaming myself for a long time."

"I kept thinking..."

"Maybe I shouldn't have said yes."

I slowly shook my head, even though she couldn't see me.

"If you had accepted him without thinking..."

"That would've been different."

"But that's not what you told me."

"You accepted because you trusted him."

"And trusting someone..."

"...isn't something you should hate yourself for."

She didn't reply immediately.

A few seconds later, I heard her take a deep breath.

"Thank you..."

she said quietly.

"I really wanted to hear an honest answer."

I smiled faintly.

"I promised I wouldn't lie."

For a moment, neither of us spoke.

I looked at the phone in my hand.

A strange feeling settled inside me.

Just a few minutes ago...

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I had listened to the happiest memories of the person who had quietly become the most important part of my life.

Then...

I had helped her understand why saying "yes" to someone else hadn't been a mistake.

There was something painfully beautiful about that moment.

The person I secretly loved...

had trusted me enough to judge the beginning of another love story.

And I had done exactly what she asked.

Not as someone who loved her.

Not as someone hoping for a different answer.

But simply...

as the person she believed would tell her the truth.

That trust meant more to me than my own heartbreak.

So I buried every emotion that wanted to speak.

And listened.

Because I knew...

her story wasn't over yet.

The happiest memories had already been told.

Now...

she was about to tell me how those beautiful days slowly began to change.

Chapter Nineteen

When Love Started Changing

After answering her question, neither of us spoke for a while.

It felt as though she was gathering the courage to continue.

The memories she had shared until now had all been beautiful.

They carried smiles.

Laughter.

Excitement.

The happiness of first love.

But I knew...

there was another side to the story.

Otherwise...

this conversation would never have happened.

She broke the silence.

"For almost one and a half years..."

"...everything was good."

"We argued sometimes."

"But they were small arguments."

"We'd stop talking for a few hours."

"Then one of us would apologise."

"And everything would become normal again."

I quietly nodded.

That sounded like every ordinary relationship.

Nothing unusual.

"But slowly..."

"...things started changing."

Her voice became heavier.

"Not suddenly."

"It happened little by little."

"At first..."

"I didn't even realise it."

I listened carefully.

"What changed?"

I asked softly.

She answered without hesitation.

"He started doubting me."

I remained silent.

She continued.

"If I spoke to someone in class..."

"He'd ask me who they were."

"If I smiled while talking to someone..."

"He'd ask why."

"If I came home late because of extra classes..."

"He'd ask so many questions."

At first...

I thought he was simply caring.

So I answered every question patiently.

She paused for a moment.

"But after some time..."

"The questions became more frequent."

"He wanted to know everything."

"Where I was."

"Who I was talking to."

"Why I replied late."

"What I was doing."

"At first, I didn't mind."

"I thought..."

'Maybe this is how people in love behave.'

She let out a small sigh.

"But slowly..."

"...I started feeling tired."

"I wasn't hiding anything."

"So I couldn't understand why I had to explain every small thing."

I quietly asked,

"Did you tell him how you felt?"

She replied,

"Yes."

"I told him."

"I said..."

'You don't have to doubt me all the time.'

"But every time..."

"He apologised."

"And for a few days..."

"Everything became normal again."

Then she added,

"But after some time..."

"It happened again."

"The same questions."

"The same doubts."

"The same explanations."

She continued.

"I also made mistakes."

I looked up.

"What do you mean?"

"There were times when I became angry very quickly."

"I stopped explaining."

"I'd simply say..."

'Nothing.'

'Or...'

'Forget it.'

"I thought..."

'If he trusts me, he shouldn't ask so many questions.'
"But Maybe..."
"...my silence made him overthink even more."
For the first time since she started telling her story...
I realised something important.
She wasn't trying to prove that she was right.
She was trying to understand where everything started
going wrong.
That was why she had called me.
Not to support her.
Not to blame him.
But to help her see the story from outside.
She quietly asked,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm?"
"Do you think..."
"...this was where everything started changing?"
I didn't answer immediately.
Instead, I asked,
"Can I ask you one question first?"
"Okay."
"When he asked those questions..."
"Did you feel he was trying to understand you..."
"...or trying to control you?"
She became quiet.
A long silence followed.
Finally...
she answered honestly.
"I don't know."
"At that time..."
"I thought he was just scared of losing me."
"But later..."
"I wasn't sure anymore."

I slowly nodded.
Even though she couldn't see me.
Sometimes...
the most difficult questions don't have immediate
answers.
And perhaps...
this was one of them.
The happiest part of her story had ended.
Now...
both of us had stepped into the chapter where love
slowly began losing its peace.
After a few moments of silence, she continued.
"I tried to ignore those misunderstandings."
"I thought..."
"Everything will become normal again."
"For some time..."
"it actually did."
"But only for a little while."
She paused before continuing.
"There were things I wasn't comfortable with."
I quietly asked,
"Like what?"
She answered honestly.
"He wanted to become physically closer."
I remained silent.
She continued.
"Sometimes..."
"he'd ask if he could kiss me."
"I always said no."
"Not because I didn't like him."
"But because I wasn't ready."
"I believed..."
"there was a right time for everything."

"We were still students."

"I wanted us to concentrate on our studies."

"And I wanted our relationship to have limits."

She stopped for a moment.

"I explained that to him."

"I never shouted."

"I never insulted him."

"I simply said..."

"Not now."

"Maybe someday in the future."

"But not now."

I listened carefully.

Her voice wasn't filled with anger.

It was calm.

Almost as though she had repeated these same words to herself many times before.

"He also wanted to hug me whenever we met."

"I didn't always agree."

"Sometimes I stepped back."

"Sometimes I changed the topic."

"Sometimes I simply smiled and walked away."

"I didn't want him to misunderstand me."

"But I also didn't want to do something I wasn't comfortable doing."

For a few seconds, neither of us spoke.

Then she quietly added,

"I thought..."

"...if someone really loved me..."

"...he would understand my boundaries."

The room around me felt unusually quiet.

I slowly replied,

"Everyone has different boundaries."

"And they deserve to be respected."

She didn't answer.

She simply continued.

"After some time..."

"I started noticing something else."

"He was talking to another girl."

"At first..."

"I didn't think much about it."

"Everyone has friends."

"So I ignored it."

"But slowly..."

"I realised they were becoming closer."

"He spent more time talking to her."

"He laughed with her."

"They started going out together."

"When I asked him..."

"...he told me they were just friends."

She sighed deeply.

"I wanted to believe him."

"So I did."

"For a while."

"Then one day..."

"I came to know..."

"...that he had started dating her."

The words hung in the silence between us.

I closed my eyes.

Not because I was shocked.

Because I could hear the disappointment in her voice.

It wasn't anger.

It wasn't hatred.

It was the quiet pain of someone who had trusted another person completely.

"I didn't understand."

She whispered.

"If he wanted someone else..."

"...why didn't he tell me first?"

"Why stay with me..."

"...while starting something with another person?"

"I kept asking myself that question."

"But I never found an answer."

For a long time...

I didn't know what to say.

There are moments when advice feels too small.

This was one of them.

So I simply listened.

Because sometimes...

being heard is more comforting than being answered.

She became silent again.

After nearly a minute, she softly asked,

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"Tell me honestly..."

"At that point..."

"...was I expecting too much?"

I took a slow breath.

That wasn't an easy question.

And I knew...

my answer would matter to her.

I didn't want to respond without understanding everything.

So I gently replied,

"I want to hear the rest first."

"Then I'll tell you exactly what I think."

She quietly said,

"Okay..."

Then she continued her story.

The call became quiet again.

Neither of us rushed to fill the silence.
She had spent almost two hours telling me memories
that had lived inside her for years.
Some of them made her smile.
Some of them made her stop speaking halfway
through a sentence.
Now...
she wanted only one thing.
An honest opinion.
She softly asked,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm..."
"Tell me honestly."
"Who do you think was wrong?"
"Was it me..."
"...or was it him?"
I didn't answer immediately.
This wasn't a question I wanted to reply to in a hurry.
If I simply agreed with her, she might feel better for a
moment.
But that wouldn't be the truth.
And she hadn't called me for comfort alone.
She had called me because she trusted my honesty.
I slowly said,
"Can I tell you exactly what I think?"
She replied,
"That's why I'm asking."
I took a deep breath.
"From everything you've told me..."
"I don't think this question has one correct answer."
She stayed silent.
Listening carefully.
"I don't know what was going through his mind."

"I've never spoken to him."

"So I can't judge everything from only one side."

"But..."

"...from your story..."

"I feel both of you made some mistakes."

She didn't interrupt.

So I continued.

"You said..."

"Sometimes he doubted you."

"That hurt you."

"But you also said..."

"Sometimes you stopped explaining because you became tired."

"I can understand why."

"But Maybe..."

"that silence created even more misunderstandings."

She quietly replied,

"I've thought about that too."

I nodded to myself.

Then continued.

"I also think..."

"both of you expected different things from the relationship."

"You wanted patience."

"You wanted your boundaries to be respected."

"He wanted something different."

"Neither of you knew how to understand the other's expectations properly."

There was another pause.

Then I added,

"But..."

"There is one thing..."

"...that I personally feel was wrong."

She immediately asked,

"What?"

"If someone is already in a relationship..."

"...starting another relationship with someone else..."

"isn't fair."

"No matter what the reason is."

"If the relationship was already over..."

"that's different."

"But if both people were still together..."

"...another person shouldn't have entered between you."

She didn't speak.

For several seconds...

the only sound I heard was her breathing.

Then, very quietly, she asked,

"So..."

"...you don't hate me?"

The question surprised me.

I answered without thinking.

"Hate you?"

"Why would I hate you?"

"I don't know..."

she whispered.

"I kept thinking..."

"Maybe everything happened because of me."

"Maybe if I had behaved differently..."

"none of this would've happened."

I replied gently,

"Don't carry every mistake alone."

"A relationship is built by two people."

"And if it breaks..."

"usually both carry some responsibility."

"But from what you've told me..."

"I don't think you deserved to be cheated on."

"No one does."

She didn't cry.

She didn't say anything.

She simply stayed quiet.

Sometimes...

silence says much more than tears.

After almost a minute, she finally spoke.

"You know..."

"I've been asking myself these questions every day."

"I couldn't decide whether I should blame him..."

"...or blame myself."

"I think..."

"I've been doing both."

I quietly replied,

"Maybe..."

"...you don't need to do either."

"What happened has already happened."

"You can't change it now."

"But you can learn from it."

"So can he."

She slowly let out a long breath.

For the first time since she had started telling me her story...

her voice sounded a little lighter.

Not because the pain had disappeared.

Because someone had finally listened without judging her.

"Thank you..."

she said softly.

"I really wanted someone to hear the whole story before giving an opinion."

I smiled faintly.

"I promised I would."

For a few moments...

neither of us spoke.

Then...

her voice became heavy again.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"I haven't told you..."

"...what happened after the breakup."

My grip on the phone tightened.

I quietly answered,

"I'm listening."

And with those four words...

the conversation entered the most painful chapter of her life.

Chapter Twenty

When Everything Fell Apart

For a few moments, I couldn't find the right words. I simply held the phone close to my ear and waited. She had already told me how everything had begun. She had told me about the happiest days. She had told me how misunderstandings slowly entered their relationship.

Now...

she was about to tell me how it all ended.

She took a slow breath.

"After that..."

"we started arguing more often."

"It wasn't every day."

"But whenever we argued..."

"...it felt bigger than the previous one."

I quietly asked,

"What were the arguments about?"

She answered,

"Almost everything."

"If I questioned him..."

"...he became angry."

"If I stayed silent..."

"...he asked why I wasn't talking."

"If I tried explaining..."

"...he thought I was making excuses."

"I didn't know what the correct answer was anymore."

Her voice had become noticeably weaker.

Almost as though she was reliving those moments while speaking.

"There were days..."

"...when we spoke normally."

"I'd think..."

"Maybe everything is okay now."

"But after a day or two..."

"...another argument would begin."

"It became a cycle."

She paused.

Then softly continued,

"The hardest part wasn't the arguments."

"It was..."

"...feeling like I was slowly losing the person I had fallen in love with."

I remained silent.

That sentence carried more pain than everything she had said before.

She continued.

"You remember the girl I told you about?"

"The one he said was just a friend?"

I quietly replied,

"Hmm..."

"He didn't stop talking to her."

"In fact..."

"...they became even closer."

"I tried convincing myself that I was overthinking."

"I wanted to trust him."

"I really did."

"But every time I tried..."

"...something else happened."

Her breathing became heavier.

"I asked him directly."

"Tell me honestly..."

"Is there anything between you two?"

"He kept saying..."

"No."

"You're misunderstanding everything."

She became silent.

Several seconds passed.

I didn't interrupt.

"One day..."

"I found out the truth."

"He was dating her."

"While still being with me."

Those words echoed inside my mind.

Not because they surprised me.

She had already told me.

But hearing the moment itself...

made it feel different.

"I asked him why."

She continued.

"I wasn't shouting."

"I wasn't insulting him."

"I only wanted one honest answer."

"If you wanted someone else..."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Why make me believe everything was normal?"

She stopped speaking.

I could hear her trying to control her breathing.

"He didn't really answer."

"He just kept saying..."

"I'm sorry."

"It just happened."

"I didn't mean to hurt you."

She laughed quietly.

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It wasn't a laugh filled with happiness.
It was the kind of laugh people make when
remembering something they still don't understand.
"I kept asking myself..."
"How does something like this just happen?"
"I never found an answer."
The room around me felt unusually quiet.
I slowly looked towards the ceiling.
I still didn't know the boy.
I didn't know what he was thinking.
But I knew one thing.
The person on the other end of the call...
had trusted someone completely.
And that trust had been broken.
She softly whispered,
"That was our last big argument."
"After that..."
"...there wasn't much left to save."
Neither of us spoke.
The silence between us felt heavier than any
conversation.
After nearly a minute...
she quietly said,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm?"
"We broke up."
Those three words were spoken so gently...
yet they carried the weight of an entire relationship.
I closed my eyes.
Not because I was trying to imagine the scene.
Because I could hear the emptiness in her voice.
It wasn't the sadness of someone who had just
broken up.

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It was the sadness of someone who had already cried countless times before finding the strength to tell the story.

I didn't interrupt.

I didn't comfort her yet.

Some endings deserve to be heard completely before they are answered.

So I simply stayed there.

Listening.

Exactly as I had promised.

For a long time...

neither of us spoke.

The silence after those three words—

"We broke up."

—felt heavier than the story itself.

I didn't know what to say.

No sentence felt enough.

So I simply listened.

After a few moments, she spoke again.

"When everything ended..."

"I thought I'd feel angry."

"But I didn't."

"I just felt..."

"...empty."

Her voice was calm.

Too calm.

Sometimes people become so tired of crying that even their pain begins to sound quiet.

"The first few days were the hardest."

"I couldn't concentrate on anything."

"I stopped enjoying school."

"I stopped looking forward to tomorrow."

"Everything reminded me of him."

"The classroom."

"The bus."

"The places we used to visit."

"Even simple things became painful."

She took a deep breath before continuing.

"I kept asking myself..."

"What did I do wrong?"

"I replayed every conversation."

"Every argument."

"Every message."

"I searched for the exact moment where everything started breaking."

"But no matter how much I thought..."

"...I couldn't change anything."

I remained completely silent.

She didn't need advice.

She needed someone who wouldn't interrupt her memories.

"There were nights..."

"...when I couldn't sleep."

"I'd lie awake until morning."

"My mind refused to become quiet."

"I kept remembering everything."

"The good memories."

"The bad memories."

"The promises."

"The last argument."

"They all came back again and again."

She paused.

Then, after gathering herself, continued.

"There were days..."

"...when I became angry with myself."

"I blamed myself."

"I asked why I had trusted so much."
"Sometimes..."
"...I even hurt myself."
There was another silence.
I didn't ask how.
I didn't ask why.
I knew enough to understand that she had been in a very dark place.
She quietly continued.
"I wasn't trying to die."
"I just didn't know how to deal with everything I was feeling."
"The pain inside my mind became too much."
"I didn't know where to put it."
"So..."
"...I ended up hurting myself instead.
My grip around the phone tightened.
I closed my eyes.
For the first time since the conversation had begun...
I felt genuinely scared.
Not because she had loved someone.
But because she had gone through all of this alone.
"I didn't tell anyone."
She whispered.
"I smiled in front of everyone."
"I spoke normally."
"But inside..."
"...I was completely broken."
A tear slowly rolled down my cheek.
I wiped it away before another one could fall.
She couldn't see me.
But I still didn't want my voice to reveal anything.
After another pause, she continued.

"I knew I couldn't keep living like that."

"So I tried finding something..."

"...anything..."

"...that would stop my mind from thinking."

"I started reading books."

"At first..."

"I only wanted a distraction."

"I wanted my mind to think about someone else's story instead of mine."

"Slowly..."

"I began reading more."

"Every new book gave me a few hours where I didn't think about the breakup."

She smiled faintly.

"I also started writing."

I quietly asked,

"Writing?"

"Hmm..."

"Poems."

"Not because they were good."

"But because writing made my heart feel lighter."

"There were many things I couldn't say to anyone."

"So..."

"...I wrote them down."

I imagined her sitting alone with a notebook.

Writing words that nobody else had read.

Trying to heal one page at a time.

The thought itself hurt.

She softly laughed.

"You know..."

"Some poems didn't even make sense."

"They were just feelings."

"I never showed them to anyone."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

"I didn't even think they were poems."
"They were simply..."
"...pieces of my mind."
For a long time...
I couldn't find a reply.
Everything she had gone through...
she had carried silently.
The cheerful messages.
The ordinary conversations.
The smiles she showed everyone.
Behind all of them...
there had been a battle that nobody knew about.
Including me.
I finally spoke.
Very softly.
"I'm sorry..."
She immediately replied,
"For what?"
I looked down at the floor.
"I don't know."
"I just..."
"I wish you didn't have to go through all that alone."
The other end of the call became silent.
Then she quietly replied,
"I don't think anyone could've stopped it."
Maybe she was right.
Maybe not.
But hearing those words made my heart heavier than
ever before.
The story still wasn't over.
She had told me how the relationship ended.
She had told me how she tried to survive after it.
Now...

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there was only one question left.
The question she had carried for months.
The question that had made her choose me as the
person she trusted.
And I knew...
she was about to ask it.
For several moments...
neither of us spoke.
Everything that needed to be said about the
relationship had already been said.
She had told me how they met.
How they slowly fell in love.
How they spent one and a half years together.
How misunderstandings entered their lives.
How another girl became part of the story.
How everything finally ended.
And how she spent months trying to put herself back
together.
The entire story...
had finally reached its end.
She took a slow breath.
Then, in a voice much softer than before, she asked,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm..."
"I've told you everything."
"There isn't anything I'm hiding anymore."
"I even told you the things I was ashamed to tell."
She paused.
Then quietly continued.
"So now..."
"Tell me honestly."
"Who was right in this relationship?"
"Me..."

"...or him?"

I looked at the floor beside my bed.

This was the question she had been carrying all this time.

The question that had probably kept her awake on countless nights.

I didn't want to answer quickly.

An answer given in a hurry could stay in someone's heart for years.

I slowly said,

"I've been thinking about that question ever since you started telling me everything."

She remained silent.

Waiting.

"I told you before..."

"I don't know what was happening inside his mind."

"So I can't judge every single decision he made."

"But..."

"...there is one thing I can say honestly."

She quietly whispered,

"What?"

"You genuinely loved him."

"You trusted him."

"You respected your own boundaries."

"You tried to explain yourself."

"And even when misunderstandings happened..."

"...you stayed."

"You wanted the relationship to work."

The other end of the call became completely silent.

I continued.

"But once he started another relationship..."

"...while still being with you..."

"I don't think that was fair."

"If someone no longer wants to continue a relationship..."

"...they should end it honestly."

"Starting another relationship before ending the first one..."

"...only hurts everyone involved."

I paused for a moment.

Then gently added,

"So..."

"From everything you've told me..."

"I don't think you were wrong for loving him."

"And I don't think you deserved what happened."

I heard her breathing become slightly unsteady.

For the first time that night...

she didn't try to hide her emotions.

She softly asked,

"So..."

"...you don't think everything was my fault?"

I answered without hesitation.

"No."

"Not at all."

"You made mistakes."

"So did he."

"Every relationship has mistakes."

"But betrayal..."

"...isn't the same as misunderstanding."

"They're different."

For a few seconds...

all I could hear was silence.

Then...

very quietly...

she started crying.

Not loudly.

Not uncontrollably.

Just soft tears that she had been holding back
throughout the entire conversation.

I didn't interrupt.

Sometimes...

people don't cry because they hear something new.

They cry because someone finally says the words they
have been needing to hear.

After a while, she spoke between tears.

"For months..."

"I kept blaming myself."

"I thought..."

"Maybe if I had been better..."

"Maybe if I had agreed to everything..."

"Maybe if I had changed..."

"...he would've stayed."

My heart sank.

I replied gently,

"Aashika..."

"If someone truly wants to stay..."

"...they don't stay because you've changed yourself."

"They stay because they choose you."

"And you should never feel guilty for protecting your
own boundaries."

"You had every right to say no to things you weren't
comfortable with."

She didn't reply immediately.

Instead...she quietly wiped away her tears.

Then she whispered,

"Thank you..."

"Nobody has ever listened to the whole story before
answering."

I smiled faintly.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

"That's because...", "I wanted to understand your story before judging it."

Another silence followed.

This one felt different.

Lighter.

Not because the pain had disappeared.

But because she was no longer carrying it completely alone.

After a minute, she softly said,

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"There's one more thing..."

I waited.

She continued.

"After everything that happened..."

"...I don't think I believe in love anymore."

Those words quietly settled between us.

I didn't answer immediately.

Because I knew...

those few sentences were about to change something inside me forever.

Chapter Twenty-one

The Promise Never Spoken

After she said those words...

"I don't think I believe in love anymore."

...the conversation fell silent.

Not because there was nothing left to say.

Because neither of us knew what should be said next.

I quietly held the phone against my ear.

Outside my window, the night continued as if nothing had happened.

Somewhere in the distance, a motorcycle passed by.

A dog barked.

Then everything became quiet again.

She spoke first.

"You know, Mithran..."

"I've been thinking a lot these past few months."

"About relationships."

"About people."

"About promises."

She stopped for a moment.

Then let out a slow sigh.

"I don't think I have the strength to go through something like that again."

I didn't interrupt.

She wasn't asking a question.

She was simply letting her heart speak.

"I don't want another relationship."

She said it calmly.

Without anger.

Without hatred.

Just...

with exhaustion.

It sounded less like a decision...

and more like someone who had run out of hope.

A few seconds later, she continued.

"I've lost faith in love."

"I don't know whether real love even exists anymore."

"I believed someone."

"I trusted someone."

"I imagined a future."

"And one day..."

"...everything disappeared."

I slowly closed my eyes.

Every sentence she spoke carried years of
disappointment.

She wasn't saying these things to make anyone feel
sorry for her.

She genuinely believed them.

That was what hurt the most.

She laughed quietly.

A tired laugh.

"If someone asks me about relationships now..."

"I'll probably tell them not to fall in love."

"They'll be happier."

I smiled sadly.

Not because I agreed.

Because I understood why she felt that way.

Pain has a strange way of convincing people that
tomorrow will always look like yesterday.

After another long silence, she softly whispered,

"And marriage..."

"I don't even want to think about it."

"I don't want it."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

"I don't want another person making promises."

"I don't want another beginning that could end the same way."

For a few moments...

I couldn't find a single word.

The girl who had once smiled while talking about her happiest memories...

was now speaking as though she had completely given up on the future.

It wasn't heartbreak anymore.

It was fear.

Fear of trusting again.

Fear of believing again.

Fear of losing again.

I quietly asked,

"Have you been thinking about this for a long time?"

She answered immediately.

"Every day."

"Since the breakup."

"I kept asking myself..."

""What if it happens again?""

""What if I trust someone again?""

""What if they leave too?""

"I don't think I can survive that twice."

The room around me felt unusually heavy.

I looked down at the floor.

For the first time in my life...

I wished I could remove someone's pain simply by listening.

But life doesn't work that way.

Some wounds heal slowly.

Some scars remain forever.

She spoke again.

"You know what hurts the most?"

I quietly replied,

"What?"

She answered in almost a whisper.

"I don't miss the relationship anymore."

"I miss the person I used to be before it ended."

"I miss smiling without pretending."

"I miss trusting people without being scared."

"I miss believing that love could last."

Those words stayed with me.

They weren't the words of someone who still wanted him back.

They were the words of someone mourning the version of herself that had disappeared.

I leaned back against the wall and slowly took a deep breath.

The conversation had already lasted for hours.

Neither of us had noticed the time.

Neither of us wanted to end it yet.

Because for the first time...

she wasn't carrying those memories alone.

She had finally shared them.

Every single one.

And I had been there...

from the first sentence to the last.

Without interrupting.

Without judging.

Simply listening.

For a long time...

neither of us spoke again.

Sometimes...

silence itself becomes the most honest conversation.

The silence between us lasted for almost a minute.

Neither of us wanted to end the call.
After sharing everything she had been carrying for so long...
it felt strange to suddenly return to ordinary conversations.
She softly asked,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm..."
"Do you think..."
"...I'll ever become normal again?"
The question caught me by surprise.
Not because I didn't expect it.
Because I could hear genuine fear behind it.
She wasn't asking whether she'd find another relationship.
She was asking whether she'd ever find herself again.
I thought for a few seconds before answering.
"I don't know how long it'll take."
"But I believe..."
"...one day you'll smile without forcing yourself."
"Maybe not today."
"Maybe not next month."
"But one day."
She quietly listened.
I continued.
"You're not the same person you were before."
"What happened has changed you."
"But that doesn't mean your life has ended."
"It just means..."
"...you're healing."
Another silence followed.
Then she softly laughed.
"You always speak so calmly."

I smiled.

"I don't know if I'm right."

"I'm just saying what I truly feel."

She whispered,

"I hope you're right."

"So do I."

After a few moments, she spoke again.

"I don't think I'll trust anyone again."

"I don't think I'll ever love another person."

"I don't even want to think about relationships."

"I just want peace."

Her words quietly settled inside my heart.

At that moment...

I realised something.

If I ever told her what I truly felt...

my confession wouldn't bring her happiness.

It wouldn't make her smile.

It wouldn't heal her.

Instead...

it would become another burden for someone who was already carrying too much.

She wasn't rejecting me.

She didn't even know I loved her.

She was simply speaking from her pain.

Every sentence came from a heart that had lost its faith.

And I understood that.

For the first time...

my own feelings didn't matter.

Her peace mattered more.

I gently replied,

"You don't have to decide anything now."

"You don't have to think about another relationship."

"You don't have to think about marriage."

"Just..."

"...take your time."

"Heal first."

"The future can wait."

She didn't reply immediately.

After a few seconds, she softly said,

"Thank you."

"You never forced me."

"You never judged me."

"You just listened."

"I really needed that."

A small smile appeared on my face.

"I'm glad you told me."

"I know it wasn't easy."

"I was actually scared."

She admitted.

"I thought..."

"...Maybe you'd think differently about me after hearing everything."

I answered without hesitation.

"No."

"Not even a little."

"You trusted someone."

"You loved someone."

"You got hurt."

"That doesn't change the kind of person you are."

She quietly let out a deep breath.

It almost sounded like relief.

As though she had finally placed down a weight she had been carrying for years.

The conversation slowly became lighter.

We spoke about ordinary things for a few minutes.

College.

Her studies.

Family.

Nothing emotional.

It felt as though both of us needed those simple conversations before ending the call.

After some time, she softly said,

"I think I should sleep."

"It's getting late."

I looked at the time.

Neither of us had realised how many hours had passed.

"Yeah..."

"You should."

Before ending the call, she said something that stayed with me forever.

"Thank you for listening."

"I don't think I'll ever forget this conversation."

I quietly smiled.

"You don't have to thank me."

"We're family."

"We're friends."

"You can tell me anything."

She softly replied,

"Hmm..."

"Good night, Mithran."

"Good night, Aashika."

The call ended.

The screen of my phone slowly turned black.

The room became completely silent.

But inside me...

another conversation had only just begun.

The call had ended.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

The screen of my phone slowly went dark.
For a few seconds...
I continued holding it against my ear.
Almost as if the conversation hadn't ended yet.
The room was completely silent.
Only the ceiling fan continued turning above me.
I slowly placed the phone beside my pillow.
Then leaned back against the wall.
I looked towards the window.
The night sky was empty.
The streetlights outside painted long shadows across
the road.
Everything looked exactly the same as it had a few
hours ago.
But somehow...
nothing felt the same anymore.
For the first time that night...
I allowed myself to think.
Not about her relationship.
Not about the boy.
Not about the breakup.
About myself.
I replayed the entire conversation from the beginning.
The way she hesitated before telling me.
The happiness in her voice while remembering her
first love.
The sadness when she spoke about the
misunderstandings.
The silence after saying,
"We broke up."
The fear in her voice when she said,
"I don't believe in love anymore."
Every sentence echoed inside my mind.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I quietly asked myself one question.
"Why did hearing all of this hurt so much?"
I already knew the answer.
I had known it for much longer than I wanted to admit.
I had simply refused to say it aloud.
I closed my eyes.
Then, for the first time in my life...
I stopped lying to myself.
Very softly...
almost like a whisper meant only for my own heart...
I admitted the truth.
I love Aashika.
The words never left my lips.
Nobody heard them.
Not my family.
Not my friends.
Not even Aashika.
Only I knew.
And somehow...
admitting it to myself hurt more than hiding it ever had.
I smiled.
A small, tired smile.
Not because I was happy.
Because everything finally made sense.
Why I always waited for her messages.
Why her late replies never made me angry.
Why choosing gifts for her felt more exciting than buying something for myself.
Why her happiness mattered more than my own.
Why hearing another person's love story had broken something inside me.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

It wasn't friendship.
It had never been just friendship.
Somewhere along the way...
without asking my permission...
my heart had quietly fallen in love.
I looked at the phone lying beside me.
Just a few minutes earlier...
the girl I loved had told me she no longer believed in
love.
She had said she never wanted another relationship.
She had said she didn't even want to think about
marriage.
Those weren't words spoken to reject me.
She didn't even know what I felt.
She was speaking from pain.
From a heart that was still trying to survive.
At that moment...
another thought entered my mind.
"What would happen if I told her the truth?"
I imagined it for only a second.
Not because I wanted to confess.
Because I wanted to understand.
Would she smile?
No.
Would she feel relieved?
No.
Would my confession heal her heartbreak?
No.
It would only place another weight onto someone
who had just begun putting hers down.
That realization made my decision surprisingly easy.
I slowly looked out of the window once more.
Then, without speaking...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I made a promise to myself.
If my love ever becomes another burden in her life...
I will never place it on her shoulders.
I will carry it myself.
No matter how long it takes.
No matter how painful it becomes.
It wasn't a promise made out of fear.
It wasn't because I lacked courage.
It was because...
at that moment...
her peace meant more to me than my confession.
If loving someone truly meant wanting the best for
them...
then perhaps...
this was my way of loving her.
Silently.
Without expecting anything in return.
I switched off the light.
The room disappeared into darkness.
I closed my eyes.
Sleep never came.
Instead...
I spent the entire night remembering every chapter of
our story.
From the little girl who fought with me over childish
things...
to the young woman who trusted me enough to tell
me the story of her broken heart.
Neither of us knew it then.
But that single phone call...
had quietly changed both of our lives.
For her...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

it was the night she finally shared the pain she had been carrying.

For me...

it was the night I accepted the love I would spend years hiding.

And somewhere beyond that silent promise...

two different futures had already begun to exist.

One...

where these feelings would remain forever unspoken.

And another...

where destiny would someday ask me the hardest question of my life.

Should I tell her... or let her go?

Part V — The Silent Years

Chapter Twenty-Two

A New Beginning for Her

A few days had passed since that long phone call.
The conversation where Aashika had finally told me
everything about her first love.

Her happiness.

Her heartbreak.

Her tears.

And the pain she had carried alone for so long.

After that night, I wondered whether things would
become awkward between us.

Maybe she would hesitate to call me again.

Maybe she would regret telling me everything.

Maybe every conversation from now on would feel
different.

But...

none of that happened.

A few days later, my phone rang.

It was Aashika.

For a second, I simply looked at the screen before
answering.

"Hello?"

"Hi."

Her voice sounded normal.

Not forced.

Not heavy.

Just... normal.

That one word quietly removed every fear I had been carrying.

We didn't talk about her breakup.

Neither of us mentioned it.

It wasn't because we were avoiding it.

It was because there was nothing more to say.

She had already trusted me with every memory.

Now...

she wanted life to move forward.

And I respected that.

Instead of talking about the past, she asked,

"What are you doing?"

"Nothing much."

"What about you?"

"I'm helping Amma."

I smiled.

Some things never changed.

No matter how busy she was, she always found herself helping her mother with something around the house.

While talking, I could hear vessels being moved in the background.

Sometimes she would pause in the middle of a sentence.

"Wait..."

"I'll call you after keeping this here."

A few seconds later, she would continue exactly where she had stopped.

Those little interruptions somehow made the conversation feel more real.

From that day onwards...

our conversations slowly returned to what they had always been.

Simple.

Comfortable.

Unplanned.

There was no need to search for topics.

Sometimes we spoke for fifteen minutes.

Sometimes for two hours.

Sometimes we stayed on the call even when neither of us had anything important to say.

I made one decision that day.

A decision she never knew about.

I would never ask about her past relationship again.

Not because I wasn't curious.

But because I didn't want to reopen a wound that had only just begun to heal.

If one day she wanted to talk about it again...

I would listen.

Until then...

I wanted to give her new conversations instead of old memories.

The days slowly settled into a familiar routine.

I attended college.

She attended school.

Whenever either of us found a little free time, one of us would call.

Sometimes I called first.

Sometimes she did.

There was no rule.

No expectation.

Only comfort.

One evening, while returning home from college, I received a message.

Aashika:

"Reached home?"

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I smiled without realizing it.

"Yes. Just now."

"Okay. Eat properly."

"You too."

Such ordinary messages.

Yet...

they somehow made ordinary days feel lighter.

Life didn't suddenly become perfect.

She was still healing.

I was still hiding feelings she knew nothing about.

But one thing had quietly returned between us.

Peace.

And for the first time in many months...

peace felt enough.

Weeks slowly passed.

Without either of us noticing...

our conversations became longer again.

The sadness that had once filled every pause in her voice slowly started disappearing.

Little by little...

her old self was returning.

One evening, she called me while I was walking back home from college.

"What are you doing?"

"Walking."

"Again?"

I laughed.

"I have to come home somehow."

She laughed too.

For a second...

it felt exactly like our old conversations.

No sadness.

No heavy silence.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Just two people talking about nothing important.
She slowly started sharing the small moments of her day again.
Sometimes she would tell me what happened at school.
Sometimes she would complain about homework.
Sometimes she would laugh about something one of her friends had said.
None of those stories were extraordinary.
But hearing her laugh while telling them...
made them special to me.
Whenever she laughed...
I found myself smiling too.
Not because the jokes were always funny.
Because hearing her happy again felt like a victory.
One that she didn't even know I was celebrating.
There were days when she would suddenly send me a picture of the sky.
Or a flower she had noticed.
Or the snacks she was eating.
Then she'd ask,
"What are you doing?"
I would reply with whatever I was doing at that moment.
Studying.
Watching a movie.
Cooking something.
Sometimes even a badly taken photo of what I had cooked.
She would immediately reply,
"You've improved."
I would proudly say,
"Of course."

Then she'd laugh.
Slowly...
our conversations stopped feeling careful.
Neither of us was choosing words anymore.
We simply spoke.
Exactly the way we always had.
One night, while talking over the phone, she suddenly
became quiet.
"What happened?"
I asked.
"Nothing."
"You suddenly stopped talking."
She smiled softly.
"I was just thinking."
"About what?"
She replied,
"You know..."
"I feel much better now."
Those five words stayed with me for the rest of the
night.
I didn't ask,
"Are you completely okay?"
Because healing doesn't happen all at once.
Some wounds become quieter before they disappear.
Instead, I simply said,
"I'm happy."
She laughed.
"You sound like an old man."
"And you sound like you're making fun of me."
"I am."
We both laughed.
That laugh...
felt different.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Not because it was louder.
Because it was genuine.
It wasn't hiding pain anymore.
It came naturally.
And hearing it made me realize something.
The girl who once said,
"I don't believe in love anymore."
was slowly beginning to believe in happiness again.
Maybe not in love.
Not yet.
But at least...
in tomorrow.
From that day onwards...
I stopped worrying about whether she was okay every
single minute.
Instead...
I started enjoying the little moments we shared.
A random call.
A silly joke.
A photo of the evening sky.
A message asking whether I had eaten.
Those ordinary moments quietly became the most
valuable part of my day.
Without realizing it...
she had started smiling more often.
And without telling anyone...
seeing that smile had quietly become my favourite
part of life.
As the weeks passed...
something quietly changed between us.
Not our conversations.
Not our friendship.
But the comfort we found in each other's presence.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

There was no need to message every minute.
There was no need to call every day.
Yet somehow...
we always found our way back to each other.
If something funny happened during my day...
she was one of the first people I wanted to tell.
If something happened at her school...
she'd tell me during our next call.
Sometimes it was something important.
Sometimes it was just a teacher saying something
funny.
Or her mother asking her to do another household
chore.
Those ordinary conversations slowly became part of
my everyday life.
Whenever I cooked something new...
I'd send her a picture.
She'd immediately reply,
"Looks good."
Sometimes she'd tease me.
"Did you really cook this?"
I'd laugh and send another picture from a different
angle.
"See? I actually did."
She'd finally reply,
"Okay, okay... I believe you."
Those little conversations never lasted more than a
few minutes.
But somehow...
they always stayed in my mind much longer.
There were evenings when neither of us had anything
to talk about.
Still...

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one of us would call.

We'd remain on the phone while doing our own work.

She'd be folding clothes.

I'd be completing assignments.

Sometimes...

five whole minutes would pass without either of us speaking.

Yet...

it never felt awkward.

It felt peaceful.

I slowly realised something.

Not every meaningful conversation needs words.

Sometimes...

knowing someone is still there is enough.

I never tried to impress her.

I never searched for romantic words.

I never hinted at what I felt.

After hearing everything she had gone through...

I had made a promise to myself.

I would never become another reason for her to feel pressured.

If my feelings stayed inside me forever...

that was okay.

As long as she could smile again.

There were moments when she thanked me for listening.

Moments when she said,

"I can tell you anything."

Every time she said those words...

my heart became both happy and heavy.

Happy...

because she trusted me.

Heavy...
because she trusted me only as the person who would
always understand her.
And honestly...
that was enough.
At least...
I wanted it to be enough.
One afternoon, while I was travelling back from
college, my phone vibrated.
It was her.
She didn't call.
She only sent one message.
"Reached college?"
I smiled and replied,
"Yes."
A few minutes later another message arrived.
"Okay... Study well."
I simply replied,
"You too."
Anyone else reading those messages would've thought
they were ordinary.
Maybe they were.
But to me...
they carried a strange warmth.
It wasn't romance.
It wasn't friendship alone.
It was care.
Quiet...
simple...
unspoken care.
Without noticing it...
she had become part of my daily routine.
Not because we planned it.

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Because it happened naturally.
If an entire day passed without talking to her...
it felt incomplete.
Not empty.
Just...
different.
She never asked me to stay.
I never asked her to.
Yet...we always stayed.
Call after call.
Message after message.
Day after day.
Looking back now...
I think this was the happiest period of our friendship.
'There were no misunderstandings.
No hidden pain between us.
No difficult conversations.
Just two people...
slowly becoming an irreplaceable part of each other's
everyday life.
She found someone she could always rely on.
And without ever saying it aloud...
I found the person my heart had quietly chosen.

Chapter Twenty-Three

Becoming Best Friends

Days quietly turned into weeks.
Weeks slowly turned into months.
Without either of us realizing it...
talking to each other had become part of our everyday
routine.

There was no fixed time.

No fixed reason.

Sometimes she called me after coming back from school.

Sometimes I called her after returning from college.

Sometimes a conversation began with a simple,

"What are you doing?"

And somehow...

three hours would pass before either of us noticed.

One evening, while I was travelling back from college, my phone vibrated.

It was a WhatsApp message.

Aashika:

"Finished college?"

I smiled before replying.

"Just got into the bus."

A few seconds later...

"Did you eat?"

"Not yet."

"Go home and eat first."

"Yes, Amma."

Immediately...

another message appeared.

"Idiot "

I laughed quietly to myself.

The people around me in the bus had no idea why I was smiling at my phone.

Those little conversations slowly became my favourite part of the day.

They weren't romantic.

They weren't dramatic.

They were simply...

comfortable.

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Sometimes we talked about college.
I complained about assignments.
Internal marks.
Placement training.
Friends doing funny things in class.
She would patiently listen.
Sometimes she'd laugh.
Sometimes she'd simply say,
"You'll somehow manage."
Somehow...
hearing those words from her always made me feel
calmer.
She also shared stories from her school.
Teachers.
Exams.
Friends.
Projects.
Sometimes she'd complain that she was tired after
helping her mother with housework.
I'd tease her.
"You work more than all of us."
She'd proudly reply,
"Someone has to."
There were days when we had absolutely nothing
important to say.
Still...
one of us would call.
The conversation would begin with,
"So..."
"What?"
"Nothing."
"Then why did you call?"
"I don't know."

She'd laugh.

"So you're wasting my time?"

"I thought you liked wasting time with me."

She'd stay silent for two seconds before laughing again.

Sometimes we'd argue over the smallest things.

Not real arguments.

Just childish ones.

Who forgot to reply.

Who ended the call first yesterday.

Who was busier.

Who took longer to answer messages.

Within minutes...

we'd forget what we were even arguing about.

Late-night conversations slowly became normal again.

Not every night.

But often enough.

Sometimes we'd start talking around ten o'clock.

Then suddenly one of us would look at the time.

"It's already one?"

Neither of us knew where those hours disappeared.

We simply talked.

About everything.

About nothing.

One night, she suddenly asked,

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"If we didn't have phones..."

"Do you think we'd still talk this much?"

I laughed.

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I'd have to come all the way to Kerala every day."

She laughed so loudly that I had to move the phone away from my ear.

"You're impossible."

After the laughter settled...

she quietly said,

"I'm glad we talk."

I didn't know why...

but those four words stayed in my heart for a long time.

I simply replied,

"Me too."

Neither of us realised it then.

But somewhere between those ordinary calls...

those random jokes...

and those meaningless conversations...

we had quietly become the most constant part of each other's everyday life.

And without either of us noticing...

our friendship had grown stronger than ever before.

As the months passed...

our conversations slowly became different.

Not longer.

Not shorter.

Just...

deeper.

Without realizing it, we had stopped talking only about college or school.

We started talking about life itself.

One evening she called me while arranging clothes.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

I don't know what course I should choose after school."

I smiled.

"You've been thinking about it again?"

"Every day."

"What do you think?"

For the next thirty minutes...

we spoke only about her future.

The colleges she liked.

The courses she was interested in.

The things she was afraid of.

I wasn't giving perfect advice.

I simply listened and told her what I honestly thought.

A few days later...

it was my turn.

I called her after coming back from college.

"I'm tired."

"What happened?"

"Assignments..."

"Placement training..."

"And internal submissions."

She laughed.

"So... normal college life?"

"Unfortunately."

She laughed again.

"Don't worry."

"You'll finish all of it."

Somehow...

those simple words always gave me more confidence than they probably should have.

As time went on...

there was hardly anything we couldn't talk about.

Family.
Studies.
Cooking.
Movies.
Songs.
Future dreams.
Random childhood memories.
Even the smallest problems.
If something good happened...
one of us would tell the other.
If something bad happened...
we did the same.
Sometimes she would call just to complain.
"Amma made me clean the whole house."
I laughed.
"You always complain..."
"...but you still finish everything."
"What choice do I have?"
"None."
"Exactly."
Some evenings...
she would suddenly become quiet.
I had learned not to ask too many questions
immediately.
Instead, I'd simply wait.
After a few moments...
she would start talking on her own.
"Today wasn't a good day."
"What happened?"
Then she would tell me everything.
Sometimes it was because of school.
Sometimes because of stress.
Sometimes there wasn't any particular reason.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

She just wanted someone to listen.
I noticed something.
She never had to think before calling me anymore.
If something happened...
my phone would ring.
It didn't matter whether it was good news or bad news.
I had quietly become one of the first people she wanted to tell.
I also stopped hiding the small parts of my own life.
I told her about college projects.
The funny things my friends did.
The food I tried cooking.
Sometimes I'd even send her pictures.
She would immediately reply,
"This actually looks nice."
I'd proudly answer,
"I told you I've improved."
She'd tease me,
"I'll believe it only after tasting it."
I laughed.
"Deal."
There were days when we dreamed about the future.
Nothing too serious.
Just simple conversations.
"What do you want to do after college?"
"What kind of job do you want?"
"Where do you want to live?"
"What places do you want to visit?"
Neither of us realized how naturally those conversations came.
There was no hesitation anymore.
One night...

while we were talking about completely random things...
she suddenly said,
"You know something?"
"What?"
"I don't think I've told anyone all these things as much as I've told you."
I stayed quiet.
Then smiled.
"I'll take that as a compliment."
"It is."
That one sentence stayed with me for days.
Not because it made me feel special.
Because it reminded me how much trust had quietly grown between us.
It hadn't happened in one day.
Or one month.
It had grown through every late-night call.
Every small joke.
Every ordinary message.
Every time one of us simply listened without judging the other.
Looking back...
I think trust was never something we built intentionally.
It simply happened.
One conversation at a time.
And before either of us noticed...
telling each other everything had become the most natural thing in the world.
Without either of us noticing...
something had quietly changed.
It wasn't our conversations.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

It wasn't the amount of time we spent talking.

It was...

who we had become in each other's lives.

Whenever something happened...

whether it was something happy or something stressful...

my phone would ring.

Sometimes she would call.

Sometimes she'd simply send,

"Can I call?"

I'd always reply,

"Yeah."

A few seconds later...

my phone would start ringing.

One evening, I answered her call.

"What happened?"

"Nothing..."

"You don't call saying 'nothing.' Tell me."

She laughed.

"I just wanted to talk."

I smiled.

"That's a better reason."

Some days she would tell me about a funny incident at school.

Some days she'd complain about assignments.

Sometimes she'd tell me about a small argument at home.

Nothing serious.

Just everyday life.

The kind of things people usually share only with someone they feel comfortable with.

Whenever she asked,

"What do you think?"

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I never tried to give perfect advice.
I simply answered honestly.
Sometimes she'd agree.
Sometimes she'd laugh and say,
"No... I'll do it my way."
And somehow...
both of us were okay with that.
She wasn't calling me because I always had the right
answers.
She was calling because she knew I'd listen before
answering.
There were also days when I called her first.
Not because something important had happened.
Just because I wanted to hear her voice.
If she didn't answer immediately...
I never became angry.
I knew she was probably helping her mother.
Or studying.
Or busy with something at home.
Eventually...
she would call back.
"Sorry..."
"I was busy."
"It's okay."
"What were you doing?"
And another conversation would begin.
One afternoon...
while I was sitting in my college canteen...
my phone vibrated.
It was her.
She didn't call.
She simply sent,
"I wanted to tell you something first."

I smiled.
"Tell me."
She immediately typed everything that had happened
that day.
While reading those messages...
I realised something.
Whenever something happened in her life...
she wanted me to know.
Not because she had to.
Because it had become natural.
I never thought of it as something special.
At least...
not at that time.
I simply felt happy that she trusted me.
Looking back now...
I understand what those moments meant.
Trust isn't built in one conversation.
It's built in hundreds of ordinary moments.
One night she suddenly said,
"You know..."
"Hmm?"
"If something happens..."
"you're one of the first people I think of calling."
For a second...
I forgot what to say.
Not because those words sounded romantic.
They weren't.
They were something much simpler.
Much purer.
She trusted me.
Completely.
I quietly replied,
"You can call anytime."

She laughed.

"Even at three in the morning?"

"If it's important..."

"Yes."

"What if it's not important?"

I laughed.

"Then I'll complain the next morning."

She laughed so much that she couldn't finish her sentence.

That laughter stayed with me long after the call ended.

Not because I thought she loved me.

I knew she didn't.

She had never given me any reason to think that.

She saw me as her cousin.

Her closest friend.

Someone she could always depend on.

And honestly...

I never wanted to destroy that trust by expecting something she had never promised.

So I continued being exactly what she needed.

Someone who listened.

Someone who stayed.

Someone who never made her feel uncomfortable.

If my love had to remain hidden...

then so be it.

Because at that moment...

being her safest person meant far more to me than becoming the person she loved.

And without either of us realizing it...

that silent promise became the strongest part of our friendship.

Chapter Twenty-Four

The Love That Stayed Hidden

By then...
I had already accepted one truth.
I loved her.
Not because of one moment.
Not because of one conversation.
Not because she had done something extraordinary.
It had happened quietly...
over the years.
Through childhood memories.
Late-night calls.
Random messages.
Small gifts.
Shared laughter.
And countless ordinary days.
Nothing around me had changed.
But somehow...
everything reminded me of her.
Whenever I saw something she liked...
my first thought was,
"She'll like this."
Whenever something funny happened...
I wanted to tell her first.
Whenever my phone vibrated...
I hoped it was her message.
Sometimes I laughed at myself.
"Why am I overthinking this much?"
Then I'd put my phone aside...
only to check it again a few minutes later.

It was silly.
But it had become normal.
I never told anyone.
Not my friends.
Not my family.
Not even my sister.
'These feelings stayed where they had always been.
Inside me.
'There was one sentence...
that never left my mind.
"I don't want another relationship."
She had said it months ago.
But I remembered it every single day.
Whenever my heart wanted to tell her everything...
that one sentence stopped me.
I never imagined confessing anymore.
Not because I was afraid of rejection.
Because I respected her pain.
If she had finally found peace...
I didn't want to become another reason for her to
overthink.
So...
I decided something.
Whenever I was around her...
I would never let my feelings become visible.
Instead...
I'd simply make her laugh whenever I could.
If she smiled...
that was enough.
If she was happy...
I was happy too.
A few weeks later...
my sister and I visited Kerala again.

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Like always...
we spent time at Aashika's house.
Everyone talked together.
We laughed.
Took a few photos.
Shared meals.
Spent the evening talking about ordinary things.
Nothing extraordinary happened.
Nothing dramatic happened.
And Maybe...
that was what made those memories beautiful.
While everyone else simply enjoyed another family
visit...
I quietly enjoyed every ordinary moment beside her.
Without expecting anything.
Without asking for anything.
Without telling her anything.
At that time...
I believed these peaceful days would continue forever.
I didn't know...
that life had already begun counting the days toward
July 22.

Chapter Twenty-Five

Before July 22

January:

January arrived quietly.

For our family...

it was a month filled with happiness.

Aashika's elder sister was getting married.

Everyone in our family was excited about the wedding.

Just like every family function...

our relatives gathered together after a long time.

The house was filled with laughter, conversations, decorations, and people running from one place to another.

The moment I reached the wedding hall...

my eyes automatically searched for only one person.

Aashika.

I didn't even realize I was looking for her.

It had become a habit.

After a few moments...

I finally saw her.

For a second...

I completely forgot everything around me.

She was wearing a beautiful traditional dress.

I had seen her many times before.

But that day...

she looked different.

Not because of the dress alone.

There was something about the way she smiled while helping everyone around her.

She looked...
beautiful.
Much more beautiful than I had ever seen her before.
I stood there for a few seconds.
Just watching.
Not staring.
Simply admiring.
Then I smiled to myself.
"She looks really happy today."
That thought alone made me happy.
Unlike the rest of us...
she hardly had any time to sit down.
It was her sister's wedding.
She was busy from morning till night.
Helping relatives.
Welcoming guests.
Carrying things.
Answering everyone who called her name.
Every few minutes...
someone would ask,
"Aashika..."
And she'd immediately run to help.
I wanted to talk to her.
But every time I thought about walking towards her...
someone else called her away.
So instead...
I quietly helped wherever I could.
If someone asked me to move chairs...
I did it.
If they needed decorations arranged...
I helped.
If someone wanted water...
I brought it.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

They were small jobs.
Nothing important.
But helping somehow made me feel like I was part of
the happiness around us.
Sometimes...
our eyes met from opposite sides of the hall.
She'd smile for a second.
Then another relative would call her again.
And she'd disappear into the crowd.
That was our conversation for most of the function.
Just small smiles.
Nothing more.
Hours passed.
The wedding slowly came to an end.
Guests began leaving.
The house finally became a little quieter.
For the first time that entire day...
I saw her sitting alone for a few minutes.
She looked tired.
Probably because she had been on her feet since
morning.
My heart immediately started another battle.
"Should I ask..."
"Or should I just leave it?"
I looked at my phone.
Then looked at her again.
I had been thinking about one thing the entire day.
A selfie.
Not because I wanted to post it anywhere.
Not because I wanted to show anyone.
I simply wanted one memory from that day.
But asking her...
felt much harder than it should have.

I walked a few steps towards her.
Stopped.
Turned back.
Walked again.
Stopped once more.
I laughed at myself.
"Why am I this shy?"
Finally...
before I could change my mind again...
I walked up to her.
"Aashika..."
She looked up.
"Hmm?"
I hesitated for a second.
Then quietly asked,
"Can we... take a selfie?"
There was a short silence.
Then she smiled.
"Of course."
Just like that.
As if it was the simplest question in the world.
We stood next to each other.
I opened the camera.
For some reason...
my hands were shaking slightly.
She noticed.
"Why are you so nervous?"
I laughed awkwardly.
"I don't know."
She smiled again.
"Just take the photo."
Click.
Then another.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

And one more.
That was all.
Only a few seconds.
But somehow...
those few seconds became one of my favourite
memories.
After taking the selfies...
we sat and talked for a while.
Nothing serious.
Just ordinary conversations.
She asked about my studies.
I asked about hers.
We laughed about how tired everyone looked after
the function.
It felt peaceful.
Natural, Comfortable.
Before leaving...
I helped with a few more small works around the hall.
Carrying things.
Arranging chairs.
Helping relatives pack up.
Nothing extraordinary.
Just doing whatever I could.
Every now and then...
I'd see her walking past.
Still smiling.
Still busy.
Still being herself.
Around the same time...
there was another small change in my life.
I had started talking to a girl from my school...
someone I had once called my crush.
We had recently begun speaking again.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Our conversations were friendly. Normal.
And they continued for some time.
But no matter how much we talked...
I noticed something strange.
Whenever something good happened...
the first person I wanted to tell...
was still Aashika.
Whenever I smiled...
I unconsciously wondered what she'd say.
Whenever I remembered the wedding...
I didn't think about the crowd.
Or the decorations.
Or the celebrations.
I remembered only one thing.
A shy boy...
finally gathering enough courage...
to ask for a simple selfie.
And a girl...
smiling as though it had never been a difficult
question at all.

May:

A few months passed after the wedding.
Life slowly returned to its usual routine.
My first semester examinations had started.
Every day was almost the same.
Wake up.
Revise.
Write the exam.
Come back home.
Sleep.
Then prepare for the next subject.
Among all the exams...

the one I was thinking about the most was
Mathematics.
It was scheduled for Monday.
I wanted to score well.
So naturally...
I planned to spend the weekend revising.
But...
life had something else planned.
One evening...
my parents told me,
"We're going to Kerala on Sunday."
I looked at them in confusion.
"Now?"
"There is a housewarming function at your uncle's
house."
Immediately, the first thing that came to my mind
wasn't the function.
It was my Maths exam.
"But my exam is on Monday."
"We'll come back before then."
After thinking for a while...
I agreed.
On Sunday morning...
we started our journey to Kerala.
The roads were long.
The weather was pleasant.
After a few hours...
we finally reached my uncle's new house.
The function had already begun.
Relatives were everywhere.
Children were running around.
Everyone was busy greeting one another.
Aashika and her family had arrived two days earlier.

When I saw her...
she smiled.
I smiled back.
That was how almost every meeting between us
started.
Simple.
Without any awkwardness.
Even after meeting...
we didn't speak much in the beginning.
That was always my problem.
Whenever I met her in person after a long time...
I never knew how to start a conversation.
I always had a strange hesitation.
Not because I was uncomfortable around her.
But because I became unusually quiet whenever she
was standing in front of me.
After some time...
that hesitation slowly disappeared.
Just like always.
We started talking normally.
About college.
About school.
About the journey.
About random things happening around the house.
Nothing serious.
Just another ordinary family gathering.
The afternoon passed quickly.
Soon...
it was time for Aashika's family to leave.
They had come by car.
Before leaving...
we spoke for a few more minutes.
Then she waved goodbye.

Their car slowly disappeared from the street.
Our family had planned to stay until night.
Everything was going according to plan.
Until...
an argument suddenly broke out between my father
and my uncle.
I didn't know how it started.
But within a few minutes...
the atmosphere completely changed.
Instead of staying...
we decided to leave immediately.
We left the function much earlier than expected.
Since we had come out so suddenly...
there wasn't any transport available immediately.
So...
all of us waited at the bus stand.
For a long time.
The road was unusually quiet.
Buses came and went.
But ours hadn't arrived yet.
Finally...
our bus came.
My parents and my sister had sleeper seats.
I had only a seater.
It didn't really matter to me.
I was just thinking about reaching home on time.
Because the next morning...
I had my Mathematics examination.
The journey continued through the night.
I barely slept.
Early the next morning...
we finally reached home.
I went inside...

slept for barely two hours...
woke up...
got ready...
and left for college.
The exam went surprisingly well.
While writing it...
I completely forgot about the previous day's journey.
Once it was over...
I finally felt relaxed.
The semester examinations were almost behind me.
A few days later...
another trip was waiting for me.
On 27th May...
my sister and I travelled to Kerala.
Unlike the Kerala trip...
this journey wasn't rushed.
It felt peaceful.
Comfortable.
Almost like coming to a second home.
As soon as we reached...
Aashika welcomed us with the same familiar smile.
For the next few days...
the three of us spent most of our time together.
Sometimes it was just me...
my sister...
and Aashika.
Sometimes...
her mother joined us as well.
We went to different places around Kerala.
Walked through shopping streets.
Visited malls.
Stopped for snacks whenever someone felt hungry.
Sometimes...

we didn't even have a destination.
We simply went wherever everyone felt like going.
Those outings weren't extraordinary.
No dramatic moments.
No unforgettable confessions.
Just ordinary family memories.
The kind of memories people rarely realise they're
creating while they're living them.
Looking back now...
I think those peaceful days became special only
because I didn't know what was waiting for me in the
month that followed.
At that time...
July was simply another month.
I had no idea...
it was about to become the month that would change
my life forever.

July:

By the time July arrived...
my semester examinations had already ended.
College finally gave me a small break.
Without thinking too much...
my sister and I packed our bags once again.
Our destination...
Kerala.
Unlike every previous visit...
this trip felt different.
Not because anything extraordinary was waiting for
us.
But because we finally had enough time to simply
enjoy being there.
The moment we reached Kerala...
everything immediately felt familiar.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

The roads.
The weather.
The house.
Even the smell of the evening air somehow reminded
me that I was back.
It had slowly started feeling like a second home.
The next few days passed peacefully.
There were no plans.
No schedule.
No urgency.
Every morning...
we would wake up late.
Eat breakfast together.
Then decide where to go.
Sometimes it was a mall.
Sometimes a nearby shopping street.
Sometimes nowhere at all.
Some days...
staying at home and talking together felt better than
going outside.
Those eight days became one of the happiest periods
of my life.
Not because something unforgettable happened every
day.
But because nothing bad happened.
Everything felt peaceful.
Simple.
Comfortable.
One night...
around eleven o'clock...
someone suddenly said,
"Let's go eat ice cream."
No one refused.

Within a few minutes...
all of us were ready.
Me.
My sister.
Aashika.
Her sister.
And her brother-in-law.
The roads were almost empty.
The city looked completely different at midnight.
Shops were slowly closing.
Street lights reflected on the roads.
The weather was cool.
Everything felt calm.
We reached an ice cream shop.
Everyone ordered something different.
Then we stood outside...
laughing...
talking...
and teasing one another while eating.
There was nothing romantic about that night.
It was simply a family outing.
But somehow...
those ordinary moments stayed in my memory
forever.
While everyone else was talking...
I quietly looked around.
Then looked at Aashika.
She was laughing at something her sister had said.
Seeing her genuinely happy somehow made me smile
too.
I never told her that.
I simply stood there...
enjoying the moment.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

By the time we reached home...
it was already very late.
Most people would've gone straight to sleep.
But not us.
Someone brought out UNO cards.
Immediately...
everyone gathered around.
The game began.
Nobody cared who won.
The fun came from accusing each other of cheating.
Laughing whenever someone got a +4.
Pretending to be angry after losing.
Every few minutes...
someone would burst into laughter.
Time quietly disappeared.
When someone finally looked at the clock...
it was almost two in the morning.
We all looked at each other and laughed.
"No wonder we're sleepy."
That night...
everyone slept in the same room.
My sister slept beside Aashika.
I lay down nearby.
Within a few minutes...
everyone else had fallen asleep.
The room became completely quiet.
I looked towards the ceiling.
Then slowly closed my eyes.
A strange thought crossed my mind.
"If life could stay like this forever..."
For the first time in a long while...
I wasn't overthinking.
I wasn't worrying.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I wasn't afraid of tomorrow.
I was simply happy.
Those eight days passed much faster than I wanted.
Soon...
it was time to return to college.
I had taken five days of leave.
While I was enjoying Kerala...
my phone kept ringing.
It was my class teacher.
Again.
And again.
Every time I looked at the screen...
I smiled helplessly.
"Mam... I'm in Kerala."
There wasn't much I could do.
After returning home...
I immediately went back to college.
There wasn't enough time to rest.
Classes had already begun.
Soon after...
placement training started.
For the next eight days...
my routine completely changed again.
Morning.
College.
Training.
Assignments.
Home.
Sleep.
Repeat.
Even though I was busy...
my mind often travelled back to Kerala.
To those peaceful eight days.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

To the midnight ice cream.
To the laughter around the UNO cards.
To the simple conversations.
Without realizing it...
I had already started missing them.
One evening...
after placement training ended...
I called Aashika.
After talking for a while...
I casually asked,
"Can I come to Kerala again... before your college
opens?"
There was a small pause.
Then she happily replied,
"That's great... you can come."
Those words immediately made me smile.
But...
my overthinking mind never allowed happiness to
stay simple.
After a few seconds...
I asked another question.
"Your mother and father... didn't say anything about
me coming?"
For a moment...
I wondered whether I had asked something
unnecessary.
She answered almost immediately.
"No."
"They'll actually be happy if you come."
"They like having you here."
For a few seconds...
I couldn't say anything.
That single sentence stayed inside my heart.

Not because it meant something romantic.
Because it made me feel accepted.
It made me feel like their home had slowly become
another place where I belonged.
Without thinking twice...
I decided.
This time...
I would travel to Kerala alone.
For the first time.
Not with my parents.
Not with my sister.
Just me.
I packed my bag.
Boarded the bus.
And started another journey towards the place that
had unknowingly become the happiest part of my
holidays.
The first four days of that visit were beautiful.
Peaceful.
Exactly the way I had imagined.
We went street shopping together.
Walked through crowded markets.
Visited malls.
Spent hours looking at things we never intended to
buy.
Sometimes we bought small things.
Sometimes we simply walked and talked.
Neither of us cared.
Being together was enough.
One evening...
I taught her how to ride.
She sat in front.
I sat behind her.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Holding only the handlebar behind the seat.
Never her shoulder.
Never her hand.
Never her waist.
Because I already knew something about her.
She didn't like being touched.
Not by friends.
Not even comfortably by family.
I respected that without her ever needing to remind me.
She slowly tried balancing.
Stopped.
Started again.
Laughed whenever she made a mistake.
I quietly guided her.
"Slowly..."
"Don't panic."
"Look ahead."
Little by little...
she became more confident.
Seeing her learn made me genuinely happy.
At that moment...
I didn't know that these peaceful days were quietly approaching their end.
Because July 17...
was only one evening away.
The first four days passed so peacefully...
that I honestly believed the rest of the trip would be the same.
There were no misunderstandings.
No arguments.
No sadness.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Nothing that made me think something was about to change.

If someone had told me then...

that these would become the last carefree days before everything changed...

I would've never believed them.

Then...

July 17 arrived.

Like every other evening...

everyone gathered together after dinner.

Instead of watching television...

I brought out a pack of cards.

Not UNO.

A different one.

One that meant a little more to me.

A few months earlier...

during my college days...

my friends and I used to play UNO almost every day.

After playing it so many times...

I started imagining my own version.

Different colours.

Different designs.

A few extra power cards.

Some small rule changes.

Slowly...

that imagination became reality.

I designed it.

Printed it.

And named it...

"YouKnow."

It was something I had created myself.

I was proud of it.

Not because it was perfect.

Because it was mine.
When I came to Kerala...
I had brought that card game with me.
I wanted everyone to play it.
Especially Aashika.
I wanted to see whether she'd enjoy the game I had
created.
That night...
we all sat together.
The cards were shuffled.
Everyone learned the rules.
At first...
everything felt exactly like the nights before.
Laughter.
Small arguments.
People accusing each other of cheating.
Celebrating whenever someone made another person
draw cards.
The room was filled with noise.
Just the way family game nights usually are.
Aashika also played.
She smiled.
She laughed.
She teased everyone whenever they lost.
Watching her enjoy something I had created...
made me strangely happy.
I didn't say anything.
I simply kept playing.
After a while...
her phone vibrated.
She picked it up.
Looked at the screen.
And smiled.

I didn't think much about it.
People receive messages all the time.
The game continued.
A few minutes later...
another notification appeared.
Again...
she looked down.
Again...
she smiled.
Then she quickly typed something.
Placed the phone beside her.
And continued playing.
I still didn't think much about it.
But slowly...
the notifications became more frequent.
Every few minutes...
her phone lit up.
She would unlock it.
Read the message.
Smile.
Type a reply.
Then come back to the game.
Without realizing it...
I started noticing something.
Her attention wasn't on the cards anymore.
It was somewhere else.
Sometimes...
it even became her turn before she realised everyone
was waiting.
Someone would say,
"Aashika..."
"It's your turn."
She'd immediately look up.

"Oh... sorry."

Then she'd play a card.

A minute later...

her phone would light up again.

The game continued.

But...

it didn't feel the same anymore.

For the first time that night...

my mind started asking questions.

"Who is she talking to?"

I immediately answered myself.

"It doesn't matter."

The game continued.

Another message.

Another smile.

Another reply.

"Maybe it's just one of her friends."

A few more minutes passed.

She smiled again while reading something.

This time...

she even laughed quietly to herself.

I looked at my cards.

But I wasn't thinking about the game anymore.

Without realizing it...

my attention had shifted completely towards her.

Then...

another thought quietly entered my mind.

"Why is she smiling like that?"

I hated that question the moment it appeared.

Because I knew exactly where it was leading.

I tried pulling myself back into the game.

Focused on my cards.

Played another turn.

Pretended everything was normal.
But my eyes kept drifting towards her.
Not intentionally.
They simply did.
Every few minutes...
her phone lit up.
Every few minutes...
she smiled.
Something inside me slowly became uncomfortable.
Not angry.
Not yet.
Just...
uneasy.
I told myself again,
"You're overthinking."
"Stop."
"She's allowed to text anyone."
"Don't be stupid."
For a few minutes...
those thoughts worked.
I became normal again.
Then...
another notification appeared.
She immediately picked up her phone.
This time...
instead of placing it back on the floor...
she continued typing for a longer time.
The game continued without her.
Someone called her.
"Aashika..."
She looked up.
"Oh..."
"I forgot."

She laughed.
Played one card.
Then looked back at her phone.
At that moment...
something changed inside me.
Not because she was texting someone.
But because...
for the first time since I had arrived...
I felt invisible.
The cards were still in my hands.
People were still talking around me.
The room was still full of laughter.
But somehow...
everything around me became strangely quiet.
I wasn't jealous because she had a phone.
I wasn't upset because she was chatting.
I was hurt because...
the person who had laughed with me for four days...
was now smiling at someone else...
while sitting right beside me.
I still didn't know who that boy was.
I didn't know why they were talking.
I didn't know anything.
And Maybe...
that was exactly what frightened me.
The game slowly lost its excitement.
At least for me.
I continued playing.
But my mind had already left the room.
It had become trapped inside questions...
that had no answers.
After some more time...
Aashika quietly placed her cards on the floor.

"I'm feeling sleepy."
"You all continue."
She smiled politely...
stood up...
and walked towards her room.
Within a few seconds...
she disappeared.
The room suddenly felt different.
The game continued.
Everyone else kept laughing.
Talking.
Playing.
But I couldn't enjoy it anymore.
I tried.
I genuinely tried.
But my heart refused to return to the game.
That night...
without anyone realizing it...
the happiest trip of my life...
had quietly begun turning into the most painful
memory I would ever carry.
That night...
I couldn't continue playing.
My hands were still holding the cards.
But my mind wasn't in the game anymore.
Everyone else was still laughing.
Talking.
Playing another round.
Nothing had changed for them.
But for me...
something had quietly broken.
I don't know why it affected me so much.
She hadn't done anything wrong.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

She wasn't hiding her phone.
She wasn't trying to hurt me.
She was simply talking to someone.
Yet...
my heart refused to understand something that my
mind already knew.
After a few more rounds...
I quietly kept my cards on the floor.
"I'll sleep."
Nobody questioned me.
Everyone thought I was simply tired.
Maybe...
I wanted them to think that.
I went into the room.
Switched off the light beside me.
Lay down on the bed.
Closed my eyes.
Sleep never came.
Every time I closed my eyes...
I saw the same scene again.
Her phone lighting up.
Her smiling.
Typing.
Smiling again.
For some reason...
that smile kept replaying inside my head.
I turned to the other side.
Looked at the ceiling.
Closed my eyes again.
Nothing changed.
Then...
the overthinking started.
It always began quietly.

One question.

Then another.

Then another.

Until I couldn't stop it anymore.

"Who is he?"

"Is he just a friend?"

"Why was she smiling so much?"

"Have they been talking for a long time?"

"Did she smile like that while talking to me?"

"Am I just overthinking?"

Every answer I gave myself created another question.

The more I tried stopping my thoughts...

the faster they came back.

Around me...

everyone was sleeping peacefully.

The room was completely silent.

Only the ceiling fan continued turning above us.

I slowly looked around.

My sister was asleep.

Aashika had already gone to sleep.

The entire house was quiet.

Only I remained awake.

For the first time in years...

I cried without making a sound.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

I simply covered my face with my pillow...

so that nobody would hear me.

I wasn't crying because she was talking to another boy.

I wasn't even sure who he was.

I was crying because...

until that night...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I had never realised how much she meant to me.
That night...
I finally understood something.
Jealousy doesn't always come from possessiveness.
Sometimes...
it comes from fear.
Fear of slowly losing someone who had unknowingly
become your entire world.
Morning arrived much sooner than I wanted.
I don't remember sleeping at all.
Maybe I slept for a few minutes.
Maybe I didn't sleep at all.
I only remember opening my eyes...
feeling exhausted.
When I came out of the room...
everyone else was already awake.
The house looked exactly the same as every other
morning.
Someone was making breakfast.
Someone was watching television.
Someone was talking on the phone.
Life had continued normally.
Aashika was there too.
She looked at me.
"Gooooood morning..."
she said with a small smile.
I looked at her.
For a second...
I wanted to answer exactly the way I always did.
Instead...
I simply replied,
"Morning."
Nothing more.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

She probably noticed.
Maybe she didn't.
She didn't ask anything.
Neither did I.
'That day...
our conversations became unusually short.
She spoke only when necessary.
I replied only when necessary.
'There wasn't any argument.
'There wasn't any misunderstanding.
'There wasn't even any discussion.
Only...
silence.
'The strange thing was...
neither of us tried to break it.
I kept waiting for her to ask,
"What happened?"
She never did.
Maybe...
she was waiting for me to start talking first.
I never did.
Days passed.
July 18.
July 19.
July 20.
July 21.
'Then...
July 22.
Every day looked normal from the outside.
We ate together.
Sat in the same house.
Walked past each other.
But the conversations we usually had...

never happened.

Sometimes...

our eyes met.

Then both of us quietly looked away.

Neither of us knew how to return to the way things
had been just a few days earlier.

And because neither of us took the first step...
the silence slowly became heavier than any argument
could have been.

July 22.

The day I had to return home.

My bus was scheduled for the night.

I packed my bag slowly.

Much slower than usual.

Not because packing took time.

Because somewhere inside me...

I didn't want the trip to end like this.

Before leaving...

I quietly looked around the house one last time.

Everything was exactly the same.

Yet...

nothing felt the same anymore.

The happiest trip of my life...

had become the quietest goodbye I had ever
experienced.

The time I had been avoiding...
finally arrived.

July 22.

My last day in Kerala.

I packed my bag quietly.

Folded my clothes.

Checked my charger.

Kept everything inside my backpack.

The room looked exactly the same as the day I had arrived.

Only...

I wasn't the same person anymore.

Every previous time I had visited Kerala...
leaving had always been difficult.

But this time...

it felt different.

This time...

I wasn't only leaving a city.

I was leaving behind a silence that neither of us had
tried to break.

Throughout the day...

we hardly spoke.

Not because we were angry.

Not because we hated each other.

We simply didn't know where to begin.

The silence had become too long.

Every passing hour made it even harder to speak
normally.

Sometimes...

I caught myself looking towards her.

She was doing her own work.

Helping her mother.

Walking from one room to another.

Talking to everyone else.

But not to me.

A hundred times...

I wanted to say something.

Even something as simple as,

"What are you doing?"

But every single time...

the words stayed inside my mind.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

I don't know whether she was waiting for me.
Or whether she simply thought everything was
normal.
Even today...
I don't know.
As evening slowly approached...
my departure became real.
My bus was scheduled for the night.
After dinner...
I picked up my bag.
Everyone told me to travel safely.
I smiled.
Said goodbye.
Tried behaving as though nothing was wrong.
Her father offered to drop me at the bus stop.
She came along too.
The three of us got into the vehicle.
Usually...
our rides were never this quiet.
Someone would always start a conversation.
Someone would laugh.
Someone would ask random questions.
That night...
none of those things happened.
The vehicle moved through the familiar Kerala roads.
Streetlights passed one after another.
People were still walking on the footpaths.
Shops were slowly closing.
The city looked alive.
But inside me...
everything felt strangely empty.
I wanted to look at her.
I wanted to say something.

Anything.
But I couldn't.
She also remained quiet.
Looking outside the window.
Neither of us broke the silence.
Within a few minutes...
we reached the bus stand.
I got down with my bag.
Her father helped me keep it near the bus.
He reminded me to call after reaching home.
I nodded.
Then...
there was one final moment.
Aashika slowly walked towards me.
She looked at me.
Smiled very slightly.
And softly said,
"Goodbye..."
I looked back at her.
For a moment...
I forgot every sentence I had been thinking about for
the past five days.
All I managed to say was,
"Goodbye..."
That was it.
No explanation.
No questions.
No "See you soon."
Just one word.
Spoken by two people who had talked for hours every
day...
yet couldn't speak for even one minute when it
mattered the most.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

The conductor called for the passengers.
I climbed into the bus.
Placed my bag above the seat.
Then sat beside the window.
As the engine started...
I looked outside one last time.
Her father stepped back.
Aashika was still standing there.
The bus slowly began moving.
For a few seconds...
I could still see her.
Then...
little by little...
she disappeared behind the lights of the bus stand.
The moment I couldn't see her anymore...
something inside me collapsed.
I turned towards the window.
Pulled the curtain slightly.
And for the first time in my life...
I cried without trying to stop myself.
I wasn't crying because I had left Kerala.
I had left Kerala many times before.
I wasn't crying because she had said goodbye.
She always did.
I was crying because...
for the first time...
I felt as though I was losing the version of us that I
loved the most.
The version where we spoke without thinking.
The version where every conversation came naturally.
The version where silence felt peaceful...
instead of painful.
The bus continued moving through the highway.

Outside...
the lights slowly disappeared.
Inside...
I kept looking at our WhatsApp chat.
Again.
And again.
And again.
I opened the keyboard.
My fingers began typing.
I wanted to ask her...
"Why didn't you talk to me properly?"
"Did I do something wrong?"
"Why did you ignore me?"
"Why did those five days feel so different?"
I read the message.
Then...
I deleted every single word.
I locked my phone.
Kept it beside me.
Looked outside.
Five minutes later...
I picked it up again.
This time...
I typed something completely different.
"Maybe I was the one who became distant."
"Maybe I should apologise first."
"Maybe I shouldn't overthink everything."
"Maybe tomorrow everything will become normal again."
I stared at those words for a long time.
Then...
I deleted them too.
The bus continued its journey.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Everyone around me had already fallen asleep.
Only the sound of the engine remained.
And the light from my phone.
I opened our chat one last time.
Two different messages filled my mind.
One was written by my pain.
The other...
was written by my love.
One wanted answers.
The other wanted peace.
One wanted to speak.
The other wanted to wait.
I knew...
I could send only one.
I took a deep breath.
Closed my eyes.
And made my decision.

**“Every decision creates a future.
Some decisions create two.”**

To Be Continued...

Sometimes love isn't lost.

Sometimes it simply takes a path you never expected.

To my parents,

Thank you for teaching me that every story
deserves to be finished.

To my readers,

Thank you for walking beside Mithran
through every chapter.

To my AYK,

Thanks for everything.

*Experience the ending by
choosing your path.....*

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Can Love Survive?

A) Not Like This

B) Only If It Waits

Written By

MRETYUN JAI B

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

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